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2026

International Relations

Jan 2025 – May 2026 Mains Current Affairs



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TO OUR READERS

Dear Future Administrators,

Welcome to **PMF IAS Mains Magnum 2026 Series 5.0 – International Relations**, a focused compilation designed to strengthen your **conceptual clarity, analytical understanding, and answer-writing readiness** for the UPSC Civil Services Mains Examination.

This volume covers **current affairs from January 2025 to May 2026**, carefully curated from a Mains-oriented perspective with a strong emphasis on India's bilateral and multilateral relations, neighbourhood diplomacy, major global developments, strategic partnerships, geopolitical conflicts, international organisations, global governance reforms, economic diplomacy, regional groupings, maritime security, diaspora engagement, and emerging challenges in world affairs.

The objective of this volume remains simple yet crucial: **maximum revision in minimum time with maximum relevance**. Key topics have been **marked with */**** to support prioritised revision and an efficient preparation strategy. To maintain conciseness and examination utility, the content focuses on major diplomatic developments, summit outcomes, international agreements, strategic initiatives, government policies, contemporary geopolitical trends, and analytical dimensions, while avoiding unnecessary theoretical elaboration.

International Relations forms a crucial component of GS Paper II. UPSC consistently tests candidates on India's engagement with the world, evolving geopolitical realities, regional and global institutions, strategic and economic partnerships, global conflicts, and their implications for India's national interests. A careful analysis of previous year questions indicates that this segment regularly contributes significant weightage **(approximately 50-80 marks)**, making it an important scoring area in the Mains examination.

For enhanced preparation support, aspirants may also refer to **PMF IAS Pathfinder for Mains**, which provides **structured answer-writing frameworks, value addition tools, diplomatic keywords, and multidimensional perspectives** essential for GS Paper II.

We hope this compilation helps you revise faster, retain better, and approach International Relations with clarity, confidence, and examination-oriented precision.

With best wishes,
(Mains Team, PMF IAS)

If you find any discrepancy or wish to share feedback, feel free to reach out. Every suggestion is valued and contributes to the continuous improvement of future editions. Connect with us at **Jha1Mohit@Gmail.Com**

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PMF IAS Mains Magnum 2026 — International Relations

Mains Specific International Relations Current Affairs from January 2025 to May 2026

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Changing Global Order & Foreign Policy

{IR – Diplomacy} India's Diplomacy in a Changing World Order **

❖ **Context (IE):** Amid growing geopolitical instability, shifting global trade patterns, and evolving power dynamics, India is recalibrating its foreign policy.

- PM Modi's visits to **UAE** & **Europe**, alongside India's engagement in BRICS, QUAD, and **Africa outreach**, reflect this evolving strategy.

Changing Nature of World Order

- **Power Shift:** Decline of US unipolarity and rise of China, India, EU and ASEAN, creating a multipolar world order. E.g., G20 influence diversification.
- **Bloc Fragmentation: Rival geopolitical blocs** emerging around the US–China rivalry. E.g., QUAD vs China-led BRI alignments shaping global partnerships.
- **Economic Nationalism:** Countries prioritise domestic industries and supply chain resilience. E.g., China+1 strategy shifting manufacturing to India and Vietnam.
- **Tech Rivalry:** Competition in critical technologies like AI, semiconductors, and space. E.g., the US-China race for semiconductor dominance and AI leadership.

Five Principles Guiding India's Diplomacy

1. **Reciprocity:** India should support trusted partners like the **UAE** that back India on core interests such as **terrorism** and **Kashmir**.
2. **Diversification:** India is expanding **engagement with Europe** for trade, technology, green energy, investments, education, and strategic partnerships.
   ❖ India's trade agreements with the EU and European Free Trade Association reflect Europe's rising strategic significance for India.
3. **Strategic Flexibility:** India should pursue **pragmatic multi-alignment** through forums like BRICS, SCO and the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue without rigid ideological commitments.
4. **Strategic Expansion:** Africa is becoming increasingly important for India due to its markets, youthful population, critical minerals, and geopolitical significance.
5. **Domestic Renewal:** Effective diplomacy requires strong domestic economic reforms, technological advancement, and institutional adaptability at home.

Major Challenges to Indian Diplomacy

➢ **China Challenge:** India faces **border tensions** and **Indo-Pacific competition** from China. E.g., Ladakh standoff and BRI expansion.
➢ **Power Pressure:** India navigates **US–China rivalry** while **maintaining strategic autonomy**. E.g., balancing QUAD participation with ties to Russia.
➢ **Economic Dependence: Trade deficits** and **supply chain** reliance constrain diplomacy. E.g., dependence on Chinese electronics imports.
➢ **Neighbourhood Instability: Regional volatility** affects diplomacy. E.g., political crisis in Sri Lanka and instability in Myanmar.

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Way Forward for India's Diplomacy in a Changing World Order

- ✓ **Strategic Autonomy:** Maintain **flexible multi-alignment** without bloc politics. E.g., India is engaging both QUAD and BRICS simultaneously.
- ✓ **Supply Diversification:** Reduce dependence on single-source imports through the **China+1 strategy**. E.g., shifting electronics manufacturing to Vietnam and India.
- ✓ **Institutional Reform:** Push for global governance reforms. E.g., India's demand for **expansion of UNSC permanent membership**.
- ✓ **Regional Cooperation:** Strengthen **neighbourhood connectivity frameworks**. E.g., **BIMSTEC replacing SAARC** as an active regional platform.
- ✓ **Tech Leadership:** Promote digital and cyber diplomacy. E.g., India's **UPI expansion** into countries such as **Singapore and the UAE**.

{IR – Diplomacy} India's Diplomatic Headwinds in 2026 **

❖ **Context (TH):** After a turbulent 2025 marked by geopolitical shocks and policy surprises, India enters 2026 navigating diplomatic pressures amid global power shifts and regional instability.

Major Diplomatic Headwinds for India

- **US Policy Volatility:** High tariffs, H-1B visa curbs, and sanctions on Russian oil purchases under President Trump's second term have **strained India–US ties**, evident in **25% tariffs and penalties** on India.
- **Russia–Ukraine Fallout:** India's discounted Russian oil imports invited EU–UK sanctions on Nayara Energy, exposing India to secondary sanctions risk despite strategic autonomy claims.
- **Middle East Instability:** Continued Gaza conflict stalled the **India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC)**, undermining India's connectivity and energy-security ambitions.
- **Global Rightward Shift:** Rise of **ultra-right governments in Europe** and elsewhere has weakened multilateral consensus on trade, climate, and migration, affecting India-led coalitions.

Neighbourhood Fragility

- **Pakistan Escalation:** Operation Sindoor, the Pahalgam terror attack, weakened India's diplomatic narrative on terrorism, while **renewed F-16 clearances to Pakistan** raised security concerns.
- **China Dual Challenge:** China's military and diplomatic support to Pakistan during Operation Sindoor and unresolved LAC tensions continue to constrain trust-building.
- **Bangladesh Backlash:** Mob violence and **anti-India sentiment** following the killing of a right-wing leader, combined with political instability, have strained India's influence.
- **Nepal Political Volatility:** Gen-Z–led protests in **2025** toppled the government, reviving nationalist rhetoric and policy uncertainty, which risks slowing India's "Neighbourhood First" policy outcomes.
- **Afghanistan Engagement Dilemma:** India's outreach to the Taliban regime raised concerns over legitimising a regime accused of systemic human rights and women's rights violations.

Opportunities Amid Headwinds

- **Strategic Autonomy Leverage:** India's balanced stance on Russia–Ukraine war enhanced its profile as a **non-aligned mediator**, reflected in continued energy access despite sanctions.

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- **China Engagement Window:** Resumption of Kailash–Mansarovar Yatra, visa restoration, and water-data sharing indicate **calibrated de-escalation** after the 2024 Modi–Xi meet.
- **Global South Leadership:** India's disaster aid to Sri Lanka after **Cyclone Ditwah** ($450 million) reinforced its image as a **first responder** in the **Indian Ocean Region**.
- **Economic Diplomacy:** Rising interest in India as a supply-chain alternative post-China-plus-one strategy strengthens India's bargaining position in trade talks.
- **Net Security Provider:** India's position as a net security provider in the Indian Ocean Region is reinforced through anti-piracy patrols and HADR operations, exemplified by Operation Sankalp.
- **Afghanistan Strategic Opening:** India's calibrated engagement with the Taliban regime, including the 2025 visit of the Afghan Foreign Minister to Delhi, creates space to counter Pakistan's influence.

Key Diplomatic Priorities for 2026

- **Trade Diversification:** Fast-track pending FTAs with EU, US, GCC, ASEAN, building on successful UK–India and **Oman trade agreements** signed in 2025.
- **Neighbourhood Stabilisation:** Deepen economic and infrastructure engagement with **Bhutan**, **Sri Lanka** and the **Maldives**, as seen in high-level visits and aid commitments in 2025.
- **Energy Security:** Maintain **diversified oil sourcing** from Russia, West Asia, Americas, mirroring India's strategy that reduced crude import vulnerability during 2022–25 shocks.
- **Technology Diplomacy:** Leverage hosting of the **AI Summit 2026** to shape global AI norms, following India's G20 Digital Public Infrastructure leadership model.
- **Multilateral Balancing:** Use forums like BRICS, SCO and Quad to hedge against bloc politics, exemplified by India attending SCO despite India–China frictions.
- **Diaspora & Mobility:** Push back against restrictive visa regimes using economic leverage, as attempted through sustained **high-level engagements in Washington**.

{IR – Foreign Policy} Viksit Bharat 2047: Redefining Foreign Policy

❖ **Context (TH):** As **multilateralism erodes** under power politics, India must rethink **strategic autonomy**, build self-strength, diversify trade, and anchor diplomacy in **Viksit Bharat 2047**.

Shifting Global Dynamics

- **UN Leadership:** India historically **led the Global South** at the UN, shaping post-colonial rules. E.g., 1992 climate negotiations.
- **China Influence:** Since 2010, China has headed four major UN agencies and exceeds Western aid, reducing India's institutional sway.
- **US Withdrawal:** The U.S. **exited 31 UN bodies** and rejected **WTO dispute settlements** (2019), **weakening multilateral governance**.
- **Trade Expansion:** **China is the largest trading partner** of 120 countries, backed by the **Belt and Road** and diversified exports.
- **India Challenges:** As a **potential 3rd- largest economy**, India faces a U.S.-dominated global order and must reformulate foreign policy.

Evolution of Strategic Autonomy

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- **Global Leadership:** India's historic Global South leadership gave it outsized influence, but weakened international institutions now limit its voice.
- **Cold War:** Strategic autonomy guided India during the Non-Aligned Movement, but lost relevance after the Soviet Union collapsed in 1991.
- **Policy Choices:** India joined the U.S.-led Quad in 2017 and opted for **Russia's S-400 missiles** over U.S. Patriot systems in 2018.
- **Russia Ties:** India relies on Russia for advanced military technology, a partnership tested by U.S. attempts to influence strategic alignments.
- **Swing State:** With **China's rise**, U.S. analysts view India as a **"swing state"** rather than fully strategically autonomous, reflecting multipolar pressures.

Fragmentation of Multilateral Trade

- **Asymmetric Order:** Global trade is increasingly unequal, driven by **"America First" policies**, unilateral tariffs, and selective market access.
- **Tariff Asymmetry:** Under the India–U.S. framework, India agreed to double industrial imports while the **U.S. retains ~18% tariffs**, unlike **EU FTAs eliminating ~70% tariff lines**.
- **China Leverage:** **China exploited WTO rules** to emerge as a **manufacturing hub** and is now the top trading partner for over 120 countries.
- **Growth Pressures:** India faces constrained growth space amid intensifying U.S.–China rivalry and reduced multilateral safeguards.
- **Supply Realignment:** **Friend-shoring**, Quad, AUKUS, and tech controls signal a shift from **WTO-centric multilateralism** to minilateral power blocs.

India's Adaptive Foreign Policy

- **Norm-to-Power Shift:** The erosion of **UN-centric multilateralism** compels India to move from **rule-shaping leadership to pragmatic power-based diplomacy**.
- **Autonomy Recast:** Strategic autonomy transforms into **issue-based alignments**, balancing the Quad, Russia ties, and China engagement to protect national interests.
- **Trade Realignment:** **Asymmetric global trade** and **U.S.–China rivalry** force India to **diversify markets**, pursue FTAs, and embed trade diplomacy within foreign policy.
- **Developmental Diplomacy:** Foreign policy increasingly serves domestic goals, technology access, industrial capacity, and growth, anchored in the vision of **Viksit Bharat 2047**.

India's Pathways to Global Leadership

- ✓ **Youth Advantage:** India's young population, exemplified by nearly half of Silicon Valley's workforce, can drive a cyber and AI superpower.
- ✓ **Policy Shift:** Foreign policy must evolve from **'strategic autonomy' to Viksit Bharat 2047**, integrating trade and technology diplomacy. E.g., Quad and S-400.
- ✓ **Endogenous Capability:** India should quietly **develop domestic industrial** and **technological strength**, similar to the early 20th-century U.S. and China. E.g., Make in India.
- ✓ **Trade Diversification:** **Expand exports and FTAs with Asia and Africa** to reduce U.S. dependence and enhance economic resilience. E.g., ASEAN and AfCFTA.
- ✓ **Regional Incentives:** **Treat Pakistan as a policy partner** using economic tools like water-sharing, IP pipeline, and trade agreements. E.g., Kashmir water, Iran-Pakistan-India pipeline.

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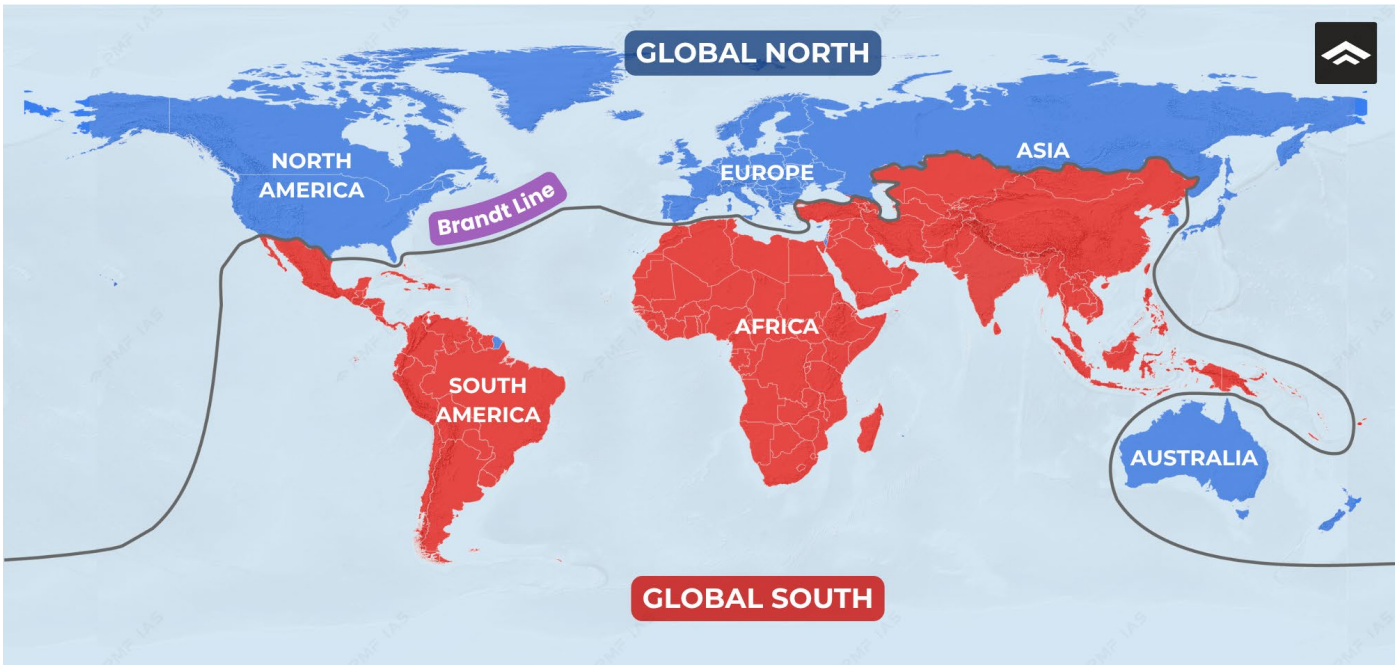
✓ **BRICS Leadership:** **Reposition BRICS as an economic cooperation bloc** and integrate digital currencies for smoother cross-border trade and remittances. E.g., digital rupee and cross-border payments.

{IR – Groupings} India and the Global South *

❖ **Context (IE):** PM Modi visited **Ghana**, **Trinidad** & **Tobago**, and **Argentina** on his way to the **BRICS Leaders' Summit** in **Brazil**, reaffirming India's strategic focus on the **Global South.**

About the Global South

- The Global South refers to **economically developing countries** mainly in Asia, Africa, Latin America, and Oceania with histories of colonial exploitation.
- **Common Challenges:** The group faces shared vulnerabilities in **climate impact,** debt burden, digital divide, and access to healthcare.



Significance of the Global South

- The Global South comprises over **80%** of the **world's population** and a rising middle class.
- **Geoeconomic Leverage:** BRICS+ and South–South trade has amplified **economic cooperation** and alternative development models.
- **Multilateral Pressure:** The Global South's collective efforts have pushed for fairer climate finance, vaccine equity, and WTO reforms.
- **Strategic Autonomy:** It challenges Western dominance and encourages **multipolarity** through forums like the **G77, NAM,** and **IBSA.**

Challenges to India's Role in the Global South

➢ **Humanitarian Gaps:** India's **limited aid** to Gaza and Sudan sparked criticism from Africa and West Asia.
➢ **UNESCO Defeat:** India lost the **UNESCO Vice-Chair vote in 2023**, reflecting discontent over India's muted stance on Gaza.

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- **Perception Shift:** Growing alignment with Western powers has weakened India's image as an independent leader in the Global South.
- **BRICS Discord:** The BRICS expansion has created divisions, with no consensus on UNSC reform, thereby weakening India's reform agenda.
- **Manufacturing Doubts:** The non-renewal of India's ₹1.9 lakh crore PLI scheme raised concerns about its industrial reliability.

India's Attempt to Reconcile the Global South

- ✓ **Balanced Diplomacy:** India reiterated support for a **two-state solution** in Palestine while maintaining strategic neutrality.
- ✓ **Voice Amplification:** PM Modi's speeches in the G7 and G20 outreach platforms reaffirmed India's Global South commitment.
- ✓ **BRICS Advocacy:** India pushed for an **equitable development** focus within BRICS and highlighted the AU's G20 inclusion.
- ✓ **Institutional Reform Push:** India renewed calls for **UNSC restructuring** and advocated Global South inclusion in global finance.
- ✓ **Development Cooperation**: India has extended **concessional credit**, tech sharing (like **UPI, Co-WIN**), and **ITEC training** to partner nations.
- ✓ **Tech Partnerships:** India offered DPI solutions, AI collaboration, and digital governance models to partner countries.
- ✓ **Cultural Diplomacy:** PM's diaspora outreach in Argentina and Caribbean states boosted **people-to-people linkages.**

{IR – Groupings} Rise of Minilateralism *

- ❖ **Context (ET):** Multilateralism, marked by **broad-based cooperation** through institutions like the UN, WTO, and WHO, has long anchored global governance. However, rising inefficiencies, institutional deadlocks, and power imbalances have weakened its effectiveness.
- This has led to minilateralism, small, **interest-based coalitions** of like-minded countries focused on specific, actionable goals. As **EAM S. Jaishankar** aptly noted: "*Smaller groups of nations that are effective and focused may be better suited to today's fragmented world.*"

Understanding Multilateralism and Minilateralism

Multilateralism

- A formal, **rules-based cooperation** among **three or more countries**, often under the framework of global institutions. It promotes universal norms & consensus-based decision-making on international issues.
- **Example:** United Nations (UN), World Trade Organisation (WTO), International Monetary Fund (IMF), World Bank, Paris Climate Agreement & North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO).

Minilateralism

- A flexible, informal, and **issue-specific cooperation** among a **limited number of states** based on shared interests, strategic priorities, or capabilities, aiming for quick, effective, and focused outcomes.
- **Example:** QUAD (India, US, Japan, Australia), AUKUS (Australia, UK, US), International Solar Alliance (ISA), I2U2 (India, Israel, UAE, USA).

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Key Challenges to Traditional Multilateralism

- **Erosion of Trust and Institutional Gridlock:** Increasing unilateralism and blocked reforms **weaken multilateral** institutions. E.g. U.S. blocking WTO Appellate Body appointments.
- **Geopolitical Rivalries and Polarisation:** Conflicting interests and **bloc politics** obstruct global consensus. E.g. Russia vetoing UNSC resolutions; U.S.-China friction in UN bodies.
- **Global South Marginalisation:** Inadequate representation reduces the legitimacy of global platforms. E.g. India and the African Union's demand for UNSC reform.
- **Ineffective Crisis Response:** Delayed and **unequal responses** to transnational crises expose systemic weaknesses. E.g. Unequal vaccine access during COVID-19.
- **Funding and Operational Constraints:** Resource limitations impact **institutional efficiency**. E.g. WHO's over-dependence on voluntary contributions.

Reasons for the Rise of Minilateralism

- **Quick Decision-Making:** Smaller coalitions can **act swiftly** and adapt to changing global dynamics. E.g. Quad's rapid response to Indo-Pacific security.
- **Issue-Based Cooperation:** Minilateralism enables focused collaboration on specific priorities with measurable outcomes. E.g., **AUKUS** (defence) and **I2U2** (food security, clean energy).
- **Bypassing Multilateral Gridlock:** Minilateral frameworks **avoid the delays** and deadlocks of larger institutions, enabling faster resolutions. E.g. USMCA concluded faster than WTO trade reforms.
- **Strategic Alignment:** Minilateralism strengthens regional security, economic cooperation, and global governance through shared interests. E.g., **Quad's maritime security**.
- **Complementary to Multilateralism:** Minilateral initiatives test **broader multilateral agreements**, enabling scalability. E.g., G20 influences the Paris Climate Agreement.

Minilateralism for India

Challenges of Minilateralism for India	Opportunities of Minilateralism for India
Disruption of Global Unity: Narrow, issue-based coalitions may weaken inclusive multilateral bodies such as the UN and WTO.	**Enhanced Strategic Positioning:** Coalitions such as the Quad strengthen India's position in Indo-Pacific security.
Risk of Strategic Isolation: Exclusion from key groups, such as AUKUS, limits India's global influence.	**Leadership in Niche Areas:** India spearheads global initiatives in sectors such as solar energy through ISA.
Tension in Foreign Relations: Aligning with one bloc may strain relations with others (e.g., U.S.-Russia dynamics).	**Agile and Focused Cooperation:** Smaller groups facilitate quicker, issue-specific collaboration.
Reduced Voice in Global Norm-Setting: India may be sidelined in shaping the rules established by exclusive groupings.	**Platform for Strategic Autonomy:** India can engage selectively while upholding non-alignment.
Diplomatic Overstretch: Overlapping alliances complicate foreign policy and stretch diplomatic resources.	**Bridge Between Global North and South:** India can mediate and represent the interests of developing nations.

Limitations of Minilateralism

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- **Lack of Inclusivity:** Minilateral groups **often exclude** smaller or less powerful nations, sidelining the voices of the Global South.
- **Fragmentation of Global Governance:** Overlapping minilaterals can **cause policy incoherence** & weaken multilateral institutions. Digital frameworks from different blocs may conflict with UN efforts.
- **Weak Enforcement Mechanisms:** Minilateral agreements are often **informal** and **voluntary**, lacking vigorous enforcement or dispute resolution mechanisms.
- **Short-Term Strategic Focus:** Groupings often form around **immediate geopolitical** or **economic interests,** potentially neglecting long-term global public goods. For example, security-centric alliances like AUKUS may overlook development or climate justice.
- **Risk of Geopolitical Polarisation:** Minilateralism can **reinforce bloc politics**, intensifying rivalry and eroding trust in the global system. Counter-blocs in response to the Quad or AUKUS may deepen divides.

Need for Co-existence of Minilateralism and Multilateralism

- **Complementary Roles:** Minilateralism provides **speed**, **flexibility**, and **issue-based cooperation**, while multilateralism guarantees legitimacy, inclusiveness, and global norm-setting.
- **Bridging Institutional Gaps:** Where **multilateral frameworks stall** (E.g., WTO deadlock), minilateral groups can serve as experimental platforms or interim solutions.
- **Scalable Solutions:** Successful minilateral initiatives **can expand** into broader multilateral agreements (E.g., GATT evolved into WTO).
- **Broad Consensus:** Climate change, pandemics, and cybercrime require **inclusive multilateral frameworks** for sustainable, long-term solutions.
- **Avoiding Fragmentation:** Exclusive reliance on minilateralism can **foster geopolitical blocs**, undermining global cooperation.

{IR – Diplomacy} Small Tables Diplomacy

❖ **Context (TH):** India's **"Small Tables Diplomacy"** leverages informal, flexible forums to fill global leadership gaps. Engaging blocs like the EU at Republic Day 2026 signals a shift from bilateral to coalition-focused diplomacy.

India's Small Tables Diplomacy in 2026

- **Meaning:** A foreign policy approach where countries work through **small**, **flexible**, **purpose-driven coalitions** to achieve faster decisions & shape rules, rather than relying on large **consensus-based forums**.

India–EU Engagement

- **FTA Beyond Tariffs:** **India–EU Free Trade Agreement** will shape market access via data rules, competition norms, and green standards, not just customs duties.
- **Standards Pressure:** **EU sustainability rules (CBAM)** can increase the burden on export-heavy sectors like textiles, chemicals, and auto components.
- **Window Timing:** EU wants to cut dependence on China and hedge US unpredictability; Delhi must act fast before political-economic priorities shift.

India and BRICS

- **India's Chair Opportunity:** India can push BRICS toward execution using **New Development Bank (NDB)** guarantees & practical toolkits to convert communiqués into projects.
- **Diluted Cohesion:** BRICS expansion increases reach but reduces clarity as members pursue different goals, making consensus and delivery harder.

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- **Signalling Risk:** Turning BRICS into **anti-West rhetoric or de-dollarisation** posturing can trigger US tariff retaliation, hurting India's capital, tech, and trade goals.

India and Quad

- **Core Deliverables:** Focus on maritime domain awareness, resilient ports, cyber resilience, disaster response, where capacity gaps are high.
- **India's Advantage:** India can offer **rapid-retaskable HADR capabilities** (Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief) that build trust without diplomatic drama.
- **US Factor:** Trade frictions involving Washington can spill into Quad cohesion, so delivery needs issue separation of trade and security.

Structural Stress in Multilateralism

- **Consensus Burden:** Large memberships mean **lowest-common-denominator outcomes**; strong decisions get diluted into vague statements, especially in the United Nations (UN).
- **Domestic Politics Spillover:** G20 agendas increasingly reflect domestic contestations, blocking continuity and reducing global coordination capacity.
- **Agenda Polarisation:** **Competing narratives** (Ukraine, trade wars, tech controls) crowd out Global South priorities, weakening legitimacy and inclusiveness.
- **Institutional Rigidity:** **Fixed rules and veto powers**, especially in the UNSC, prevent timely reform and crisis response.
- **Legitimacy Deficit:** **Under-representation of emerging economies** in global institutions erodes trust, prompting countries to seek alternative minilateral platforms.

Rationale Behind the Shift to Small Tables Diplomacy for India

- **Faster Outcomes:** Smaller coalitions avoid **consensus paralysis**, allowing India to push time-bound deliverables instead of vague declarations.
- **Rule-Shaping Space:** India can influence standards, norms, and governance rules (AI, digital, climate, supply chains) before they get locked by major powers.
- **Global Leadership Gap:** In **"white spaces"** where no power can convene credibly, India can act as a trusted bridge-builder between North and South.
- **Economic Payoff:** Coalitions with **EU/Japan/ASEAN** can diversify markets and value chains, helping India de-risk trade, tech, and investment flows.
- **Coalition of the Willing:** India can build aligned groups on specific priorities (critical minerals, clean energy, semiconductors), ensuring implementation is bigger than symbolism.

Challenges of Small Tables Diplomacy for India

- **Coalition Instability:** **BRICS expansion** (**2024**) added members with divergent interests, **slowing consensus and diluting focus** on development finance.
- **Diplomatic Overstretch:** India simultaneously engages in Quad, BRICS, SCO, IPEF, and EU talks, stretching limited trade, tech, and climate negotiators.
- **Great Power Spillover:** Ukraine war divisions within G20 and BRICS show how geopolitical rivalries can **paralyse economic agendas**.
- **Economic Vulnerability:** EU's CBAM could **raise compliance costs** for Indian steel, cement, and chemicals exports from 2026.

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➢ **Rule-Setting Asymmetry:** OECD-driven data, AI, and green standards often emerge before Indian MSMEs are ready for compliance.

Way Forward

✓ **Strategic Prioritisation:** Focus on **high-impact coalitions** EU (trade & standards), Quad (security & HADR), BRICS (development finance).
✓ **Issue Separation:** Maintain **Quad maritime cooperation** despite India–US trade disputes over digital taxes and market access.
✓ **Delivery Mechanisms:** **Use New Development Bank** guarantees to fast-track infrastructure and clean energy projects in the Global South.
✓ **Standards Readiness:** Align domestic schemes like PLI and the National Green Hydrogen Mission with EU sustainability benchmarks.
✓ **Bridge Leadership:** Position India as a **norm-translator** balancing EU climate ambition with Global South equity at COP negotiations.

{IR – Issues} Rules-Based Order

❖ **Context (TOI):** At the WEF, Davos, Canadian PM said the **post-WWII "rules-based order"** has been a partial fiction, where strong states exempt themselves, and the world is in a "rupture, not a transition.

Why are Rules-Based Orders Under Strain?

- **Selective Rules:** International rules are enforced unevenly, prioritising strategic interests over universal norms. E.g., **Iraq War vs Gaza/Ukraine debates**
- **Hegemonic Bargain:** The US-led order endured as America provided maritime security and dollar-based global financial stability.
- **Weaponised Interdependence:** Trade, finance, and supply chains increasingly serve as geopolitical coercion tools. E.g., **Trump-era tariff threats**.
- **Alliance Anxiety:** Unilateral actions strain alliance cohesion, weakening trust among traditional security partners. E.g., Greenland proposal and NATO.

Global Implications

- **Shift to Power:** Great powers increasingly prioritise strategic interests over international norms, weakening the rules-based global order.
- **Fragmented Multilateralism:** Ineffective global institutions accelerate reliance on flexible minilateral coalitions like IPEF & QUAD.
- **Transactional Alliances:** Strategic partnerships increasingly prioritise **issue-based interests** and **reciprocal gains** over shared democratic values and commitments.

Implications for India

- **Strategic Autonomy Test:** India will face higher pressure to **"choose sides"** as US–China competition expands into tech, trade and finance.
- **Trade Weaponisation Risk:** Tariffs, sanctions and export controls can hit India even without direct conflict, affecting overall growth and jobs.

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- **Normative Space Opening:** As the credibility of rules weakens, India can push for **fairer representation & rule reform**, especially for Global South priorities.

Way Forward for India

- ✓ **Strategic Autonomy:** Pursue calibrated multi-alignment to balance **U.S.–China** rivalry while safeguarding national interests.
- ✓ **Economic Resilience:** Strengthen **Atmanirbhar Bharat** to reduce supply-chain vulnerabilities and external economic coercion.
- ✓ **Global South:** Champion **UNSC** and **WTO** reforms through stronger Global South leadership and coalition-building.
- ✓ **Minilateralism:** Deepen engagement with **QUAD** and **IPEF** to secure strategic and economic interests.
- ✓ **Rules-Based Order:** Advocate an inclusive global order with consistent and non-selective enforcement of international law.

{IR – Foreign Policy} Hyper-Nationalism

❖ **Context (IE):** India's foreign policy is increasingly influenced by hyper-nationalism & image management. This risks undermining strategic realism, critical self-reflection, & informed long-term decision-making.

Understanding Hyper-Nationalism – Meaning and Features

- **Meaning:** **Hyper-nationalism** refers to **an excessive form of nationalism** that prioritises national pride over rational foreign policy.
- **Key Features:**
  - ❖ **Suppresses Dissent:** Critics are labelled anti-national, **limiting debate** on **strategic decisions**.
  - ❖ **Blocks Scrutiny:** Internal questioning of foreign policy is avoided to preserve the **national image**.
  - ❖ **Creates Adversaries:** Neighbouring states are **framed as threats** to foster public unity.
  - ❖ **Distorts Ethics:** Proxy violence is justified, weakening moral standards in external conflicts.

Benefits of Hyper-Nationalism in a Globalised World

- **Partnerships:** Assertive nationalism strengthens defence & technology cooperation with major powers.
- **Global Standing:** Hyper-nationalism enhances India's influence in the **G20** and **Quad** platforms.
- **Policy Stability:** Nationalist cohesion strengthens investor confidence through predictable policy continuity.
- **National Unity:** External threats foster unity, strengthening India's international negotiating position.
- **Strategic Autonomy:** Firm nationalism reduces external dependence, reinforcing independent foreign policy.

Challenges of Hyper-Nationalism in a Globalised World

- ➢ **Diplomatic Rigidity:** Nationalist framing restricts flexibility, evident in India's cautious Ukraine stance.
- ➢ **Regional Unease:** Assertive Indo-Pacific posture unsettles ASEAN partners despite shared strategic interests.
- ➢ **Moral Credibility:** Selective silence on Myanmar weakens India's credibility in multilateral forums.
- ➢ **Strategic Realism:** Hyper-nationalism limits pragmatic engagement despite potential diplomatic opportunities.
- ➢ **Conflict Risks:** Nationalist pressures heighten escalation risks during Pakistan and China standoffs.

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Trends of Hyper-Nationalism in India's Foreign Policy

- **Nationalist Projection:** India's **limited international support** after Operation Sindoor reflected a foreign policy prioritising **nationalist image** over coalition-building.
- **Neighbourhood Backlash:** The "#BoycottMaldives" campaign, driven by online outrage, demonstrated how **hyper nationalist** sentiment strained diplomatic ties with a neighbouring state.
- **Selective Silence:** India's silence during the Gaza conflict signalled a shift from **values-based diplomacy** to **alliance-driven selectivity**, weakening its normative credibility in the Global South.

Way Forward for India's Foreign Policy

- ✓ **Diplomatic Flexibility:** India must retain **diplomatic flexibility**, as Turkey does through multi-vector foreign policy.
- ✓ **Regional Trust:** India must rebuild regional trust through steady diplomacy, following Indonesia's ASEAN approach.
- ✓ **Policy Consistency:** India should take consistent global positions, as Norway does, to uphold credibility.
- ✓ **Strategic Realism:** India should adopt strategic realism like **Vietnam**, balancing interests without ideological overreach.
- ✓ **Conflict De-escalation:** India should adopt **de-escalation protocols**, as seen in China–ASEAN conflict management frameworks.

{IR – Changing Global Order & Foreign Policy – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. In an era of weakening multilateral institutions and rising geopolitical fragmentation, minilateral platforms are gaining prominence. Analyse how India can leverage 'small table diplomacy' to enhance its global influence and secure strategic and economic interests. Suggest institutional and policy measures to deepen the effectiveness of this approach. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about small-table diplomacy, and mention an example.
- **Body:** Write how India can leverage 'small table diplomacy' to enhance its global influence and secure strategic and economic interests, mention challenges, and suggest institutional and policy measures to deepen the effectiveness of this approach.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on a coordinated and cooperative approach to effectively implement Small Table Diplomacy.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- **Small table diplomacy** is the use of flexible, purpose-driven coalitions for faster, targeted decision-making. E.g., India leverages the **Quad & BRICS** to advance strategic, economic, & development goals.

How India Can Leverage Small Table Diplomacy

- **Quick Decisions:** Smaller coalitions **enable actionable**, **time-bound outcomes**, avoiding diluted consensus like Quad, EU, or selected BRICS groups.

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- **Norm Leadership:** Shape emerging global standards in AI, data, climate, and trade before major powers dominate.
- **Market Diversification:** Partner with the **EU**, **Japan**, and **ASEAN** to reduce dependency and de-risk trade and investments.
- **Security Gains:** Strengthen **maritime**, **cyber**, and **disaster response capabilities** while maintaining strategic autonomy

Challenges

- **Coalition Instability:** **Divergent interests** in expanded BRICS or other platforms can slow consensus.
- **Diplomatic Overstretch:** Engagement across Quad, BRICS, SCO, EU, and IPEF may strain resources.
- **Great Power Spillover:** **Geopolitical rivalries** (US-China, Russia-West) can paralyse economic or security agendas.
- **Economic Vulnerabilities:** **Compliance costs** from EU sustainability rules (CBAM) and OECD standards.

Measures to Deepen the Effectiveness of This Approach.

- ✓ **Priority Focus:** **Concentrate on high-impact platforms** like EU (trade), Quad (security), and BRICS (development finance).
- ✓ **Issue Separation:** Keep **security cooperation** independent of **trade disputes**. E.g., India–US digital tensions.
- ✓ **Fast Delivery:** Use **NDB's guarantees** and **dedicated task forces** to expedite infrastructure and clean energy projects.
- ✓ **Standards Alignment:** Sync domestic schemes like PLI and Green Hydrogen Mission with global compliance norms.

Conclusion

- Small table diplomacy lets India **shape norms** and **bridge global divides** via Quad and BRICS. With **strategy** and **coordination**, it converts partnerships into real **economic and strategic gains**.

Q. To what extent is India's foreign policy being shaped by domestic political narratives rather than pragmatic geopolitical calculations? Discuss (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write brief meaning of hyper-nationalism and mention it impact as well.
- **Body:** Write how India's foreign policy being shaped by domestic political narratives and pragmatic geopolitical calculations.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on balanced approach to safeguard long-term national and global interests.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- Hyper-nationalism is an excessive form of nationalism that prioritises **national pride over rational foreign policy**, which undermines national interest.

Influence of Domestic Political Narratives

- **Nationalism over Realism:** Limited international support after **Operation Sindoor** reflected a foreign policy prioritising nationalism over coalition-building.
- **Affect Neighbourhood:** **Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA)** sparked protests in Bangladesh.

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- **Selective Silence:** India's silence during the **Gaza conflict** signalled a shift from realism to alliance-driven selectivity.
- **Neighbourhood Backlash:** The **"#BoycottMaldives" campaign**, driven by online outrage, strained diplomatic ties

Pragmatic Geopolitical Calculations Still at Play

- **Strategic Neutrality:** India's balanced position on the **Russia-Ukraine war** enabled discounted oil imports from Russia.
- **Multi-Alignment:** Active participation in **QUAD**, **BRICS**, and **SCO** highlights realism.
- **Realignment Standoff:** After the **Galwan clash**, India deepened defence ties with Western partners.
- **Economic Realism:** Engagements in **FTAs** (**UK**, **EU**) and semiconductor partnerships with the US.

Conclusion

- India's foreign policy must **balance domestic political** narratives with strategic realism to safeguard long-term national and global interests.

Q. "India's aspiration for Viksit Bharat 2047 unfolds amid eroding multilateralism and intensifying US–China rivalry." Critically examine how this evolving global order is reshaping India's leadership of the Global South and recalibrating its strategic autonomy. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the evolving global order.
- **Body:** Write how the evolving global order is reshaping India's leadership of the Global South, recalibrating its strategic autonomy, and the way forward.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on self-reliance and innovation to reshape India's Global South leadership.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- India's path to **Viksit Bharat 2047** faces a **weakening multilateral order** & **rising U.S.–China rivalry**, challenging its Global South leadership. Strategic autonomy now demands balancing technology, trade, & security.

Reshaping India's Global South Leadership

- **Decline of UN Influence:** India's agenda-setting is constrained as **UN and WTO mechanisms weaken**. E.g., WTO dispute settlement has been blocked since 2019.
- **China's Challenge:** China leads **four UN agencies** and invests **~$150B via Belt and Road**, limiting India's sway in the Global South.
- **Pragmatic Diplomacy:** India strengthens ties through **Vaccine Maitri** and tech aid, sending 1.2 million COVID-19 doses abroad.
- **Minilateral Coalitions:** India leverages BRICS, G20, and IBSA to maintain influence amid eroding multilateralism.

Recalibrating Strategic Autonomy

- **From non-alignment to Multi-alignment:** India **balances Quad membership**, **Russia S-400 deal** ($5.5B), and cautious China engagement to retain strategic flexibility.
- **Economic Statecraft:** **Diversifying FTAs** with ASEAN, EU, Africa, and boosting **Make in India** reduces dependence on a single power.

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- **Issue-based Autonomy:** Foreign policy prioritises tech (AI, semiconductors), security, and trade considerations over ideological commitments.
- **Capability-driven Autonomy:** India **builds endogenous strength**, **70% defense indigenization**, and is the **third-largest drone producer** to secure strategic independence.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Domestic Capability: Strengthen India's manufacturing**, **AI**, **semiconductor**, and **defence sectors** to reduce foreign dependence.
- ✓ **Trade Diversification: Expand FTAs** with Asia, Africa, and Latin America to mitigate U.S.–China reliance.
- ✓ **Development Diplomacy:** Use vaccines, technology transfer, and climate initiatives to reinforce **Global South leadership**.
- ✓ **Strategic Alignment: Balance Quad**, **BRICS**, **Russia**, and **China ties** to protect autonomy and national interests.

Conclusion

- India's true power comes from self-reliance and innovation; by **building domestic capabilities & pragmatic diplomacy**, it can lead the Global South and safeguard strategic autonomy in a **multipolar world**.

Q. In an era of weakening multilateral institutions and rising geopolitical fragmentation, minilateral platforms are gaining prominence. Analyse how India can leverage 'small table diplomacy' to enhance its global influence and secure strategic and economic interests. Suggest institutional and policy measures to deepen the effectiveness of this approach. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

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- **Small table diplomacy** is the use of flexible, purpose-driven coalitions for faster, targeted decision-making. For example, India leverages the **Quad and BRICS** to advance strategic, economic, & development goals.

How India Can Leverage Small Table Diplomacy

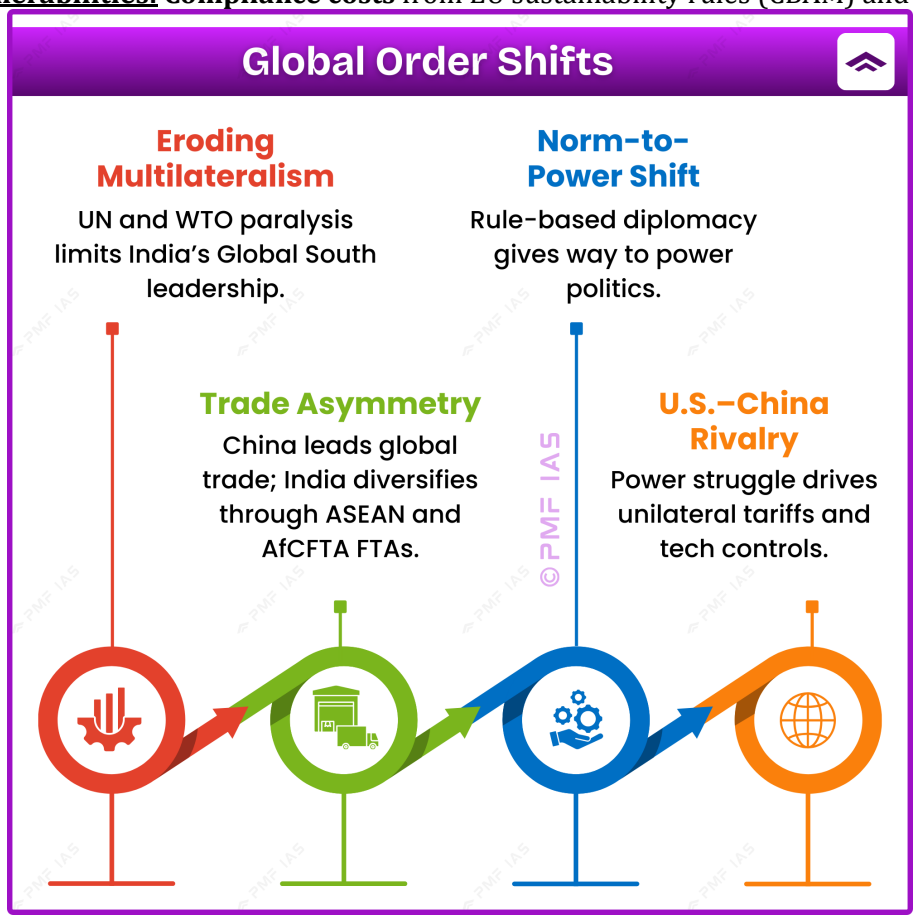
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- **Norm Leadership:** Shape emerging global standards in AI, data, climate, and trade before major powers dominate.
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Challenges

- **Coalition Instability:** **Divergent interests** in expanded BRICS or other platforms can slow consensus.
- **Diplomatic Overstretch:** Engagement across Quad, BRICS, SCO, EU, and IPEF may strain resources.
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Measures to Deepen the Effectiveness of This Approach.

- ✓ **Priority Focus:** **Concentrate on high-impact platforms** like EU (trade), Quad (security), and BRICS (development finance).
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Strategic Diplomacy

{IR – Diplomacy} India's Critical Minerals Diplomacy **

❖ **Context (TH):** India's clean-energy transition increasingly depends on imported critical minerals, and tightening export controls have made supply security a strategic priority.

⇨ *A **critical mineral** is a **metallic or non-metallic element** crucial for modern technologies, economies, and national security, with the potential risk of disruptions to its supply chains.*

Significance of Minerals Diplomacy for India

- **Import Dependence:** India is **100% import-dependent** for key minerals like lithium, cobalt and nickel, making energy transition supply chains externally vulnerable.
- **China Dominance:** China controls about **81% of the processing capacity** of key critical minerals, turning minerals into a **geopolitical choke point**, not just a trade item.
- **Downstream Supply Vulnerability:** In 2024–25, India imported **53,000+ tonnes** of rare earth magnets, with **over 90%** sourced from China, risking disruption for EVs, wind turbines and electronics.

India's Region-Wise Critical Mineral Partnership Assessment

Australia

- **Reliable Upstream Partner:** Australia offers stable politics and large reserves, making it a credible long-term supplier anchor for India's transition needs.
- **Investment Track:** Under the **India-Australia Critical Minerals Investment Partnership** (**2022**), five target projects were identified for possible investment in lithium and cobalt.

Japan

- **Resilience Template:** Japan's response to rare earth disruption focused on diversification, stockpiling, recycling and long-term R&D rather than reactive buying.
- **Upgraded Cooperation:** Partnership is expanding towards **joint extraction/processing** and possible **stockpiling arrangements**, including in third countries.

Africa

- **High Potential:** Africa's mineral abundance and rising demand for local value addition offer long-run opportunities beyond transactional ore extraction.
- **India's Push:** Deals with **Namibia** (lithium, rare earths, uranium) and talks in **Zambia** (copper, cobalt).

United States

- **Dialogue Heavy:** Friend-shoring has struggled to move beyond discussions, as tariffs, trade rules and policy volatility reduce long-term reliability.
- **Key Frameworks:** TRUST Initiative and **Strategic Minerals Recovery Initiative** propose joint work on rare-earth processing and recycling tech.

European Union (EU)

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- **Alignment Need:** India must align with lifecycle environmental norms to plug into EU standards.
- **Key Platforms:** Critical Raw Materials Act & **European Battery Alliance** offer a structured supply-chain.

West Asia (Gulf)

- **Midstream Potential:** **UAE** and **Saudi Arabia** are building battery materials and refining capacity, offering processing partnerships for mineral ores.
- **Gap:** Institutional depth remains limited, so India needs structured rather than ad-hoc arrangements.

Russia

- **Partnership:** Russia has sizeable reserves and scientific linkages with India, offering diversification.
- **Constraints:** Sanctions, financing and logistics reduce reliability, making Russia a **hedge partner**.

Latin America

- **New Frontier:** **Argentina**, **Chile**, **Peru** and **Brazil** are becoming central to global rare earth strategies.
- **Early Stage:** KABIL signed a ₹200 crore exploration agreement in **Argentina** (**Catamarca** lithium blocks).

Canada

- **Re-emerging Partner:** Canada has strong reserves of nickel, cobalt, copper and rare earths and could become a stable partner post ties restoration.
- **Risk Factor:** Political stability in bilateral relations is key, else diplomacy could remain underutilised.

Challenges in India's Minerals Diplomacy

- **Import Dependence:** India remains **100% import-dependent** on lithium, cobalt, and nickel, exposing clean-energy supply chains to external shocks.
- **China Dominance:** China controls **81% of critical mineral processing** and supplies **90%+ of India's rare-earth magnets**, creating strategic vulnerabilities.
- **Geopolitical Risks:** Sanctions, trade restrictions, export controls, and policy uncertainties disrupt reliable access to critical mineral supply chains.
- **Domestic Constraints:** Limited refining, processing, and recycling capacity and fragmented institutional coordination hinder India's mineral security and value-chain integration.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Processing Capacity:** Prioritise domestic refining and separation to reduce exposure to external choke-points; E.g., build **REE magnet and lithium refining clusters** with assured offtake.
- ✓ **Value-Chain Deals:** Shift from MoUs to bankable projects with equity, technology and offtake terms; E.g., **mining-to-processing packages** instead of extraction-only contracts.
- ✓ **Recycling Scale:** Build **urban mining** capacity for batteries and magnets to reduce import dependence.
- ✓ **Institutional Clarity:** Create a single strategic command for minerals diplomacy & domestic mining policy integration; E.g., a **Critical Minerals Board** linking MEA, Mines, Commerce, and industry.

{IR – Diplomacy} India's Buddhist Diplomacy

- **Context (IE):** Despite hosting **7 of 8 Ashtamahasthanas**, India accounts for only **~6% of Foreign Tourist Arrivals** from Buddhist tourism.

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⇨ ***Ashtamahasthanas:*** *Bodh Gaya (Enlightenment), Sarnath (First Sermon), Kushinagar (Parinirvana), Rajgir, Vaishali, Shravasti, Sankasya, and* ***Lumbini*** *(Birthplace; in* ***Nepal****).*

Role of Buddhism in India's Soft Power Diplomacy

- **Soft Balancing:** India's control over Himalayan Buddhist centres like **Tawang and the Dalai Lama's** presence counterbalance China's influence in Asian Buddhist affairs.
- **Relic Diplomacy:** The country loans sacred relics (e.g., Piprahwa relics) to build cultural goodwill.
- **Knowledge Diplomacy:** Revival of Nalanda University aims to restore India as a global Buddhist learning hub.
- **Institutional Multilateralism:** New Delhi-based **International Buddhist Confederation** positions India as a key facilitator of the Pan-Asian Buddhist Agenda.
- **Act East Link:** Shared civilisational values of **'Peace and Coexistence'** make Buddhism a foundational cultural layer of the Act East Policy.

Challenges in Realising Full Potential

➢ **Limited Global Projection:** India under-leverages Buddhism compared to Thailand, Sri Lanka, and Japan.
➢ **Symbolic vs Substantive Gap:** Efforts often remain **event-based (relic exhibitions)** rather than sustained engagement.
➢ **Fragmented Branding:** Sites treated as isolated tourist destinations rather than a **civilisational circuit**.

Govt Initiatives

- **Targeted Connectivity: Buddhist Circuit Scheme** in the North-East builds physical infrastructure and interpretation centres to boost tourism.
- **Community Upliftment:** Buddhist Development Plan under PMJVK establishes community halls, health facilities, and green energy projects in the Himalayan and Northeast Buddhist regions.
- **Circuit Development:** Swadesh Darshan 2.0 develops tourist infrastructure, facilities, wayside amenities, and experience centres at major Buddhist pilgrimage sites.

Way Forward

✓ **Institutional Mechanism:** Establish a **Buddhist Heritage and Pilgrimage Development Authority** to coordinate continuous conservation, fast-track transport permits, and unified destination branding.
✓ **Transit Modernisation:** Build international airport ecosystems at hubs like **Gaya** and integrate fast-track specialised e-visas to facilitate repeat charter operations.
✓ **Knowledge Diplomacy:** Fund academic fellowships in **Pali** and **Buddhist** studies to re-establish India's ancient legacy.

Read More> *India displaying Lord Buddha relics in Thailand*

{IR – Diplomacy} Soft Power *

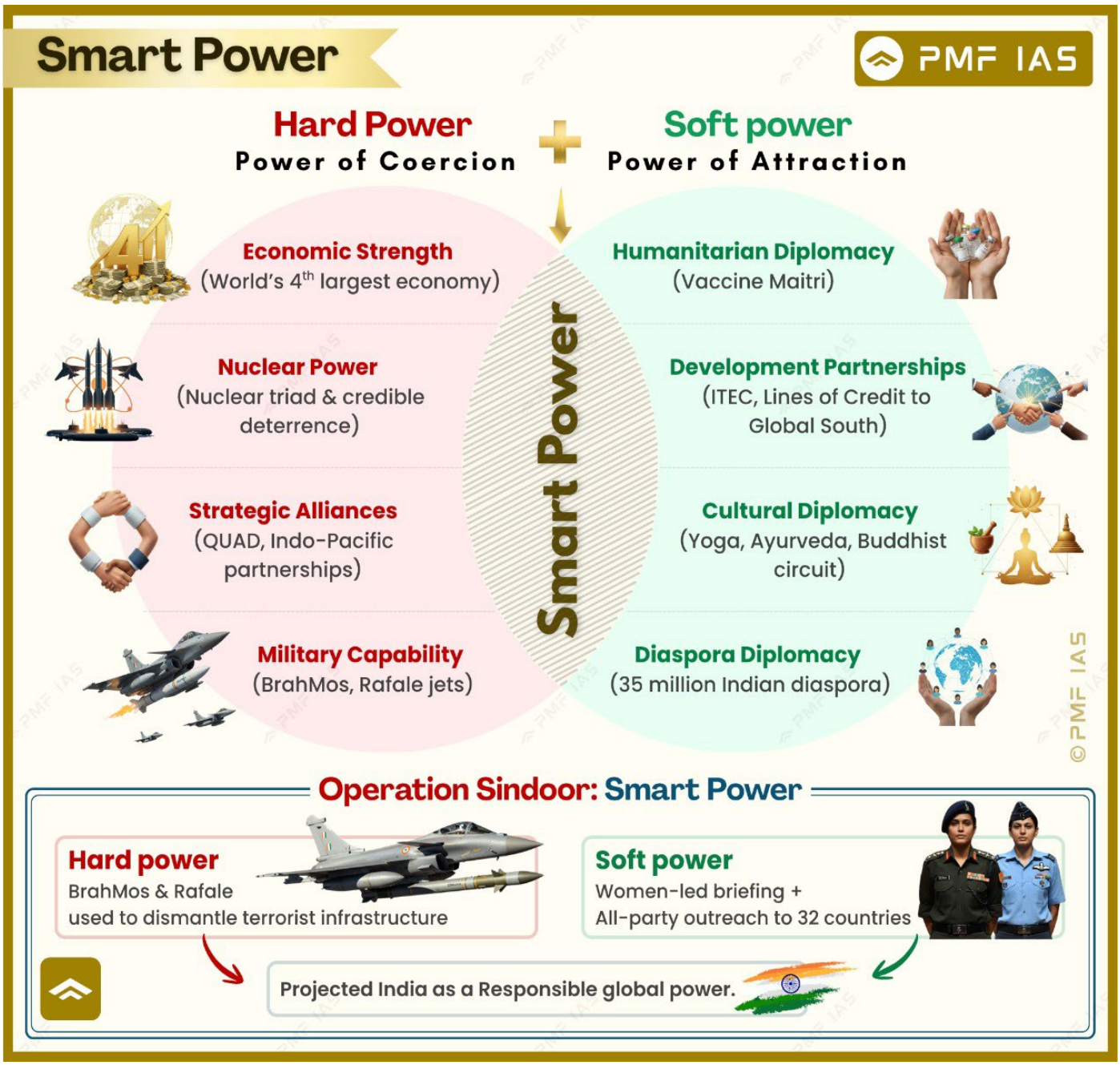
❖ **Context (IE):** In an era of shifting geopolitics, India's civilisational heritage offers immense soft-power potential, but fragmented narratives constrain global influence.

About Soft Power

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- **Meaning:** Soft Power can be defined as the ability of a nation to influence others through culture, values, and appeal rather than coercion or military force. It is the **power of attraction**.
- **Pillars of India's Soft Power:** **Samman** (dignity), **Samvaad** (dialogue), **Samriddhi** (shared prosperity), **Suraksha** (regional and global security), & **Sanskriti evam Sabhayata** (cultural and civilizational links).



Key Elements of India's Soft Power

- **Civilizational Heritage:** India's **5000-year** civilisation, **Nalanda–Takshashila** legacy, Buddhism, the philosophy of **Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam**, & non-violence inspire global respect.
  - ❖ **Yoga and Spiritualism:** International Yoga Day (21 June) was adopted by the UN with 177 nations' support; **Art of Living**, **Isha Foundation**, & **Vipassana** spread Indian spirituality abroad.

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- ❖ **Ayurveda and Traditional Systems:** Ayurveda, Siddha, Unani, Sowa-Rigpa, Homoeopathy popularised through the **AYUSH** Ministry, and the **WHO Global Centre for Traditional Medicine** (Jamnagar).
- **Bollywood:** Indian cinema, music and dance increase cultural appeal in the Middle East, Africa, CIS, and Latin America. E.g., **DDLJ** in Europe, **Baahubali** in Japan.
- **Diaspora Influence:** **Over 3.5 crore Indian diaspora** in more than 150 nations act as cultural ambassadors, e.g., CEOs of **Google and Microsoft**.
- **Sports Soft Power:** IPL attracting players from over 15 countries, support for Afghanistan and Nepal's cricket infrastructure and players enhances India's reputation.
- **Science & Technology:** India's achievements in ISRO, **Chandrayaan**, **UPI**, & Digital Public Infrastructure (**DPI**) serve as an inspiring developmental model for the world South.
- **Disaster Relief Leadership:** **Vaccine Maitri**, **Operation Dost** (Turkey earthquake), HADR missions, and rescue operations showcase India's compassionate global role.
- **Green Development:** India's climate leadership through **International Solar Alliance (**ISA), & **Global Biofuel Alliance**, creates a sustainable development model admired by the Global South.
- **Development Partnership:** Development partnership through **ITEC**, concessional Lines of Credit, & capacity building in the **Global South** enhances credibility.

Challenges to India's Soft Power

- ➢ **Lack of Coordination:** A fragmented approach among ministries reduces impact and continuity.
- ➢ **Limited Branding:** Weak global promotion compared to Korea & Japan. E.g., **K-pop**, **Anime**.
- ➢ **Political Polarisation Narrative:** Western media portrayal of social issues & minorities, impacts India's image if not countered strategically.
- ➢ **Lack of Funding:** India's soft power agencies, like ICCR, operate on a budget of Rs. **300–400 crore**, mainly for administration, while China spends ~Rs. **10,000 crores annually**, limiting global cultural outreach.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Soft Power Assessment:** MEA must evaluate India's soft power potential and devise strategies with **measurable outcomes** using a **'Soft Power Matrix'**.
- ✓ **Policy & Coordination:** Prepare a policy document on soft power projections and establish a Coordination Committee among **MEA**, Indian Council for Cultural Relations (**ICCR**) & other line ministries.
- ✓ **Diaspora Outreach:** Engage **India's 3.5 crore diaspora** and digital platforms to amplify culture globally.
- ✓ **Enhanced Funding:** Increase **ICCR's** budgetary allocation by at least **20%** over current provisions to strengthen India's soft-power outreach and reduce administrative overheads.

{IR – Diplomacy} South-South and Triangular Cooperation (SSTC) *

- ❖ **Context (**UN**):** SSTC has become a key tool for promoting development, solidarity, and innovative solutions amid declining traditional aid and global inequalities.
- With the 2030 Agenda for **Sustainable Development** nearing its deadline, India is leveraging SSTC to strengthen development partnerships among **Global South countries**.

About South-South and Triangular Cooperation (SSTC)

- **South-South Cooperation:** It is a framework for collaboration and exchange among developing countries in political, economic, social, cultural, environmental, and technical domains.
- **Triangular Cooperation** It is a Southern-driven partnership between two or more developing countries, supported by a developed country or multilateral organisation.

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- **Guiding Principles:** Based on mutual respect for sovereignty, equality, non-interference, mutual benefit, solidarity, and peaceful coexistence.

Evolution of South-South and Triangular Cooperation

- The **United Nations Office for South-South Cooperation (UNOSSC)** was created on **1974** to promote economic cooperation among developing countries.
- **Buenos Aires Plan of Action (BAPA) 1978,** adopted by 138 UN member states, establishing the first framework for SSC and emphasising solidarity, mutual respect, and shared learning.
- **Nairobi Outcome Document (2009)** expanded SSC beyond technical cooperation to political, institutional, and infrastructural collaboration.
- **India-UN Development Partnership Fund (2017)** was established to finance demand-driven SSTC projects across developing countries.
- The United Nations declared "**New Opportunities and Innovation through SSTC**" as the theme for the **2025 UN Day for South-South and Triangular Cooperation**

Contemporary Relevance of South-South and Triangular Cooperation

- **Empowerment and Solidarity:** Strengthens self-reliance, mutual respect, and shared learning while avoiding the conditionalities often linked to North-South aid
- **Tackling Global Challenges:** Provides collective solutions to poverty, rising inequalities, climate change, and shrinking traditional aid.
- **Driver of SDGs:** Acts as a major force for achieving the **2030 Agenda**, particularly **SDG 2 (Zero Hunger)**, through affordable, locally driven innovations.
- **Multi-Sectoral Role:** Supports progress in agriculture, health, education, digital economy, climate resilience, social protection, and urban development.

India's Role in South-South and Triangular Cooperation

- **Philosophy:** Aligned with India's philosophy of **Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam** ("The world is one family").
- **Institutional Mechanisms:**
  - **Development Partnership Administration:** Key agency within the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), Central body for planning and implementing SSTC projects.
  - **Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC):** Capacity-building program in 160+ countries.
  - **India-UN Development Partnership Fund:** Supports 75+ demand-driven projects in 56 countries, focusing on **Least Developed Countries (LDCs)** and **Small Island Developing States (SIDS)**.
- **Technological Leadership:** Shares digital public infrastructure like Aadhaar and UPI for cost-effective, replicable solutions globally.
- **Regional Advocacy:** Hosted Voice of the Global South Summits to amplify Southern priorities and advocated for permanent African Union membership in G20.
- **World Food Programme (WFP):** Piloted **Annapurti** (Grain ATMs), women-led **Take-Home Ration**, and **rice fortification** for improving food security in other developing countries.

Challenges in South-South and Triangular Cooperation

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- **Fragmentation:** Diverse political systems, economic priorities, and historical contexts often lead to scattered efforts, diluting impact and hindering cohesive collaboration.
- **Funding Gaps:** SSTC largely depends on trust funds and voluntary contributions (e.g. IBSA Fund), which are often unpredictable and insufficient.
- **Political Will:** Inconsistent commitment and delayed initiatives weaken trust among partners.
- **Triangular Cooperation Complexities:** Involvement of developed countries or multilateral organisations introduces bureaucracy and power asymmetries, which may compromise Southern leadership.
- **Monitoring Gaps:** Absence of a common framework results in weak evaluation, limited transparency, and difficulty in scaling successful projects.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Foster Innovation:** Building on the **2025 UN Day theme**, countries should promote creative, locally relevant solutions and support pilot projects with strong institutional frameworks.
- ✓ **Enhance Financing:** Increase funding for **demand-driven initiatives** and embed monitoring to strengthen transparency, effectiveness, and replication.
- ✓ **Multi-Stakeholder Partnerships** to include civil society, private sector, academia, and grassroots communities, ensuring cooperation remains people-centred and contextually relevant.
- ✓ **High-Impact Sectors:** Prioritise food security, nutrition, climate resilience, health systems, and education, where Southern innovations can be scaled and replicated across similar contexts.
- ✓ **Knowledge Sharing:** Strengthen regional and global knowledge platforms, facilitate training programs, and share best practices to enhance learning across countries.
- ✓ **Align with SDGs:** Design projects with measurable development outcomes, linking SSTC initiatives to Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) for maximum impact.

{IR – Diaspora} Global Talent Re-engagement

❖ **Context (TH):** Shifts in **global migration policies** have intensified **India's need for a structured strategy** to attract, reintegrate, and retain highly skilled professionals positioned abroad.

Need for a Structured Talent Re-engagement Strategy

- **Brain Circulation:** With Indian nationals accounting for **~ 71% of H-1B approvals** in **FY2024**, external policy disruptions create a window for converting **brain drain into productive brain circulation**.
- **Innovation Deficit:** India's R&D expenditure remains at just **0.64% of GDP**, significantly lower than that of advanced economies, underscoring the urgency of attracting globally trained researchers.
- **Retention Constraints:** Mobility studies indicate that **wage incentives alone are insufficient**, as long-term talent retention depends on networks, family support systems, and institutional ecosystems.
- **Global Competition for Skills:** Advanced economies increasingly deploy targeted migration and research policies, intensifying the race for **high-end human capital**.

Challenges in Re-engaging India's Global Talent

- ➢ **Bureaucratic Inertia:** Rigid institutional frameworks and heavy red tape often frustrate scientists accustomed to agile, global research environments.
- ➢ **Infrastructure Deficit:** Inadequate laboratory facilities and delays in grant disbursements fundamentally hinder returning talent from producing high-quality intellectual property.

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- **Relocation Deterrents:** Large **compensation gaps** and **quality of life issues** such as urban pollution make permanent relocation unviable for top professionals.
- **R&D Void:** India's weak corporate research culture forces returning experts to depend almost entirely on limited publicly funded academic positions.
- **Cultural Friction:** Deeply ingrained **hierarchical work cultures** and **inflexible promotion** systems in domestic institutions alienate the highly skilled diaspora.

Key Initiatives Supporting Talent Re-engagement

- **GATI: Global Access to Talent from India** is designed to strengthen engagement with globally positioned Indian professionals by facilitating cross-border innovation linkages.
- **eMigrate V2.0:** A digital migration governance platform improving transparency, worker protection, and skill-matching efficiency across overseas employment ecosystems.
- **VAJRA: Visiting Advanced Joint Research** is a faculty scheme that allows overseas scientists and academicians to work as adjunct faculty in Indian institutions, converting **"brain drain" into "brain gain".**
- **KIP: Know India Programme** is a diaspora engagement initiative fostering cultural, economic, and institutional linkages between India and young overseas Indians.

Pravasi Bharatiya Divas (PBD)

- **Objective:** Prawasi Bhartiya Diwas is celebrated annually on **January 9th** to mark the contribution of the **Overseas Indian community** to the development of India.
- **Historical Background:** The date **January 9** was chosen to commemorate the **return of Mahatma Gandhi from South Africa** to India in **1915**.
- **Inception:** Established in **2003** following the recommendations of the High-Level Committee on Indian Diaspora (headed by **L.M. Singhvi**).
- **Format:** It was **an annual event until 2015**. Since **2015**, it has been celebrated as a **biennial event**.
- **Organisers: Ministry of External Affairs**, in partnership with a selected State Government.

Read More > *India's Diaspora*

{IR – Strategic Diplomacy – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. To what extent can soft power complement India's economic and strategic interests amid intensifying great-power competition? Discuss the opportunities and challenges in aligning soft power with national priorities (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

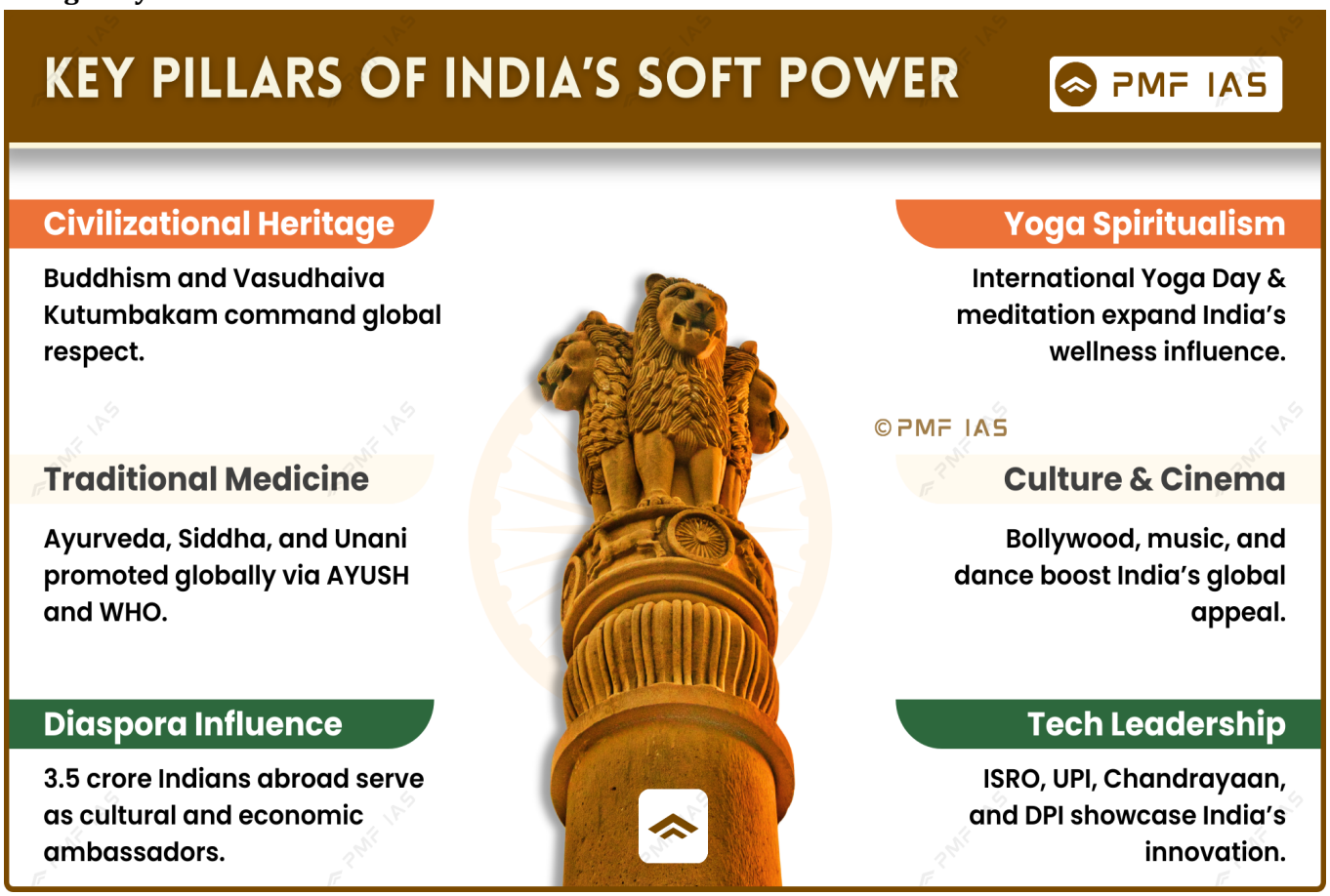
- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about soft power and include a recent example.
- **Body:** Describe how soft power presents opportunities for India's strategic and economic interests, while also highlighting challenges and the way forward.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasise the transition from soft power to smart power by outlining the upcoming actions.

Model Answer (250 Words)

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- Soft power, the ability to influence through attraction rather than coercion, enables nations to shape global preferences. India leverages it through initiatives such as **Vaccine Maitri**, **ISRO missions**, and **International Yoga Day**.



Soft Power as an Opportunity for India's Strategic and Economic Interests

- **Cultural Diplomacy:** **Yoga**, **Ayurveda**, and India's heritage boost credibility. E.g., International Yoga Day was adopted by 177 nations.
- **Diaspora Outreach:** **3.5 crore Indians abroad** serve as ambassadors, promoting trade and strategic connections.
- **Tech Leadership:** **ISRO**, **Chandrayaan**, **UPI**, and **DPI** highlight India's role as a Global South innovator.
- **Humanitarian Diplomacy:** **Vaccine Maitri**, **Operation Dost**, **ISA**, and **Biofuel Alliance** strengthen India's global influence.

Challenges

- **Coordination Gaps:** **A fragmented approach** across MEA, ICCR, & the Culture Ministry limits soft-power impact.
- **Branding Deficit:** **Weak global promotion** reduces visibility compared to K-pop or Confucius Institutes.
- **Media Perception:** **Negative Western coverage** of domestic issues impacts India's credibility internationally.
- **Funding Shortfall:** **ICCR's Rs. 300–400 cr** budget is far below **China's ~Rs. 10,000 cr**, limiting outreach.

Way Forward

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- ✓ **Policy Framework:** Create a **National Soft Power Strategy** with measurable outcomes. E.g., unified coordination between MEA and ICCR.
- ✓ **Diaspora Outreach: Engage 3.5 crore Indians abroad** via digital campaigns and podcasts. E.g., **Pravasi Bharatiya Divas** initiatives.
- ✓ **Funding Boost:** Increase ICCR budget by **≥20% from Rs. 300–400 cr**.
- ✓ **Strategic Alignment:** Link **soft-power programs** with trade and development projects. E.g., ITEC scholarships and concessional Lines of Credit in Africa.

Conclusion

- **"A nation leads not by the might of its power, but by the light of its values."** With **coordinated outreach** & **sustained investment**, India can transform soft power into a strategic and economic lever of global leadership.

-------- End of Chapter --------

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Multilateralism & Global Governance

{IR – Groupings} BRICS *

❖ **Context (IE|IE):** India is **balancing** its aspirations for global leadership with the constraints of China-dominated forums like BRICS. As multilateral institutions evolve, India must **evaluate** whether they support or hinder its strategic autonomy and foreign policy interests.

Evolution of BRICS	
BRICS Formation	• Established in **2009** with **Brazil, Russia, India** & **China** as **founding members**.
South Africa's Entry	• **South Africa** joined the bloc in **2010**, expanding it to BRICS.
Recent Expansions	• In 2023, **Iran, Egypt, Ethiopia,** and the **UAE** joined the group, with **Saudi Arabia** invited.
Current Membership	• Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Saudi Arabia, Iran, Egypt, Ethiopia, UAE, and Indonesia.

Strategic Relevance of BRICS

- **Global Weight:** With **11 member countries**, BRICS represents nearly **50% of the world's population**, about **40% of global GDP,** and around **26% of global trade** (MEA).
- **Diverse Yet Cohesive:** Unlike the ideologically aligned G7, BRICS brings together nations with varied political systems and economic models, making it both resilient and complex.
- **Multilateral Shield:** In an era marked by U.S. retreat from global leadership and weakening of institutions like WTO & WHO, BRICS offers its members **strategic autonomy** & a **collective bargaining platform**.
- **South-South Solidarity:** It strengthens cooperation among developing nations, boosts **global standing**, and presents an alternative vision of global governance amid a shifting multipolar order.

Significance of BRICS for India

- **Economic Powerhouse:** BRICS accounts for **40% of global GDP**, giving India access to vast emerging markets and reducing dependence on Western economies.
- **Infrastructure Boost:** Through the **New Development Bank (NDB)**, India has received **$10 billion** in loans for sustainable transport, renewable energy, and urban infrastructure (NDB).
- **Global South Voice:** India leverages BRICS to champion **Global South priorities** like climate finance and digital inclusion, highlighted at the **2023 Johannesburg Summit**.
- **Strategic Balance:** BRICS supports India's **multi-alignment diplomacy**, allowing it to balance ties with China and Russia while maintaining autonomy from Western blocs.
- **Tech Cooperation:** Platforms like the **BRICS Vaccine R&D Centre** and Innovation Framework foster India's collaboration in AI, digital tech, and health research.
- **Energy Security:** With **Russia supplying 35% of India's crude imports (2023)**, BRICS enhances India's energy diversification and resilience against global shocks.

Challenges

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- **Economic Asymmetry:** China's GDP (**$19.23 trillion**) is nearly **five times India's ($4.187 trillion)**, giving Beijing disproportionate influence over BRICS agendas.
- **Strategic Divergence:** Tensions such as the India-China border dispute and differing foreign policies limit cohesion on global issues.
- **Low Intra-BRICS Trade:** Despite a **26% share of global trade, intra-BRICS trade is only 2.2% (2022)** due to geographic constraints and China's dominance.
- **Weak Financial Alternatives:** The **NDB and CRA** have limited funds compared to the IMF/World Bank, constraining India's financial leverage.
- **Limited Global Influence:** BRICS+ holds **~19% IBRD voting power**, much less than G7 (**40%**) or EU-27 (**23%**), restricting global decision-making impact.
- **Overlap with Other Forums:** Groups like **IBSA** and **BASIC** are more cohesive, while BRICS diversity complicates India's agenda-setting and leadership role.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Strategic Expansion: Integrate new members** with clear criteria to maintain cohesion and enhance Global South influence.
- ✓ **Global Governance Reform:** Push for **UN**, **IMF**, and **World Bank reforms** to reflect emerging economies' interests.
- ✓ **Sustainable Finance: Mobilise predictable climate finance** and strengthen NDB for green and development projects.
- ✓ **Technological Cooperation: Promote AI**, **space**, and **digital infrastructure** collaboration to build South-led innovation capacity.
- ✓ **Economic Sovereignty: Expand local currency trade**, **cross-border payments**, and investment de-risking mechanisms for financial independence.

{IR – Groupings} Scientific Collaborations in BRICS

❖ **Context (TH): BRICS** has emerged as a significant platform for scientific collaboration, advancing coordinated research and innovation among major emerging economies.

Evolution of Scientific Collaboration in BRICS

- **Strategic Birth: Brasilia MoU** (**2015**) transitioned BRICS science cooperation from informal discussions to a formal institutional framework.
- **Funding Launch: STI Framework Programme** (**2016**) introduced the **virtual pot model** and funded the first multilateral R&D grants among member states.
  - ⇨ ***Virtual Pot:*** *Each country* ***funds its own researchers*** *within a joint project rather than contributing to a centralised repository.*
  - ⇨ ***Eligibility:*** *A research proposal must include partners from* ***at least three BRICS member countries*** *to qualify under the STI Framework Programme.*
- **Commercial Pivot: Hangzhou Action Plan** (**2017**) moved BRICS cooperation beyond academic research toward market-ready innovation and **cross-border technology transfer**.
- **Resource Pooling: Remote Sensing Agreement** (**2021**) allowed BRICS members to use common scientific infrastructure (**joint satellite constellation**) for the first time.

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- **Health Integration:** **Vaccine R&D Centre** (**2022**) brought health security into BRICS cooperation by establishing a shared platform for **pandemic preparedness**.
- **Frontier Governance:** **Rio AI Declaration** (**2025**) placed Artificial Intelligence at the core of BRICS cooperation to shape global standards in emerging technologies.

Key Scientific Initiatives under BRICS

Initiative / Platform	Domain	Core Function
iBRICS Network	*Innovation & Startups*	Connects science parks, incubators, and innovation hubs to provide **soft-landing support for startups** across BRICS markets.
Technology Transfer Centre	*Commercialisation & IP*	Supports **patent navigation** and **cross-border commercialisation** of intellectual property for startups and labs.
Institute of Future Networks	*Telecommunications & ICT*	Develops **common standards** for 5G, 6G, and industrial IoT technologies.
Energy Research Cooperation Platform	*Sustainable Energy*	Conducts joint research on hydrogen, smart grids, and renewable energy transition.
TB Research Network	*Public Health*	Aligns clinical protocols and diagnostics to combat tuberculosis and infectious diseases.
Astronomy Working Group	*Fundamental Science*	**Integrates telescope data** for joint deep-space observation and astrophysical mapping.
BRICS Network University	*Higher Education*	Enables joint research and academic exchanges across **11 thematic groups** spanning energy, ICT, health, and ecology.
Young Scientist Forum	*Human Capital*	Connects **researchers under 40** to address shared regional challenges.

Challenges in BRICS Scientific Collaboration

- **R&D Asymmetry:** China's dominant R&D expenditure creates **uneven project leadership** and structural financial dependency.
- **Institutional Fragmentation:** The **absence** of a **permanent central secretariat** weakens long-term strategic planning and administrative coordination
- **Funding Disparity:** The 'virtual pot' model exposes projects to **domestic economic volatility**, allowing funding disruptions in one member to stall multilateral initiatives.
- **Language Barriers:** Limited shared scientific language beyond English hinders peer collaboration and the standardisation of technical documentation.
- **Valley of Death:** **Low commercialisation rates** prevent the conversion of joint laboratory research into market-ready technological products

Way Forward for India in BRICS Scientific Collaboration

- ✓ **IP Framework:** Establish **standardised intellectual property sharing norms** to enable joint ownership and faster commercialisation of collaborative research outputs.

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- ✓ **Institutional Continuity:** Create a **permanent coordination mechanism** to ensure long-term funding, project tracking, and policy alignment across BRICS scientific initiatives.
- ✓ **Startup Linkages:** Develop **cross-border deep-tech startup corridors** to bridge the lab-to-market gap and scale innovation across member economies.
- ✓ **Data Collaboration:** Expand satellite and research data-sharing to **reduce duplication of high-cost infrastructure** and enhance collective scientific capability.
- ✓ **Strategic Balance:** Combine BRICS collaboration with **diversified bilateral partnerships** to avoid technological dependence and maintain strategic autonomy.

Read More> *BRICS: Evolution, Expansion & Importance for India*

{IR – Groupings} BIMSTEC

❖ **Context (TP | IE):** Shifting geopolitical dynamics and regional uncertainties make stronger Bay of Bengal cooperation essential for regional security, connectivity, and sustainable development.

Importance of BIMSTEC for India

- **Bypassing Pakistan:** Allows India to pursue regional trade, connectivity, and cooperation through BIMSTEC without being hindered by **India-Pakistan tensions in SAARC**.
- **Strategic Importance:** It bridges **South** & **Southeast Asia**, reinforcing **India's Act East** and **Neighbourhood First** policies.
- **Economic Integration:** Facilitates regional trade, investment, and value chain development, with prospects of a **BIMSTEC Free Trade Agreement**.
- **Security Cooperation:** Strengthens counter-terrorism, maritime security, and disaster response through joint efforts like **BIMSTEC DMEx**.
- **Energy and Climate Collaboration:** Enables regional energy grid planning and joint climate resilience efforts via the **BIMSTEC Energy Centre**.

BIMSTEC vs SAARC: Similarities and Dissimilarities

- BIMSTEC and SAARC are two key regional groupings in South Asia that aim to **enhance cooperation**, yet differ in their membership, priorities, and effectiveness.

Similarities

- **Membership:** Five countries, India, Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, and Sri Lanka, participate in both organizations, reflecting **overlapping membership**.
- **Goal:** Both aim to promote **regional integration**, trade, and **connectivity** among member states.
- **Leadership:** India plays a pivotal & anchoring role in both organizations, shaping agendas & cooperation.

Dissimilarities

- **Geostrategic Role:** SAARC is South Asia centric; BIMSTEC bridges South and Southeast Asia, consolidating India's influence in the **Bay of Bengal** and linking to the **Indo-Pacific**.
- **Mandate Focus:** SAARC focuses on broad social, cultural, and development issues; BIMSTEC prioritizes actionable sectors like trade, energy, connectivity, and technology.
- **Operational Effectiveness:** SAARC is largely inactive due to India-Pakistan tensions; BIMSTEC functions effectively as it excludes Pakistan and emphasizes pragmatic economic cooperation.
- **Maritime Connectivity:** BIMSTEC actively promotes maritime transport agreements across the Bay of Bengal to enhance trade, & connect ports; SAARC lacks such functional maritime initiatives.

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BIMSTEC

Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation

Members

Initial Members(BIST-EC) (1997)

- Bangladesh
- India
- Sri Lanka
- Thailand

- Myanmar (22 Decemeber 1997)
- Nepal
- Bhutan (February 2004)

BIMSTEC Organizational Structure

The Summit
Heads of State or Government of Member States.

Ministerial Meeting
Ministers dealing with foreign relations.

Sectoral Ministerial Meetings
Ministers of line ministries for respective sectors.

Senior Officials' Meeting
Foreign Secretaries/Senior officials nominated by Member States.

BIMSTEC Permanent Working Committee (BPWC)
Senior officials from National Focal Points.

BIMSTEC Purposes

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Economic Development
Accelerate growth and progress in the region.

Collaboration
Work with like-minded organizations.

Training & Research
Provide educational, professional, and technical training and research facilities.

Regional Projects
Focus on productive projects leveraging regional synergies.

Peace & Stability
Combat terrorism, crime, natural disasters, climate change, and diseases.

Connectivity
Establish multidimensional connectivity for economic integration.

International Cooperation
Collaborate with organizations sharing similar goals.

Poverty Eradicationv
Eradicate regional poverty.

Trade & Investment
Promote trade and investment for economic and social development.

Focus Areas

Initial Sectors (1997)
- Trade
- Technology
- Energy
- Transport
- Tourism
- Fisheries

Expanded Sectors (2008)
- People-to-People Contact
- Agriculture
- Environment
- Poverty Alleviation
- Counter Terrorism
- Climate Change
- Public Health

Reorganized Sectors (2021)
01 Rationalized cooperation under respective Member States' leadership.
02
03

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Benefits for Member Countries

- Overcome landlocked challenges
- Greater regional influence
- Balance China, access Indian markets
- Connection with Southeast Asia

India and BIMSTEC

India's Focus
Security, Counter-terrorism, Disaster Management, Energy.

Strategic Platform
Supports "Neighbourhood First" and "Act East" policies.

Countering China
Alternative to Belt and Road Initiative, promoting best practices.

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Issues With BIMSTEC

- **Institutional Weakness:** Lack of a strong **permanent secretariat** with sufficient funding and staff hinders coordination and implementation.
- **Slow Progress on Agreements:** Critical initiatives like the **BIMSTEC Free Trade Agreement** (FTA) and **connectivity projects** are experiencing delays and remain unfinished.
- **Political Instability:** Ongoing **crises** in Myanmar (civil war), Nepal, and Sri Lanka hinder regional cooperation and long-term planning.
- **Overlapping Priorities:** Some members prioritise ASEAN or **bilateral relations** over BIMSTEC, which reduces collective momentum.
- **Limited Financial Commitment:** Inadequate financial contributions and investments impede the implementation of large-scale projects and infrastructure development.
- **Unequal Member Commitments:** Some member nations prioritise ASEAN or SAARC over BIMSTEC.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Institutional Reform:** Establish a well-resourced **Permanent Secretariat** with professional staffing and clear mandates.
- ✓ **Connectivity Acceleration:** Fast-track critical infrastructure projects like the **Kaladan Multimodal Transit** and **India–Myanmar–Thailand Highway**.
- ✓ **Economic Integration:** Finalise the **BIMSTEC FTA** and facilitate regional value chains and cross-border trade mechanisms.
- ✓ **Targeted Sectoral Cooperation:** Deepen collaboration in disaster management, renewable energy, and digital public infrastructure.
- ✓ **Inclusive Growth:** Provide technical and financial support to Least Developed Countries like **Bhutan** and **Nepal** for capacity-building.
- ✓ **People-to-People Engagement:** Promote academic exchanges, cultural diplomacy, and relax visa norms to foster regional unity

{IR – Groupings} G20 **

❖ **Context (TH):** The **20th G20 Leaders' Summit 2025** was hosted for the **first time on the African continent** in **Johannesburg, South Africa**.

- The summit was held in the **spirit of 'Ubuntu'**, a Nguni Bantu concept (meaning "**I am because we are**") that signifies interconnectedness, human dignity, and collective well-being.

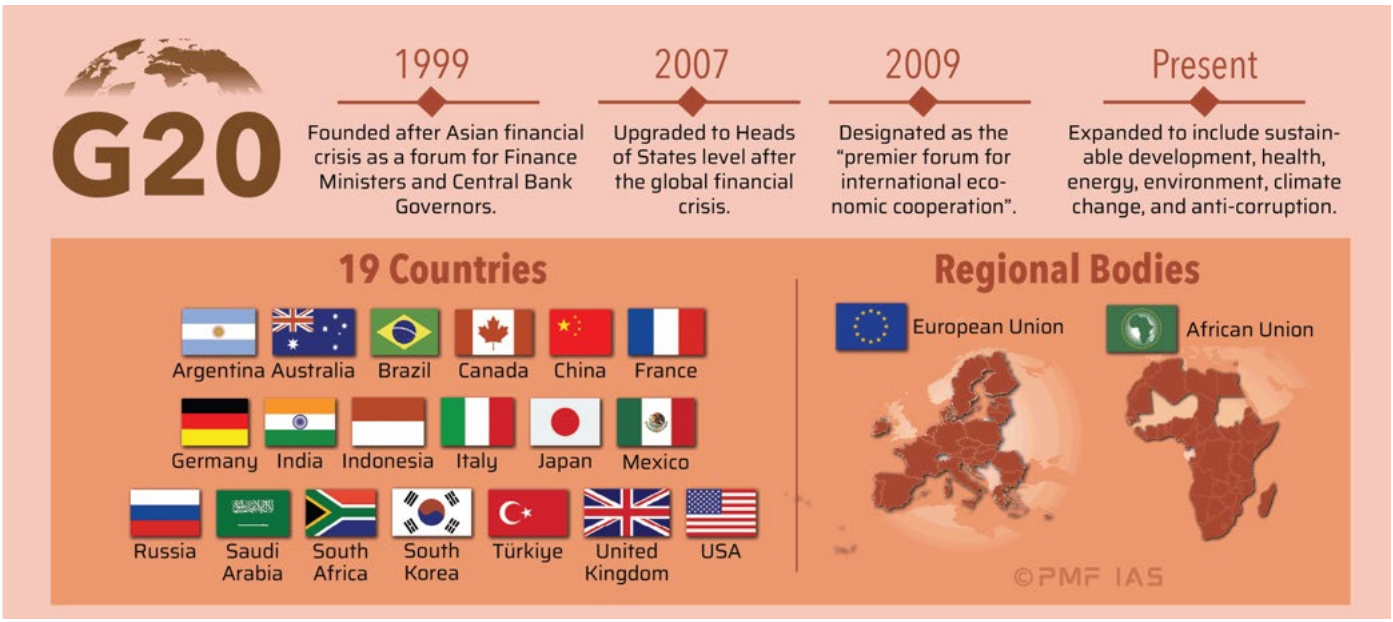
Key Outcomes of the G20 Summit 2025

- ✓ **Johannesburg Leaders' Declaration:** Adopted unusually early at the summit, it amplified the ***"Voice of the Global South"*** and prioritised development justice over geopolitical polarisation.
- ✓ **Critical Minerals:** Members adopted a landmark framework encouraging **domestic value addition** and processing within resource-origin nations (instead of exporting raw minerals).
- ✓ **MDB Reform:** Leaders approved a plan to reform **Multilateral Development Banks** (**MDBs**), including concessional financing and debt relief for low-income countries experiencing stagnation.
- ✓ **African Union:** This summit fully operationalised the **African Union's permanent membership**, bringing African development priorities to the forefront of all working-group discussions.

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- ✓ **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI):** Countries pledged financial and technical support to help developing nations deploy DPI systems and narrow the **global digital divide**.
- ✓ **AI Governance:** The declaration endorsed a **human-centric AI governance model** that ensures fair access to technology and safeguards against digital risks.
- ✓ **Debt Sustainability:** The first standalone **G20 declaration on debt** since the COVID-19 pandemic recognised that increasing debt-servicing costs are restricting development expenditure in the Global South.



Other Working Group and Sidelines Outcomes

- **Women Economic Empowerment:** **G20 Empowerment of Women Working Group** (**EWWG**) established **three pillars** for advancing women's economic empowerment
  1. **Care Economy:** Recognition of **unpaid care work as a barrier** to women's economic participation and a pledge to expand public care infrastructure.
  2. **Gender-Based Violence (GBV):** A unified commitment to **eradicate GBV** and **femicide**, treating it as both a **human-rights** and **economic crisis**.
  3. **Financial Inclusion:** A global target to close the gender gap in **digital financial services** by **2030**.
- **Digital Innovation Alliance:** **India, Brazil, and South Africa launched an alliance** to jointly develop and share DPI as a "**Global South alternative**" to Western technology platforms.
- **Restitution of Cultural Heritage:** G20 members have, for the first time, officially recognised the need to repatriate cultural artefacts and heritage items to their countries of origin.
- **Ubuntu Legacy Initiative:** Announced by the **South African Presidency** and the **African Development Bank (AfDB)** to accelerate cross-border connectivity and infrastructure projects across Africa.
- **Green Tourism:** The Tourism Working Group introduced a "**Tourism Financing Framework**" to de-risk investments for **MSMEs** and help them access green bonds.
- **Principles on Bioeconomy:** Ten voluntary principles were adopted to establish a **shared definition** and policy framework for advancing the global bioeconomy.
- **Disaster-Risk:** Leaders endorsed new guidelines to shift disaster spending **from reactive response** to **preventive planning**, including integrating risk into budgets and prearranged financial tools.

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Initiatives Proposed by India in Johannesburg G20 Leaders' Summit

- **Africa Skills Multiplier Initiative:** To train **one million certified trainers in Africa** over the next decade using a "**train-the-trainers**" model.
- **Initiative on Countering the Drug-Terror Nexus:** A coordinated effort to monitor illicit financial flows, improve intelligence sharing, and combat drug trafficking and its links to terrorism.
- **Global Traditional Knowledge Repository:** To document, preserve, and disseminate traditional knowledge systems and prevent their misappropriation through patent regimes.
- **Global Healthcare Response Team:** A multinational roster of medical experts from G20 nations to serve as a "**Health Peacekeeping Force**" during future health emergencies and disasters.
- **Open Satellite Data Partnership:** To improve access to satellite data and expertise for developing countries in agriculture, disaster management, and climate monitoring.
- **Critical Minerals Circularity Initiative:** Promotes the recycling of critical minerals and '**urban mining**' to lessen reliance on primary extraction and external supply chains.

Key Challenges at the G20 Summit

- **US Absence:** For the first time, the United States did not send a Presidential delegation, weakening the group's cohesion and diluting Western-backed commitments.
- **Critical Minerals:** While the **Critical Minerals Framework was agreed in principle**, it lacked binding enforcement mechanisms to ensure investment in local processing.
- **Geopolitical Statements:** The summit's stance on the Ukraine and Gaza conflicts was softer than in previous years; it **emphasised humanitarian impacts** rather than directly condemning aggression.
- **Climate Finance:** The summit failed to secure concrete financial commitments from developed nations for the **New Collective Quantified Goal** (NCQG) on climate finance
- **Fragmentation Risks:** The absence of the US and the increased **focus on the Global South** could divide the G20 into rival blocs rather than serve as a unified global economic forum.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Inclusive Governance:** Strengthen G20 consensus through equitable Global South representation and reforms of global governance institutions.
- ✓ **Climate Finance:** Ensure predictable, adequate, and time-bound climate finance commitments to support adaptation and sustainable development.
- ✓ **Digital Cooperation:** Expand **Digital Public Infrastructure** (**DPI**), ethical AI governance, and technology-sharing to bridge the global digital divide.
- ✓ **Implementation Focus:** Establish **robust monitoring** and **accountability mechanisms** to translate G20 commitments into measurable outcomes.

Read More> *G20: Evolution, Members and Working*

{IR – Issues} Russia–India–China (RIC) Troika

❖ **Context (TD):** Russia aims to revive the dormant **RIC Troika**, citing **eased India-China tensions** and **shifting geopolitics** amid increasing Western strategic pressures.

About the RIC Troika

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- **Nature:** **Informal trilateral strategic grouping** proposed by **Russia** in the late 1990s.
- **Purpose:** Seeks to **counter Western dominance** by fostering Eurasian political & economic cooperation.
- **Formation:** Institutionalised in **2002**, holding over 20 **ministerial-level consultations** since inception.
- **Scope:** Focuses on coordinated stances in **foreign policy**, **trade**, and **multilateral reform**.
- **Dormancy:** Became largely inactive following the **India-China Galwan border confrontation** in **2020**.

Key Drivers Behind the Revival

- **US Protectionism:** **Renewed US tariffs** push members to **counter rising trade barriers**.
- **Sanctions Impact:** Western sanctions on Russia accelerate its **alignment with Asian economies**.
- **Financial Autonomy:** **Dollar weaponisation** fuels push for non-Western payment systems.
- **Connectivity Gains:** INSTC cargo growth showcases value of coordinated **Eurasian corridors**.
- **Trade Diversification:** Global supply disruptions drive search for secure **intra-RIC trade channels**.
- **Institutional Reform:** Members seek more decisive influence in UN, IMF, and WTO reforms.

Strategic Significance of the RIC Grouping

- ✓ **Eurasian Weight:** Three major powers collectively influence Eurasia's **strategic and economic balance**.
- ✓ **Economic Share:** Over **one-third of global GDP** gives RIC substantial negotiating leverage.
- ✓ **Multipolarity:** Promotes balanced global governance, **challenging dominance of single power blocs**.
- ✓ **UNSC Leverage:** **Joint backing** from Russia and China **strengthens India's membership prospects**.
- ✓ **Security Platform:** Facilitates **crisis dialogue** and conflict management in **regional hotspots**.
- ✓ **Integration Synergy:** Advances coordination of **Eurasian connectivity**, trade, & infrastructure initiatives.

Challenges to RIC Cooperation

- ➢ **Border Disputes:** Ongoing India-China tensions obstruct deeper political and strategic trust.
- ➢ **Trust Deficit:** **Historical rivalries** constrain meaningful **defence** and **intelligence collaboration**.
- ➢ **Western Engagements:** India's **growing Western ties** dilute trilateral cohesion.
- ➢ **Quad Factor:** **Indo-Pacific security commitments** complicate India's role in RIC.
- ➢ **Neutrality Concerns:** **Intra-member rivalries** undermine RIC's credibility in mediating disputes.

{IR – Organisation} United Nations *

- ❖ **Context (TH):** At the United Nations General Assembly (**UNGA 80**), India stressed the urgent need for **comprehensive UN reforms**. The session also marked **30 years of the Beijing Declaration**, **15 years of UN Women**, and 80 years of the UN's establishment.

United Nations (UN)

- **About:** The United Nations (UN) is an **international organization** established to promote **peace, security, cooperation,** and **development** among countries worldwide.
- **Global Platform:** The UN helps nations resolve conflicts and coordinate on human rights, aid, and sustainable development.
- **The Four Main Goals of the UN:**
  - ❖ Maintaining international peace and security.
  - ❖ Developing friendly relations among nations.
  - ❖ Achieving international cooperation in solving international problems.

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❖ Being at the centre for harmonising nations' actions in attaining these common ends.

Achievements of the UN

- **Facilitated Decolonization:** By promoting self-determination, the UN supported independence movements worldwide. Over 80 former colonies gained statehood, reshaping the global map.
- **Humanitarian Assistance:** Provides aid to refugees, disaster victims, and people in crisis via agencies like UNHCR, WFP, and UNICEF.
- **Conflict Resolution:** The UN mediates disputes and deploys **peacekeeping missions** in conflict zones (e.g., Congo, Liberia, South Sudan).
- **Health:** In 1948, it created the World Health Organisation (**WHO**) to deal with communicable diseases like smallpox, malaria, and HIV.
- **Refugees:** In 1950, the UN created the **High Commissioner for Refugees** to care for the millions displaced during WWII. It continues to be at the forefront of the crises faced by refugees worldwide.

Failures of the UN

- **Conflict Failure:** The UN failed to prevent major atrocities like **Rwanda (1994)** and **Srebrenica (1995)**.
- **Weak Security Council:** The veto power of the five permanent members frequently blocks decisive action, resulting in inaction in conflicts like **Syria** and **Palestine**.
- **Rights Failure:** UN mechanisms for human rights are often slow, politicized, or reactive. E.g., delayed international response to the **Rohingya crisis in Myanmar**.
- **Bureaucracy Lag:** Complex administration and slow decision-making hinder timely UN interventions.
- **Power Imbalance:** Dominance of powerful nations marginalizes smaller states, reducing global representativeness.

Need for UN Reforms

- **Representation Gap:** The Security Council's outdated framework excludes **Africa**, **Latin America**, and **India**, diminishing its legitimacy and undermining equitable representation.
- **Veto Paralysis:** The **veto powers** of the P5 countries have obstructed collective responses in crises such as Ukraine and Gaza, resulting in stalemates and weakening trust in global security.
- **Mandate Overload:** Expanding mandates in development, climate, and terrorism, with a stagnant resource base, strain institutions and hinder SDG advancements.
- **Consensus Deficit:** The UN has failed to build consensus on issues such as terrorism, energy, and conflicts, which undermines its credibility and erodes multilateral trust.
- **Funding Crisis:** Persistent arrears and **reliance on donors** like the US and EU restrict budgetary stability, reducing resources for Global South missions.

India's Recent Roles in the United Nations

- **Security Role:** India deploys 5,000+ peacekeepers across **nine UN missions** and has escorted ~3,000 vessels during **anti-piracy patrols** in the Gulf of Aden.
- **Humanitarian Responder:** In 2024, India carried out **19 UN-supported relief missions**, including Afghanistan and Myanmar, while cumulatively implementing 600 development projects in 78 countries.
- **Reform Advocate:** As a member of the G4 group, India demands the **expansion of the UNSC**, pushing for both permanent and non-permanent seats to represent current global realities.

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- **Food Security:** In August 2025, India and UN-WFP initiated the "**Indian rice goes global**" program, committing to provide 200,000 tonnes of fortified rice for humanitarian assistance.
- **Development Financier:** Since 2017, India has jointly overseen the $150 million **India-UN Development Partnership Fund** with **UNOSSC**, aiding SDG initiatives in African, Pacific, and Caribbean countries.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Security Council Expansion:** **Include emerging powers** like India, Brazil, Germany, and Japan as permanent members.
- ✓ **Veto Power Reform:** Limit or regulate the **P5 veto** to prevent paralysis during crises.
- ✓ **Inclusivity:** Ensure that developing and populous nations have a greater voice in decision-making.
- ✓ **Peacekeeping Efficiency:** Strengthen **rapid deployment**, **accountability**, & **resources** for UN missions.
- ✓ **Human Rights:** Depoliticize mechanisms for timely action on human rights and humanitarian crises.

{IR – Organisation} United Nations Security Council **

❖ **Context (WEEK):** India has stated that UNSC reforms that do not add **new permanent members** with veto rights will continue the existing imbalance and inequality.

About the United Nations Security Council (UNSC)

- UNSC is the **principal UN organ** responsible for maintaining **international peace** and **security**.
- **Functions:** Handles conflict, peacekeeping operations, sanctions, and authorisation of military action.
- **Membership:** Comprises **15 members**; **5 permanent** (P5) and **10 non-permanent members** elected for **2-year terms**.
- **Permanent Members:** P5 includes the **USA**, **Russia**, **China**, the **UK**, and **France**, each with veto power.
- **Veto Power:** Any permanent member can block substantive resolutions using a veto, even if the majority supports it.
- **Binding Decisions:** UNSC resolutions are **legally binding** on all UN member states.

Structural Issues with UNSC

- ➢ **Membership Imbalance:** UNSC structure **remains skewed** with limited permanent members, which does not reflect current global power realities.
- ➢ **Veto:** P5 members hold disproportionate power through veto, enabling the blockage of critical decisions.
- ➢ **Lack of Representation:** Developing regions like **Africa**, **Latin America**, and the **Global South** remain underrepresented.
- ➢ **Outdated Framework:** An institution from **1945** fails to **address 21st-century geopolitical dynamics**.
- ➢ **Legitimacy Deficit:** Perceived bias and inequality reduce the credibility and effectiveness of UNSC decisions globally.

India's Position on UNSC Reforms

- **Permanent Expansion:** India **advocates expansion** of both permanent and non-permanent categories to improve representation.
- **Veto Inclusion:** Permanent expansion must include veto powers to avoid perpetuating existing inequities.
- **Equity Principle:** Reforms should ensure fair representation of developing countries & the Global South.

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- **Opposition to New Category:** Rejects creation of intermediate/new categories (with or without veto) as it complicates negotiations.

India's Claim for a Permanent Membership & Global Role

- **Largest Democracy:** India is the **world's largest democracy** with **~1.4 billion population**, strengthening its claim for global representation.
- **Economic Weight:** India is the 4th largest economy, reflecting its growing role in shaping global economic governance.
- **UN Peacekeeping Role:** India is one of the largest contributors (**~ 290,000** peacekeepers to more than 50 missions worldwide) to UN peacekeeping missions.
- **Global South Voice:** Acts as a leading representative of developing countries (G20 Presidency with Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam as theme), advocating equity in global institutions.
- **Multilateral Engagement:** Active member of BRICS and G20, with India hosting the **G20 Summit 2023** and pushing Global South priorities (e.g., African Union inclusion).
- **Responsible Power:** Advocates rules-based order, freedom of navigation (UNCLOS), and international law compliance.
- **Reform Leadership:** Consistently at the forefront of UNSC reform efforts through platforms like Inter-Governmental Negotiations (IGN) and **G4** grouping (**India, Germany, Japan, Brazil**).

Way Forward for India on UNSC Reforms

- ✓ **Text Talks:** Push for **text-based negotiations** to move Intergovernmental Negotiations toward concrete reform proposals.
- ✓ **Veto Reform:** Advocate a **supermajority restraint mechanism** to limit veto use during recognised global humanitarian crises.
- ✓ **Coalition Building:** Mobilise the **Global South** and **Group of Four** to press Permanent Five members for time-bound expansion.
- ✓ **Regional Forums:** Strengthen **regional security platforms** to reduce dependence on an unreformed United Nations Security Council.

{IR – Issues} Peacekeeping Missions *

❖ **Context (HT):** The Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) has warned that geopolitical tensions and a funding crisis are seriously jeopardising UN peacekeeping missions.

- United Nations Peacekeeping is a deployment of international military, police, and civilian personnel to help conflict-torn countries create the conditions for sustainable peace.

Challenges and Measures

Challenges	Measures
➢ **Funding Crisis:** Against budget of $5.6 billion for 2024-25, $2 billion remained unpaid as major donor countries failed to honour their commitments.	✓ **Timely Financial Contributions:** Member states must fulfil their financial obligations on time to ensure uninterrupted functioning of peacekeeping missions.

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- **Declining Missions:** Total 58 peacekeeping operations were active in 2025, falling below 60 for the 1st time since 2016.
- **Shrinking Deployments:** By 2025, around 79,000 personnel (lowest in 25 years) were deployed in peacekeeping operations, & nearly 3/4th personnels were serving in just 5 countries.
- **Veto Politics:** Veto threats and hard-line demands from permanent members complicated the renewal of operation mandates. Eg: US demanded an end to UNIFIL (Lebanon).
- **Evolving Nature of Conflicts:** Modern conflicts involve terrorism, civil wars, ethnic violence, and non-state armed actors, making traditional peacekeeping methods ineffective.

- ✓ **Reform the UN Security Council:** Reducing political deadlock and limiting misuse of veto power can improve the effectiveness and credibility of peacekeeping operations.
- ✓ **Modernise Peacekeeping Operations:** The UN should strengthen missions through advanced technology, better intelligence systems, rapid response mechanisms, improved logistical support.
- ✓ **Regional Partnerships:** Greater collaboration with regional bodies like the African Union (AU) and EU to complement UN efforts.
- ✓ **Political Solutions First:** Peacekeeping must be backed by genuine diplomatic efforts as military presence alone cannot ensure lasting peace.

Read More> ***UN Peacekeeping***

{IR – Organisation} World Trade Organisation *

❖ **Context (TH):** WTO faces a severe crisis post-**14th Ministerial Conference** (**MC14**), as rising unilateralism and lack of consensus undermine MFN principles and weaken the **global rules-based trade order**.

About the World Trade Organisation (WTO)

- **Trade Governance:** The World Trade Organisation is an intergovernmental body regulating global trade through a member-driven, consensus-based system.
- **Global Reach:** Headquarters in **Geneva**; **166 members** (**including India**), covering **~98%** of global trade, making it the primary global trade body.
- **Formal Establishment:** Established on 1 January 1995 under the **Marrakesh Agreement**, it succeeded the **General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade**.
- **Uruguay Round:** Emerged from the **Uruguay Round** (**1986–94**), which significantly reformed global trade rules.
- **Expanded Scope:** Unlike GATT, WTO covers trade in goods, services, and intellectual property.

Need for a Rules-Based Trade System

- **Rule-Based Trade:** Ensures **predictable trade** by curbing arbitrary tariffs. E.g., WTO rules prevent sudden tariff hikes, as seen during U.S.–China trade tensions.
- **Stability & Predictability:** Provides a **stable environment** for investment and supply chains. E.g., global firms rely on WTO norms to operate manufacturing networks across countries like Vietnam and India.
- **Dispute Resolution:** Offers a **legal platform** to settle trade disputes peacefully. E.g., India challenged U.S. steel tariffs at the WTO rather than escalating in retaliation.
- **Developmental Support:** Protects **developing nations** through S&DT provisions. E.g., India uses flexibilities for public stockholding to ensure food security.
- **Trade Expansion:** Promotes global trade growth and economic integration. E.g., post-1995, countries like China significantly expanded exports after joining the WTO.

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Reasons for Declining WTO Relevance

- **Rising Unilateralism:** Major powers impose tariffs, bypassing WTO rules. E.g., the U.S. used **Section 301** against China.
- **Decision Paralysis:** Consensus-based system delays **decisions** and **outcomes**. E.g., MC14 failed to issue a ministerial declaration.
- **Dispute Crisis:** **Appellate Body paralysis** weakens rule enforcement. E.g., pending disputes remain unresolved due to a shortage of judges.
- **Outdated Rules:** The WTO framework **lacks provisions for digital trade**. E.g., no clear rules on e-commerce and data flows.
- **System Fragmentation:** Shift to FTAs and plurilateral deals bypasses the WTO. E.g., regional trade agreements such as RCEP reduce the WTO's relevance.

14th Ministerial Conference (MC14) of WTO

- **Apex Authority:** The **Ministerial Conference** is the **highest decision-making body**, empowered to negotiate and amend global trade rules.
- **Statutory Provision:** Established under the **Marrakesh Agreement**, it meets once every two years.

Key Agenda

- **Dispute Reform:** Restore a fully functional, **two-tier binding dispute resolution system**, which has been paralysed since 2019.
- **Agriculture Security:** Secure a **permanent solution for public stockholding**, reduce trade-distorting subsidies, and improve market access.
- **Fisheries Subsidies:** Finalise "**Phase 2**" **rules** to **ban harmful subsidies** that contribute to **overcapacity** and **overfishing**.
- **Digital Trade:** Decide continuation of **E-commerce Moratorium** on customs duties for electronic transmissions, currently set to expire this year.
- **Plurilateral Integration:** Incorporate **Joint Statement Initiatives** (JSI) like Investment Facilitation for Development (IFD) into the formal WTO legal framework.

Key Challenges for WTO MC14

- **Geopolitical Fragmentation:** Rising "**friend-shoring**" and **national security exceptions** are undermining the Most-Favoured-Nation (MFN) principle.
- **Consensus Erosion:** The push for flexible plurilateral negotiations challenges the **unanimous decision-making model** that gives all members an equal voice.
- **Digital Sovereignty:** E-commerce moratorium creates a trade-off between global corporate interests and the **"policy space"** that developing states need to regulate digital trade.
- **Institutional Deadlock:** The absence of a functional Appellate Body has shifted the WTO from a "rules-based" to a **"power-based" negotiation system**.

Implications of the WTO Crisis

- **Weakening Multilateralism:** The decline of the WTO reduces faith in **collective trade rules**. E.g., the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership sets trade rules outside the WTO framework.
- **Rising Protectionism:** Nations **impose tariffs** and **restrictions** to protect domestic industries. E.g., the U.S.–China trade war saw repeated tariff hikes outside WTO discipline.

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- **Developing Marginalisation:** Smaller economies **lose bargaining power** in the absence of strict multilateral rules. E.g., African countries face unequal terms in EU–Africa trade deals.
- **Power-Based Order:** Global trade shifts from rules to economic strength. E.g., U.S. sanctions on Iran restrict global trade participation.
- **Economic Instability**: Uncertainty in trade rules **disrupts global markets** and **supply chains**. E.g., the Russia–Ukraine war disrupted global wheat and energy trade flows.

Way Forward: Structural and Functional Reforms

- ✓ **Decision Reform:** Move from strict consensus to **flexible consensus or critical mass approach**.
- ✓ **Dispute Revival:** Restore Appellate Body for binding and timely dispute resolution.
- ✓ **Plurilateral Regulation:** Create legal safeguards for **integrating plurilateral** deals into the WTO, ensuring inclusivity and transparency.
- ✓ **Digital Reforms:** Develop comprehensive WTO frameworks for digital trade & e-commerce governance.
- ✓ **Protect Core Principles:** Safeguard **MFN and Special & Differential Treatment** against dilution by developed nations.

{IR – Organisation} World Health Organisation

❖ **Context (TH):** The US, under Trump, signed an executive order to exit WHO, citing COVID-19 mishandling and needed reforms.

About World Health Organisation (WHO)

- **WHO** is a **specialised agency of the UN** responsible for international public health.
- It was established on **7 April 1948**. The day is now being celebrated every year as **World Health Day.**
- **Headquarters: Geneva, Switzerland**.
- The **World Health Report (WHR)** is a series of **annual** reports produced by the WHO.
- Upon the US withdrawl, it will have **193 members** (**including India**). All UN member states **except** for **Liechtenstein** (192 countries), plus **Cook Island** and **Niue**.
- It became the **first specialised agency of the UN to which every member subscribed.**

Objectives and Functions of WHO

- Lead global efforts to expand **universal health coverage**.
- Focus on the areas of **disease prevention, control and elimination**, and the promotion of health equity and well-being.
- Provide **leadership on global health issues**, set standards for public health, and provide technical assistance and support for capacity building to countries.
- **Collaborate** with various partners, including other UN agencies, governments, civil society organizations, and the private sector.
- Enhance **global preparedness** and response to health emergencies.
- Set global **health standards and guidelines by facilitating health research** and policy development.
- **Monitor emerging health issues** and coordinate responses.

Challenges for Global Health Governance

➢ **Funding Uncertainty:** WHO relies heavily on voluntary contributions, which are unpredictable.

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- **Underrepresentation of Global South:** Developing nations often receive insufficient funding.
- **Dependency on High-Income Nations:** WHO's programs are largely influenced by Western donors.
- **Need for Institutional Reforms:** Addressing inefficiencies, increasing transparency, and decentralising decision-making.

Reasons for US Withdrawal

- **Mishandling of COVID-19 Pandemic:** WHO's delayed response and alleged failure to hold China accountable.
- **Perceived Political Bias:** Accusations of WHO favouring certain member states.
- **Financial Burden:** The US contributed nearly $1.3 billion in voluntary funding (2022-2023), a significantly higher amount than other nations.
- **Bureaucratic Inefficiencies:** Concerns over slow decision-making and lack of reforms.

Impact of US Exit

On WHO

- **Funding Shortfall:** The US provides nearly **20% of WHO's budget**, affecting global health programs.
- **Disruptions in Health Initiatives:** Programs like immunisation, polio eradication, and pandemic preparedness may suffer.
- **Reduced Technical Expertise:** Loss of the US collaborations, including those with the CDC.
- **Challenges in Reform Implementation:** Reduced influence may **slow down institutional reforms**.

On Global Health Landscape

- **Financial Gap:** Developing nations reliant on WHO funding may face difficulties.
- **Geopolitical Shifts:** China and other emerging economies could gain greater influence.
- **Potential Fragmentation:** Alternative alliances or funding mechanisms may emerge outside WHO.

On the US

- **Limited Access to Global Health Data:** Loss of real-time updates on pandemics and emerging diseases.
- **Vaccine Preparedness Issues:** Challenges in accessing strain samples critical for vaccine development.
- **Reduced Global Influence:** Diminished role in shaping international health policies.

Opportunities for the Global South

- **Increased Role in Global Health Governance:** Countries like India, Brazil, and South Africa can step up contributions. Platforms like BRICS can supplement WHO funding and expertise.
- **Investment in Public Health:** Training professionals to reduce reliance on Western experts.
- **Decentralizing WHO's Structure:** Relocating WHO HQ to Asia or Africa for better resource allocation.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Diversified Funding Mechanisms:** Encourage more nations to contribute to WHO's budget to reduce dependency on a few donors.
- ✓ **Strengthening WHO's Credibility:** Implementing transparency and accountability measures.
- ✓ **Collaborative Health Frameworks:** Developing alternative funding sources and technical collaborations.
- ✓ **Reintegration of US:** Possibility of future US re-engagement under a new administration.

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{IR – Organisations} Commonwealth

❖ **Context (IE):** The **Commonwealth** is a voluntary association of **56 independent nations** promoting democracy, development, peace, trade, and cultural cooperation across continents.

What is the Commonwealth?

- **Established:** Formed through the **London Declaration** (**1949**), evolving from the **Balfour Declaration** (**1926**) into a voluntary association.
- **Membership:** Comprises **56 nations**; **India** is a founding, most populous member, while **Nauru** is the smallest.
- **Structure:** Symbolically headed by **King Charles III**, with the **Commonwealth Secretariat** headquartered at **Marlborough House, London**.
- **Functions:** Promotes **democracy, human rights, sustainable development, peace, economic cooperation, and cultural collaboration** among member states.
- **Commonwealth Games:** A **quadrennial multi-sport event**; **Glasgow** will host the **2026 Commonwealth Games**.

Major Achievements of the Commonwealth

- **Ending Apartheid Regime:** Commonwealth leaders agreed on a programme of **economic sanctions** against apartheid-era **South Africa** in 1986.
- **Promoting Development:** The Commonwealth Secretariat's **Economic Development Programme** aims to assist member states to take advantage of opportunities for economic growth.
  - ❖ **Commonwealth Fund for Technical Co-operation** (CFTC) delivers technical assistance.
- **Preventing Extremism:** The Commonwealth Secretariat **Countering Violent Extremism** (CVE) Unit works with Commonwealth member countries to prevent violent extremism and counter terrorism.
- **Environmental:** **Commonwealth Clean Ocean Alliance**, Commonwealth Blue charter project, etc.
- **Climate Change:** **Commonwealth Climate Finance Access Hub** (CCFAH) helps small and other vulnerable states secure funding to tackle climate change-related issues.

Challenges

➢ **Poverty:** Within the Commonwealth, 1/3rd of its population, around 2 billion people, live on less than US$1 per day. This number was worsened by the **COVID-19 pandemic**.
➢ **Social inequality:** Women account for more than 70% of the poor in the Commonwealth and face **discrimination** in many parts of the organisation, ranging from **unequal pay** to abusive treatment.
➢ **Health:** Around **60%** lack essential medicines or sanitation; the Commonwealth accounts for **over 60% of global HIV infections**.
➢ **Climate Change:** **Thirty-two small states** face severe climate risks, with limited resources for adaptation and resilience.

Way Forward

✓ **Expand Membership Outreach:** Strengthen partnerships with non-traditional allies and emerging economies to enhance geopolitical and economic relevance.
✓ **Reduce Inequalities:** Implement targeted policies to eliminate gender pay disparities, empower women, and foster youth-led entrepreneurship.

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- ✓ **Strengthening Economic & Trade Cooperation:** Facilitate intra-Commonwealth trade by reducing tariffs, promoting digital trade, and supporting small economies for inclusive growth.
- ✓ **Improve Public Health Initiatives:** Scale up affordable healthcare programs with a focus on HIV/AIDS prevention, maternal health, and pandemic preparedness to improve well-being.
- ✓ **Enhance Climate Resilience in Small States:** Expand access to climate finance through the Commonwealth Climate Finance Access Hub and reinforce the Blue Charter Project to conserve marine ecosystems.

{IR – Multilateralism & Global Governance – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. In light of the recent withdrawals from the World Health Organization (WHO), discuss the potential rise of regional health alliances and their impact on global health security. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the withdrawal of these nations from the WHO.
- **Body:** Discuss the potential rise of the regional health alliances and the impacts on global health security.
- **Conclusion**: Write a way forward and a conclusion highlighting the relevance of regional health alliances.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- The withdrawals of the **United States** and **Argentina** from the **WHO** highlight dissatisfaction with its structure, potentially leading to the rise of regional health alliances like **BRICS** & **African Union**. These groups could offer more localised approaches to health security, focusing on region-specific challenges.

Potential Rise of Regional Health Alliances

- **Regional Cooperation:** Alliances such as BRICS and the African Union can drive regional integration, **allowing for tailored health solutions** that are more responsive to local needs.
- **Focused Health Priorities:** These alliances can direct resources and research toward diseases specific to their regions, ensuring that neglected health issues receive attention, especially in low-income countries.
- **Private Sector Engagement:** By collaborating with the private sector, **regional initiatives** can **promote localised innovations** and more efficient solutions suited to regional health challenges.

Impact on Global Health Security

- **Fragmentation Risks:** A shift towards regional health systems may lead to fragmented policies, slowing global response efforts to pandemics and health crises.
- **Decreased WHO Influence:** As regional alliances gain influence, the role of WHO could diminish, weakening global health coordination, particularly in addressing cross-border health threats.
- **Complementary Solutions:** Despite these risks, regional alliances can complement WHO's efforts by offering diverse, region-specific approaches, enhancing the overall global health framework.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Strengthen Regional Cooperation:** Enhance collaboration among **regional bodies** to ensure consistency and avoid fragmentation.
- ✓ **Align with Global Frameworks:** Develop strategies that **complement WHO's global efforts** while addressing regional needs.

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✓ **Focus on Equity:** Ensure regional initiatives **prioritise health inequalities** and improve access to healthcare in underserved areas.

Conclusion

✓ **Regional health alliances** can play a crucial role in addressing localised health challenges, but their success will depend on aligning with global health governance to ensure coordinated, equitable solutions.

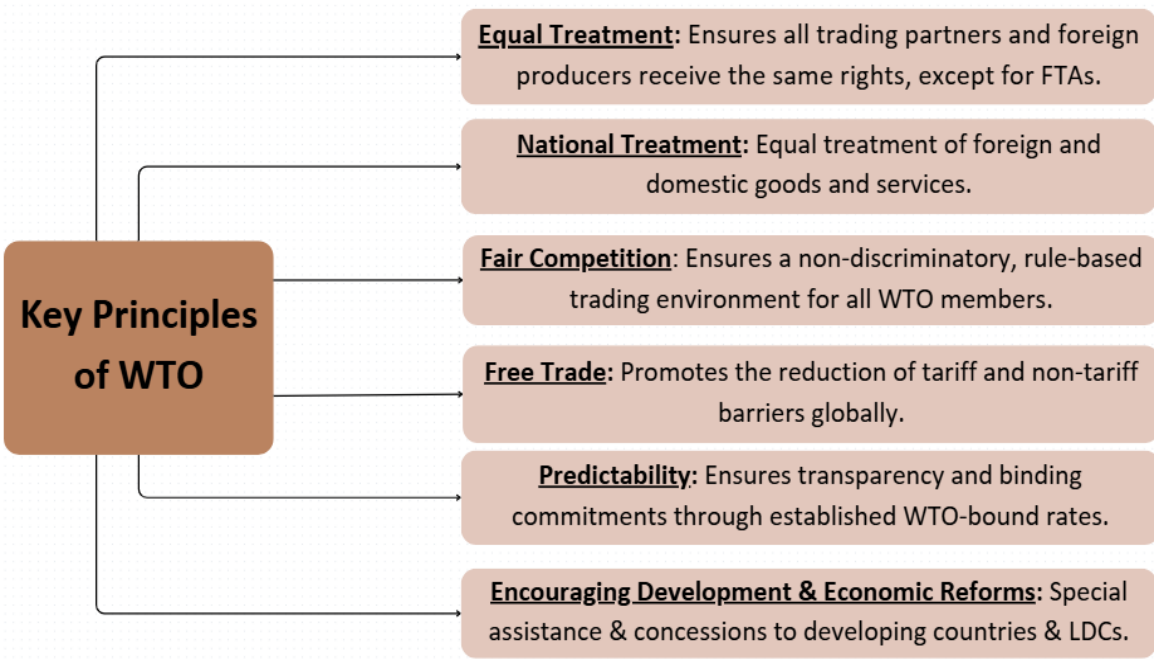
Q. In the wake of the post-MC14 crisis, what structural and functional reforms are necessary to revitalise the WTO, particularly in safeguarding India's trade and development interests? (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the WTO crisis post-MC14 crisis.
- **Body:** Write WTO's post-MC14 crisis challenges and mention that structural and functional reforms are necessary to revitalise the WTO.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on a coordinated and rule-based approach to safeguarding India's trade and development interests.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- The post-MC14 crisis has exposed the WTO's weaknesses, as **rising unilateralism** & **deadlocked decision-making** threaten global trade stability, making reforms crucial to safeguard India's trade interests.



Key Challenges in the Post-MC14 Context

➢ **Consensus Deadlock: Paralysis in decision-making** delays crucial WTO reforms. E.g., MC14 failed to issue a ministerial declaration.

➢ **Dispute Paralysis: Non-functional Appellate Body** undermines enforcement. E.g., the pending India–U.S. steel dispute has remained unresolved since 2019.

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- **Geopolitical Fragmentation:** Rising trade wars, sanctions, and **"friend-shoring"** weaken multilateralism. E.g., U.S.–China tariff conflicts and regional trade blocs like RCEP bypass the WTO.
- **Outdated Rules:** WTO lacks frameworks for **digital trade and data governance**. E.g., no clear rules on taxing digital transactions after the e-commerce moratorium lapsed.

Structural Reforms

- ✓ **Decision Reform:** Move to **flexible consensus**, preventing deadlock while protecting developing countries' inclusivity, like India.
- ✓ **Dispute Revival:** Restore Appellate Body with binding, time-bound rulings to protect India's trade.
- ✓ **Plurilateral Regulation:** Integrate **Joint Statement Initiatives** (JSI) transparently within the WTO to protect India's strategic and developmental priorities.

Functional Reforms

- ✓ **Digital Governance: Establish e-commerce and digital taxation rules** to safeguard India's digital sovereignty and policy space.
- ✓ **S&DT Reform: Introduce flexible, objective criteria** to safeguard India's development & food security.
- ✓ **Agriculture Security:** Ensure permanent **Public Stockholding** (**PSH**) solutions and curb trade-distorting subsidies by developed nations.

Conclusion

- Revitalising the WTO demands **structural and functional reforms** to strengthen dispute resolution & protect developing nations, ensuring India's trade & development interests in a **fair, rules-based system**.

Q. The credibility of the United Nations is being increasingly questioned due to its structural paralysis and limited representativeness. Analyse this statement in light of India's demand for comprehensive UN reforms. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a contextual introduction by mentioning the current example.
- **Body:** Analyse the credibility challenges of the United Nations and mention India's demand for comprehensive UN reforms.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on UN reform by mentioning the Pact for the Future.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- "The UN's delayed response to crises like **Ukraine** and **Yemen** highlights its shortcomings; at **UNGA 80**, India stressed the need for reforms for greater representation and effectiveness.

Credibility Challenges of the United Nations

- ➢ **Veto Paralysis: P5 veto** blocked decisive action in the Syrian civil war (2011–present).
- ➢ **Bureaucracy Lag:** UN delays hindered peacekeeping during the **Rwanda genocide** (1994).
- ➢ **Power Imbalance:** India, Brazil, Germany, and Japan lack permanent UNSC representation.
- ➢ **Rights Failure:** UN response to the Rohingya crisis in Myanmar was **slow** and **politicised**.

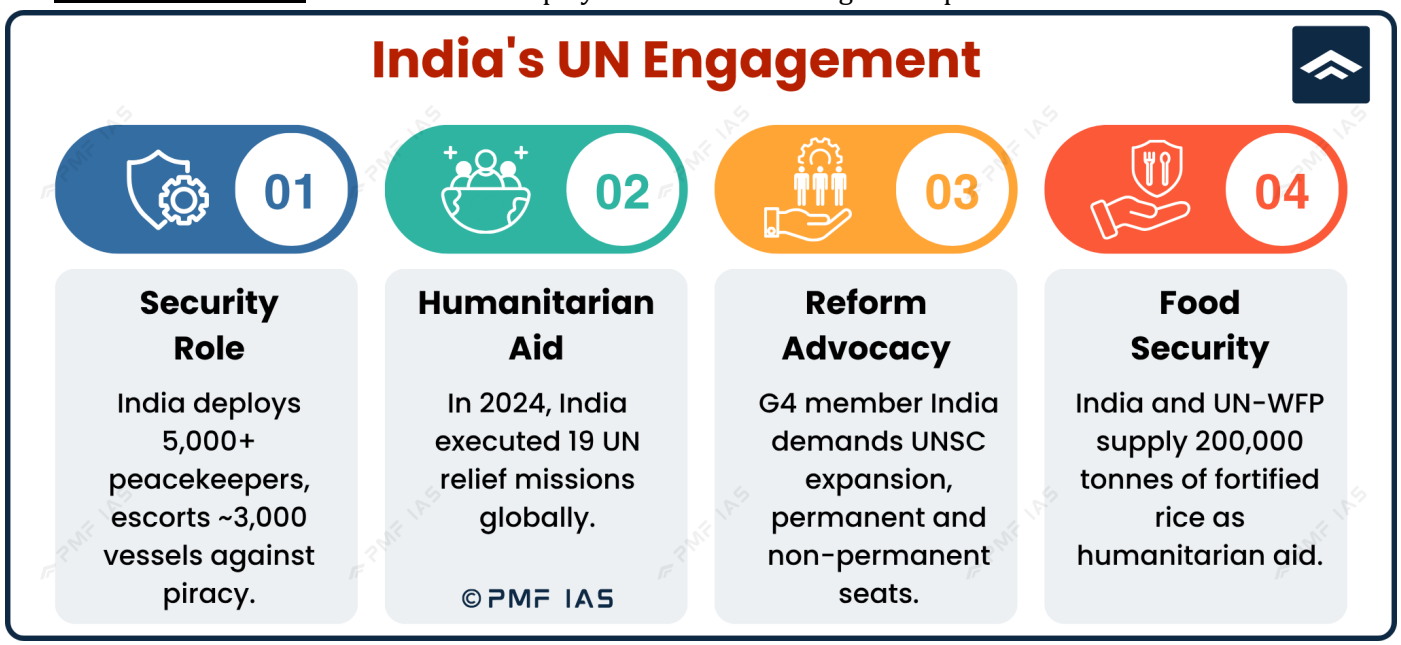
India's Demand for UN Reforms

- ✓ **Permanent Membership: India seeks a UNSC seat** representing 21% global population.

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- ✓ **Inclusivity:** Inclusion of Africa, Asia, and Latin America, covering **80% underrepresented members**.
- ✓ **Transparency:** Reform peacekeeping and budgets. E.g., India contributes ~8% UN peacekeeping funds.
- ✓ **Merit-based Roles:** Promote leadership by merit. India held eight non-permanent UNSC seats.



Conclusion

- "India's UN reform push, including **permanent membership** and **expanded representation**, along with the '**Pact for the Future,**' aims to strengthen legitimacy, effectiveness, and inclusive multilateral global governance.

-------- End of Chapter --------

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Maritime Security & Geoeconomics

{IR – Issue} Maritime Governance

❖ **Context (TH):** Escalating Iran–US maritime confrontations in the Strait of Hormuz, including **ship seizures** & **detentions**, strain international waters governance under UNCLOS.

Legal Framework of International Waters

- **UNCLOS Basis:** International waters are governed by the **United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea** (**UNCLOS 1982**), which treats oceans as a **global common** beyond national jurisdiction.
- **High Seas:** Areas beyond **Exclusive Economic Zone** (**EEZ**) where all states enjoy **freedom of navigation** without sovereign control.
- **Territorial Waters:** Extending up to **12 nautical miles**, where coastal states **exercise sovereignty** but allow **"innocent passage"** of foreign vessels.
- **International Straits:** Strategic waterways governed by the **transit passage regime** ensuring continuous and unhindered navigation.

Strait of Hormuz Maritime Crisis Escalation

- **Traffic Control:** Post-war ship movement collapsed sharply as Iran imposed **transit restrictions** and **high tolls**, driven by geopolitical considerations.
- **India Benefit:** India gained an advantage as Iran allowed selected **Indian-flagged energy shipments** to pass without reported toll payments.
- **US Action:** The U.S. enforced a **de facto blockade** by issuing **warnings and seizing vessels** targeting Iranian-linked ships in international waters.
- **Iran Response:** Iran retaliated by **firing at, detaining, and capturing** commercial vessels, escalating maritime tensions in the Strait.
- **Legal Conflict:** **Unilateral sanctions** and **seizures** under domestic law created major disputes with **international maritime law** and **UNCLOS principles**.

Maritime Security Threats

➢ **Selective Enforcement:** Powerful states apply **maritime laws unevenly**, weakening UNCLOS despite governing over **60% of global trade**.

➢ **Economic Coercion:** **Sanctions and blockades** affect nearly **30% of oil trade routes**, increasing geopolitical and supply risks.

➢ **Maritime Incidents:** **Over 150 naval confrontations** and **ship seizures** have been reported globally in disputed waters recently.

➢ **Chokepoint Risks:** The Strait of Hormuz alone carries **~20% of global oil trade**, making it highly vulnerable to disruptions from conflict.

Enhancing Ocean Governance Mechanisms

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- ✓ **Rules-Based Order:** **Strengthen UNCLOS compliance** as **~80% of global trade** moves by sea, ensuring freedom of navigation in chokepoints.
- ✓ **Multilateral Action:** Empower the **International Maritime Organisation** (**IMO**) & **UN mechanisms**, overseeing the safety of **over 100,000** merchant ships globally, to mediate maritime disputes effectively.
- ✓ **De-escalation Measures:** **Promote diplomacy** as Strait of Hormuz disruptions can impact **17–20 million barrels of oil daily**, affecting global energy stability.
- ✓ **Legal Enforcement:** **Strengthen UNCLOS arbitration** using precedents like the **2016 South China Sea ruling** to curb unlawful blockades and seizures.

Read More > *Strait of Hormuz Crisis and Its Implications for India*

{IR – Asia} Indian Ocean Geopolitics **

❖ **Context (IE):** India, along with Singapore and Oman, is hosting the 8th Indian Ocean Conference (IOC) in Muscat to discuss regional security and economic cooperation.

Historical Significance of the Indian Ocean

- **Naming & Cultural Influence:** Named after India due to its historical and cultural dominance; known as "Hind Mahasagar" for centuries.
- **Ancient Trade Networks:** Indian merchants like the **Manigramam Chettis** and **Nanadesis** engaged in extensive trade with Arab and Southeast Asian regions.
- **Maritime Presence in Texts:** Kautilya's **Arthashastra** emphasized maritime trade; Chinese traveler **Fa-Hien** recorded India's naval strength in 415 CE.
- **Colonial Disruption:** India lost its maritime dominance to European colonial powers like the Portuguese, Dutch, French, and British.

India's Historical Neglect of Maritime Power

- **Colonial Legacy:** The British, despite their naval dominance, did not develop a blue-water navy for India.
- **Post-Independence Priorities:** Leadership prioritized land-based threats, neglecting maritime strategy.
- **Shipbuilding Lag:** India ranks 20th in the global shipbuilding industry, with just 0.06% market share.
- **Strategic Oversight:** K M Panikkar (1945) warned that India's security and trade relied on naval power, **but policies** remained land-focused.

Strategic Importance of the Indian Ocean Today

- **Global Trade Hub:** Facilitates **70% of global container traffic**, **80% of India's external trade**, and **90% of its energy imports**.
- **Access for Landlocked Nations:** Vital trade route for Nepal and Bhutan.
- **Cultural and Trade Nexus:** Unlike the geopolitically tense Indo-Pacific, the Indian Ocean fosters economic and cultural ties.

Emerging Challenges in the Indian Ocean

- ➢ **Big Power Rivalry:** US, UK, France & China have significant naval presence, creating security complexities.
- ➢ **Maritime Security Threats:** Includes piracy, sea-borne terrorism, illegal fishing, arms trafficking, and climate-induced crises.

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➢ **Undersea Network Control:** European firms and China's Huawei dominate critical undersea communication cables.

India's Maritime Strategy and Initiatives

- **SAGAR Initiative (2015):** Ensures **Security And Growth for All in the Region** through stability and economic cooperation.
- **Blue-Water Policy:** India is working toward establishing itself as a dominant naval power and voice of the Global South.
- **Strategic Partnerships:** Strengthening naval and diplomatic ties with key nations like Oman and Singapore for regional security.
- **Indian Ocean Conference (IOC):** A strategic platform for regional collaboration, ensuring collective control over maritime security.

Way Forward

✓ **Strengthening Naval Infrastructure:** Invest in shipbuilding, naval expansion, and maritime surveillance.
✓ **Enhancing Regional Cooperation:** Deepen engagement with IORA, QUAD, and BIMSTEC for collective security and governance.
✓ **Boosting Blue Economy:** Sustainable fisheries, ocean-based industries & clean energy solutions.
✓ **Countering External Influence:** Safeguard undersea communication network & regional trade interests.
✓ **Climate Resilience & Disaster Preparedness:** Develop early warning systems and relief mechanisms for climate-induced disasters.

{IR – Issues} India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) *

❖ **Context (TH):** The **West Asian conflict** post-October 2023 and shifting global trade routes (like the Arctic passage) have raised concerns about IMEC's viability and strategic direction.

About IMEC

- **About:** IMEC is a multi-modal connectivity project linking India, the Gulf, and Europe, announced at G20 2023, New Delhi, to counter BRI and boost supply chain resilience.
- **Components:** It has two corridors.
  - ❖ **Eastern Corridor:** Connects India to the Gulf region.
  - ❖ **Northern Corridor:** Connects the Gulf region to Europe.
- **Background:** The **Abraham Accords** created the diplomatic climate that enabled regional cooperation and paved the way for IMEC.
  - ❖ **Abraham Accords (2020):** A set of agreements normalising Israel–Arab ties and enabling cooperation frameworks like **I2U2**.
- **PGII Link:** IMEC forms part of the Partnership for Global Infrastructure and Investment framework.
  - ❖ PGII**:** A G7 developmental initiative, announced in 2021, to narrow the infrastructure gap in developing countries by promoting sustainable, transparent, and resilient infrastructure.
  - ❖ **Similar Initiatives: European Union Global Gateway**, **Blue Dot Network**, and **the Build Back Better World** (**B3W**) Initiative.

Significance of IMEC for India

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- **Trade Boost:** IMEC cuts India-Europe transit by **40%** and costs by **30%,** enhancing trade.
- **Energy Access:** Connects to Eastern Mediterranean gas fields, strengthening energy security.
- **Geopolitical Edge:** Counters China's BRI, asserting India's strategic presence in Eurasia.
- **Investment Scope:** Opens opportunities for Indian firms in ports, railways, and logistics.
- **Route Diversification:** Complements **Chabahar** and **INSTC**, enabling multi-directional connectivity.

Challenges Faced by the IMEC Project

- **West Asia Conflict:** Gaza war and **Israel–Arab tensions** disrupt project timelines and trust.
- **Security Risks:** **Houthi attacks** in the Red Sea raise maritime vulnerability.
- **Infrastructure Gaps:** Missing multimodal links across the **Saudi Arabia–Jordan–Israel** route.
- **Funding & Implementation:** Absence of a dedicated financing framework like AIIB or NDB.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Adaptive Routing:** Explore **alternate ports** (**Jeddah**, **Dammam**, **Suez**) to bypass conflict zones (align with **IMO safety routes 2025**).
- ✓ **Multilateral Financing:** Establish **IMEC Fund** under **G20 India–EU Partnership**.
- ✓ **Green Corridor Development:** Link with the EU's Global Gateway Green Energy Projects and India's National Green Hydrogen Mission.
- ✓ **Institutional Mechanism:** Formalise IMEC Secretariat under G20's **Connectivity Agenda 2030**.

Read More> IMEC

{IR – Bilateral } UAE-India Corridor

❖ **Context (TH):** The **UAE-India corridor** is driving strategic growth through aligned policy, capital, and technology. This partnership exemplifies how shared vision fuels global economic opportunities.

Current Status

- **Trade Milestone:** **Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA)** 2022 target of $100B bilateral trade by 2030 achieved **five years early**; new target set at **$200B by 2032**.
- **Non-Oil Growth:** Non-oil trade rose **20%** last year to **$65B**, reflecting economic diversification beyond energy.
- **Investment Flow:** Since 2000, the UAE invested **$22B** in India, while India invested **$16B** there.
- **Diaspora Backbone:** Nearly **5 million Indians** in the UAE, enabling over **1,200 weekly flights**.

Strategic Significance

- **Sector Expansion:** Corridor is being reshaped by **advanced manufacturing, financial services, technology, and logistics**.
- **Industrial Projects:** **Reliance-TA'ZIZ $2B** low-carbon chemicals, **Ashok Leyland** shifted electric bus production to the UAE, and **L&T** Abu Dhabi solar-plus-storage.
- **Financial Integration:** **Emirates National Bank of Dubai (NBD's)** acquisition of **RBL Bank** is the largest FDI in Indian banking, & **DP World** has committed an additional **$5 billion** to Indian infrastructure.
- **Regional Platform:** **Bharat Mart** will serve Africa, West Asia, and Eurasia, doubling India's exports to these regions.

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Bilateral Cooperation

- **Policy Architecture:** CEPA removed **~90% tariffs**, and the **2024 Bilateral Investment Treaty** ensures investor certainty.
- **Technology Partnership:** India-UAE collaborate on **AI, data centres, and digital infrastructure**, with India hosting the **Global South AI Summit 2026**.
- **Energy Collaboration:** **Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC)** signed **multi-billion-dollar LNG agreements** with Indian Oil and HPCL.
- **Long-Term Commitment:** **Mubadala** deployed **$4B** in Indian health, renewables, and tech and **Abu Dhabi Investment Authority** is based in GIFT City.

Cooperation Challenges

- **Geo Tensions:** **Regional instability** & **shifting Middle East alliances** affect investment certainty.
- **Regulatory Differences:** Divergent labour, taxation, and compliance standards require harmonisation for smooth operations.
- **Technology Gaps:** AI and advanced manufacturing demand local talent and infrastructure, posing **implementation challenges**.
- **Trade Reliance:** **Overdependence on the corridor** for certain exports could create **vulnerability to external shocks**.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Capacity Building:** Joint digital infrastructure and skill development in Africa to enhance the corridor's global impact.
- ✓ **Investment Diversification:** **Encourage sectoral expansion** beyond energy and logistics to AI, renewables, and healthcare.
- ✓ **Policy Alignment:** Strengthen legal, tax, and investment frameworks to reduce compliance friction.
- ✓ **Innovation Leadership:** **Focus on AI** and **advanced technologies** to make the corridor a model for Global South partnerships.

{IR – Issue} India's Balancing Act in the Bay of Bengal **

❖ **Context (TH):** India's maritime ambitions in the **Bay of Bengal** face challenges despite progress in relations in the near neighbourhood.

Significance of Bay of Bengal for India

- **Trade & Connectivity:** Vital maritime corridor **linking South Asia & Southeast Asia**. Enables port development & regional integration through logistics & infrastructure.
- **Geopolitical Influence:** Enhances India's leadership role in regional platforms like BIMSTEC. Counters external influence, particularly China's maritime footprint.
- **Energy:** Rich in **oil, gas** & **fisheries** are essential for India's economic & energy security.
- **Security & Stability:** India plays a central role in **tackling piracy, trafficking, illegal fishing** & other **maritime threats**.
- **Environmental Importance:** Coastal biodiversity & ecosystems are critical for disaster resilience given the vulnerability of Bay of Bengal to cyclones, rising sea levels & erosion.

India's Balancing Act

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- **Security Architecture**: Eastern Naval Command & Andaman Tri-Service Command bolster India's eastern maritime defense.
  - ❖ MILAN Naval Exercises enhance interoperability with Southeast Asian & Western navies.
  - ❖ IORA**:** Promotes cooperative maritime governance and environmental protection.
  - ❖ **QUAD:** Reinforces India's commitment to freedom of navigation and rule-based maritime order.
- **Economic Engagement:**
  - ❖ **Act East Policy:** Boosts trade, investment, and infrastructure with Southeast Asian countries.
  - ❖ **SAGAR Initiative:** Focus on security, economic development & cooperation in Indian Ocean Region.
- **Regional Connectivity & Trade:**
  - ❖ **BBIN & BIMSTEC frameworks:** Boost economic corridors, energy, and transport connectivity.
  - ❖ BIMSTEC **Maritime Transport Agreement:** Enhances port-led growth and shipping integration.
  - ❖ Projects like Kaladan Multimodal Transit (India-Myanmar) & India-Bangladesh coastal shipping strengthen linkages.
  - ❖ Sagarmala**:** Modernises ports, improves logistics, boosts coastal economic zones.
- **Environmental Diplomacy:** Promotes Blue Economy, sustainable development & disaster resilience. Support for green shipping corridors, renewable energy, especially in Maldives and island nations.

Key Government Initiatives Driving India's Role in the Bay of Bengal

- **SAGAR Vision:** India's strategic doctrine to ensure maritime security and regional cooperation across the Indian Ocean Region.
- **Act East Policy:** Deepens economic, infrastructural, and diplomatic ties with Southeast Asia via Bay of Bengal connectivity.
- **Sagarmala Programme:** Modernises eastern ports and boosts coastal logistics to integrate India's eastern maritime economy.
- **BIMSTEC Maritime Transport Agreement:** Enhances regional port connectivity, reduces logistics costs, and facilitates trade harmonisation.
- **Kaladan Multimodal Transit Project:** Links Kolkata to Sittwe Port in Myanmar, strengthening access to Northeast India and ASEAN.
- **MILAN Naval Exercises:** Promotes maritime cooperation and interoperability with Southeast Asian and Indo-Pacific navies.
- **Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA):** Supports maritime governance, blue economy, and disaster resilience through regional partnerships.

Challenges

- ➢ **Geopolitical Competition**: China's ports in **Kyaukpyu (Myanmar), Hambantota (Sri Lanka), Chittagong (Bangladesh)** challenge Indian dominance.
- ➢ **Maritime Threats**: Rising threats from piracy, smuggling, illegal fishing & arms/drug trafficking.
- ➢ **Policy Inconsistency**: India's withdrawal of transhipment facilities to Bangladesh highlights unpredictable trade policies.
- ➢ **Vulnerabilities**: Prone to climate change, cyclones, erosion, affecting regional stability & livelihoods.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Multilateralism:** Promote a **rules-based regional order** to enhance India's credibility.
- ✓ **Trade Policies:** Ensure consistent engagement with neighbours like Bangladesh & Myanmar.

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- ✓ **Joint Infrastructure:** Collaborate on ports, digital connectivity & energy grids.
- ✓ **Climate Resilience:** Invest in shared infrastructure for early warning systems, sustainable fisheries & coastal protection.
- ✓ **Balanced Cooperation:** Promote joint patrols & exercises without infringing on partners' sovereignty.

{IR – Issue} Strait of Hormuz Crisis **

❖ **Context (IE):** Escalating Iran-US-Israel tensions threaten the **Strait of Hormuz**, a vital energy corridor, creating risks for **India's oil and gas supply and prices**.

About the Strait of Hormuz

- Strait of Hormuz lies between **Iran** (north) and **Oman's Musandam Peninsula** (south), linking the **Persian Gulf** to the **Gulf of Oman** and the **Arabian Sea**.
- It is the **world's most critical energy chokepoint** and the sole maritime exit for the Persian Gulf.
- **Energy Transit:** Nearly **20% of global oil supply** and **one-fifth of global LNG trade** (mainly from **Qatar**) pass through it.
- **Fertiliser Trade:** Around **one-third of global fertiliser exports** transit this route.
- **Alternative Routes:** **Saudi Arabia's East–West Pipeline** and the **UAE's Fujairah Pipeline** provide the only bypass options.
  - ❖ **Capacity Gap:** Their **combined unused capacity** of 2.6 million bpd can **offset only 13%** of the total Hormuz oil transit.

Primary Causes of the Strait Crisis

- **Military Strikes:** **Israel and the US attacks on Iran** escalated regional tensions, prompting Tehran to threaten Gulf oil transit routes.
- **Geopolitical Retaliation:** **Iran's response to Western actions**, including warnings from the Iranian Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), **disrupted vessel movements** and **raised supply risks**.
- **Supply Vulnerability:** Heavy dependence on the Strait of Hormuz for crude, LPG, and LNG imports **exposed global and Indian energy flows to potential disruption**.

India's Dependence on the Strait of Hormuz

- **Crude Oil:** About **50% of India's crude imports**, nearly **2.5 million barrels per day**, transit the Strait of Hormuz. India is the **third-largest crude consumer globally**, with an import dependency of **over 88%**.
- **LPG Imports:** Around **80–85% of India's LPG** comes via the Strait, with minimal strategic reserves.
- **LNG Imports:** About **60% of LNG** imports rely on this route; structural buffers are lacking.
- **Strategic Petroleum Reserves:** India maintains **~10 days of crude stocks** and **~1 week of fuel stocks**, which can mitigate short-term shocks.

Implications for India's Energy Security

- **Crude Risk:** Half of India's crude imports (**2.5–2.7 million bpd**) transit the Strait of Hormuz, threatening supply continuity.
- **Price Volatility:** Brent crude spiked above **$82/barrel**. E.g., even a **$1 rise increases India's annual import bill by $1.8–2 billion**.

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- **Short-Term Shock:** With only **one week of LPG stocks and minimal LNG reserves**, India faces high vulnerability to supply disruptions from the Strait of Hormuz.
- **Price Volatility:** Any disruption could spike global energy prices, impacting India's **88% oil import dependency** and fuel affordability.

Strategic Safeguards for India's Energy Security

- ✓ **Strategic Reserves:** India's **Strategic Petroleum Reserve**, with a capacity of **5.33 million tonnes**, provides **about 9.5 days** of net import cover.
  - ❖ **Total Cover:** Combined with commercial stocks, India's total crude oil cover stands at roughly **75 days**, below the IEA-recommended **90-day buffer**.
- ✓ **Russia Pivot:** India can absorb **discounted Russian crude** delivered via sea routes that entirely bypass the Strait of Hormuz.
- ✓ **Source Diversification:** Spot purchases from the **USA**, **West Africa**, and **Latin America** can offset disrupted Gulf supplies.
- ✓ **Pipeline Access:** Commercial arrangements can allow access to **Saudi Arabia's East-West Pipeline** and the **UAE's Fujairah Pipeline**.
- ✓ **Naval Security:** The Indian Navy maintains escort operations in the **Gulf of Oman** under Operation Sankalp to protect Indian-flagged vessels.

{IR – Maritime Security & Geoeconomics – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. The Strait of Hormuz is a vital gateway for India's crude oil and LNG imports. Analyse the implications of disruptions for India's energy security and economic stability. Suggest measures to mitigate these risks. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the Strait of Hormuz and its importance for India.
- **Body:** Write the importance of the Strait of Hormuz for India's crude oil and LNG imports, implications of disruptions for India's energy security, and suggest measures to mitigate these risks.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on the storage and diversified import approach to ensure supply continuity and economic stability.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- The **Strait of Hormuz**, a critical global energy chokepoint, handles nearly **half of India's crude** and **major LNG imports**, making disruptions a significant threat to energy security and economic stability.

The Strait of Hormuz is a Vital Gateway for India's Crude Oil and LNG Imports

- **Maritime Chokepoint:** Connects the **Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman** and Arabian Sea, vital for global energy transit.
- **Crude Dependency:** Nearly **50%** of India's crude imports (**≈2.5–2.7 million bpd**) pass through the Strait of Hormuz.
- **Gas Reliance:** About **80–85% of LPG** and **60% of LNG** imports depend on this corridor.
- **Energy Vulnerability:** India, the **third-largest crude consumer**, has **88% import dependency**, highlighting the strait's strategic importance.

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Implications of Disruptions

- **Supply Risk:** Limited reserves (**~10 days crude, ~1 week fuel**) make India vulnerable to disruptions.
- **Price Volatility:** A **$1 rise** in Brent crude adds **$1.8–2 billion annually** to import costs.
- **Economic Impact:** Rising energy prices affect inflation, fuel affordability, & agricultural output.
- **Vulnerability:** **Iran-US-Israel tensions** amplify India's exposure to **regional energy instability**.

Measures to Mitigate Risks

- ✓ **Reserves Strength:** Strategic Petroleum Reserve holds **5.33 million tonnes** (**~9.5 days cover**); combined with commercial stocks, total crude coverage ≈is **75 days**.
- ✓ **Source Diversification:** India can **pivot to Russian crude** via alternate routes and procure spot supplies from the USA, West Africa, and Latin America.
- ✓ **Pipeline Access:** **Saudi East-West** and **UAE Fujairah pipelines** partially bypass Hormuz, supplementing crude imports.
- ✓ **Naval Security:** Operation Sankalp ensures Indian-flagged vessel **protection in the Gulf of Oman**, supported by continuous geopolitical monitoring.

Conclusion

- The Strait of Hormuz is a **strategic lifeline** for India's energy security. **Diversification**, **reserves**, **pipelines**, and **naval safeguards** ensure supply continuity and economic stability.

-------- End of Chapter --------

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India's Neighbourhood First Policy

{IR – Diplomacy} Rebooting India's Neighbourhood Policy *

❖ **Context (IE):** Recent political shifts in South Asia, after strained ties and perceived regional setbacks, present India with an opportunity to reboot its **neighbourhood policy**.

About Neighbourhood First Policy

- **Meaning:** It refers to its strategic approach of **prioritising relations with its immediate neighbours**, Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, Maldives, Myanmar, Nepal, Pakistan, & Sri Lanka.
- **Objective:** Enhancing **physical**, **digital** and **people-to-people** connectivity across the region, as well as augmenting trade and commerce.

Geopolitical Instability Around India

- **Myanmar's Military Coup (2021):** The military coup disrupted India's engagement with Myanmar, affecting security cooperation and infrastructure projects.
- **Taliban Takeover in Afghanistan (2021):** Led to instability in Afghanistan, raising concerns about terrorism, regional security, and India's investments in Afghan infrastructure.
- **Political Instability in Sri Lanka (2022):** Led to the ousting of President Gotabaya Rajapaksa, affecting India's interests in the region, especially with Chinese influence growing in Sri Lanka.
- **Change in Government in Nepal (2022):** Led to a less India-friendly government under K.P. Sharma Oli strained bilateral relations, particularly over border issues and Nepal's increasing closeness to China.
- **Electoral Change in the Maldives (2023):** The electoral defeat of the pro-India government of Ibrahim Solih and the rise of Mohamed Muizzu were perceived as less favourable to India.
- **Shift in Bangladesh's Political Landscape (2023):** The potential departure of Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, a key ally of India, and the rise of opposition forces that may not be as India-friendly.

Significance of India's Neighbourhood First Policy

- **Regional Integration:** Build trust through **concessions** to deepen cooperation. E.g., India–Bangladesh connectivity projects.
- **Security Cooperation:** **Coordinate responses** to threats and resolve disputes. E.g., the Indus Waters Treaty with Pakistan.
- **China Balance:** Strengthen ties to **counter China's influence**. E.g., India's SAGAR vision in the Indian Ocean.
- **Soft Power:** Leverage cultural ties to enhance influence. E.g., Buddhist diplomacy in Southeast Asia.
- **Development Linkages:** Boost regional growth and Northeast integration. E.g., India–Myanmar–Thailand Trilateral Highway.

Changing Regional Landscape

- **Regional Flux:** South Asia is undergoing **political churn**, creating opportunities for India to recalibrate its neighbourhood policy.
- **Bangladesh Shift:** **"Bangladesh First"** approach enables pragmatic, interest-based ties; economic interdependence with India remains strong.

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- **Nepal Transition:** **Generational political change** opens scope for relations based on equality, sovereignty, and mutual respect.
- **Sri Lanka Reset:** Post-crisis leadership is fostering **pragmatic**, **economy-driven engagement**, reducing historical mistrust with India.

Need for Rebooting Neighbourhood Policy

- **Political Engagement:** Work with new governments in **Bangladesh**, **Nepal**, and **Sri Lanka** to build pragmatic partnerships. E.g., Bangladesh's recent elections strengthened India-Bangladesh trade ties.
- **Connectivity Boost:** Strengthen transport, energy, and digital links for mutual benefits. E.g., India–Nepal cross-border railway and **BBIN** energy projects.
- **Partnership Mindset:** Move from **patronage to mutual respect**, shared growth, and visible outcomes. E.g., India-Sri Lanka cooperation on **Palk Strait fisheries** and trade facilitation.

Neighbourhood Connectivity Initiatives

- **Coastal Surveillance Radar System (CSRS)** in neighbouring countries like Sri Lanka, the Maldives, Mauritius, and Seychelles to enhance maritime security.
- **Joint Military Exercises:** Conduct regular joint military exercises such as "**Mitra Shakti**" with Sri Lanka, "**Sampriti**" with Bangladesh, and "**Surya Kiran**" with Nepal.
- **Border Area Development Program (BADP):** Improve infrastructure and security along India's borders with Pakistan, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Bhutan, and Nepal.
- **SAARC Satellite:** Provide satellite-based services to SAARC member countries, including communication, weather forecasting, and disaster management.
- **Vaccine Maitri Initiative:** India supplied COVID-19 vaccines to neighbouring countries, reinforcing its role as a responsible and caring neighbour during the global pandemic.
- **Transport Corridors:**
  - **India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway:** Aimed at enhancing connectivity between India and Southeast Asia, promoting trade and cultural exchange.
  - **Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project:** Aimed at providing an alternative trade route to the northeastern states of India through Myanmar, improving connectivity and economic integration.
  - **BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement:** Involving Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, and Nepal to facilitate seamless movement of passenger and cargo vehicles across borders, promoting regional integration.
  - **Chabahar Port:** development in Iran as a strategic gateway for trade with Afghanistan and Central Asia, bypassing Pakistan.

Key Structural Challenges

- **Protectionist Approach:** India's trade policy remains **inward-looking**, with **tariffs & non-tariff barriers** that limit regional integration. E.g., India–Bangladesh trade **~$13 billion** remains far below potential.
- **Poor Connectivity:** **Weak infrastructure** and **border delays** reduce the benefits of proximity. E.g., despite a **4,096-km border**, logistics bottlenecks persist along India–Bangladesh trade routes.
- **Market Access Gap:** India runs trade surpluses but **restricts imports**, creating an imbalance. E.g., India exports ~$11B to Bangladesh but imports only ~$2B.
- **Outdated Mindset:** Patronage-based approach fuels **resentment** and **strategic drift**. E.g., growing Chinese investments and BRI projects in Sri Lanka and Nepal.

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Transforming India's Neighbourhood Policy Approach

- ✓ **Trade Reforms:** **Reduce barriers** and **expand market access** to ensure balanced regional trade. E.g., increasing imports from Bangladesh.
- ✓ **Equal Partnership:** Replace patronage with **mutual respect** and **interest-based engagement**. E.g., a new approach towards Nepal's leadership.
- ✓ **Regional Value Chains:** Build cross-border production networks for shared growth. E.g., textile and energy cooperation in South Asia.
- ✓ **Energy Cooperation:** Enhance **regional energy security** through supply and grid integration. E.g., India–Bhutan hydropower projects.

{IR – Diplomacy} West Asia Crisis & Neighbourhood Diplomacy *

❖ **Context (TH):** The West Asia conflict and tensions in the Strait of Hormuz disrupt supply lines and diaspora safety, testing India's **neighbourhood diplomacy** and regional coordination.

Significance of West Asia for South Asia

- **Energy Dependence:** South Asian economies rely heavily on **oil and gas imports** from West Asia, making them vulnerable to supply disruptions.
- **Diaspora Presence:** Nearly **25 million** South Asians work in West Asia, generating crucial remittances for regional economies.
- **Trade Routes:** Strategic sea lanes like the **Strait of Hormuz** are vital for South Asia's trade and energy transportation.
- **Supply Chains:** Instability in West Asia disrupts **food**, **fertiliser**, and **commodity** supply chains across South Asia.

India's Diplomatic Stance in the West Asia Conflict

- **Divergent Response:** India's initial reaction differed from neighbours like **Bangladesh and Pakistan**, which quickly condoled **Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's death**.
- **Delayed Diplomacy:** India took five days to send the **Foreign Secretary to the Iranian Embassy** and later expressed grief **over 150 deaths in Minab**.
- **Strategic Alignment:** India's cautious response was linked to **PM Narendra Modi's visit to Israel** and expanding **India–Israel strategic ties.**
- **Balance Challenge:** The crisis tested **India's traditional policy** of **maintaining balanced relations with Israel, Iran, and Gulf countries**.

Implications of West Asia Conflict on India's Neighbourhood Diplomacy

- **Energy Disruptions:** South Asian nations depend heavily on West Asian oil, and instability raises fuel prices and shortages in **Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, and Nepal**.
- **Diaspora Risks:** Nearly **25 million South Asians** (**over 9 million Indians**) in West Asia face safety threats and potential remittance disruptions during conflict.
- **Trade Disruptions:** Tensions around the **Strait of Hormuz**, through which **~20% of global oil** passes, threaten South Asia's trade and supply chains.

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- **Regional Expectations:** Neighbours increasingly expect India to provide **fuel, humanitarian aid, and economic assistance** during crises.
- **Maritime Security Pressure:** Naval tensions in the **Indian Ocean** challenge India's role as a **net security provider** in the region.

India's Strategic Neighbourhood Diplomacy

- **Crisis Support:** India assists neighbours during **economic or supply shocks** from West Asia conflicts. E.g., $4 billion aid to Sri Lanka, 2022.
- **Diaspora Safety:** **Protecting** and **evacuating** South Asian workers in conflict zones tests diplomatic outreach. E.g., **Operation Rahat**, Yemen 2015.
- **Energy Aid:** **Supplying fuel to neighbours** during Gulf oil disruptions strengthens regional ties. E.g., Petroleum exports to Nepal and Bhutan.
- **Humanitarian Coordination:** Leading regional emergency responses demonstrates India's role as a **responsible neighbour**. E.g., **Vaccine Maitri** is supplying COVID-19 vaccines to South Asia.

Challenges to India's Neighbourhood Diplomacy during West Asia Conflicts

- **Energy Risk:** **Gulf oil disruptions** threaten South Asian neighbours. E.g., fuel requests from Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives in March 2026.
- **Diaspora Threat:** Millions of South Asians, including **10 million Indians**, face danger in conflict zones like the **Strait of Hormuz**.
- **Economic Spillover:** Trade, remittances, and essential supplies are disrupted, **straining India's stabilising role** in the region.
- **Diplomatic Balancing:** **Delayed reactions**, like India's stance on **Khamenei's killing**, **risk perceptions of bias** among neighbours and global powers.

Way Forward for Neighbourhood Diplomacy

- ✓ **Regional Engagement:** Strengthen **diplomatic dialogue** and **crisis coordination** with South Asian neighbours during West Asia conflicts. E.g., SAARC COVID-19 virtual summit, 2020.
- ✓ **Energy Cooperation:** Develop **fuel-sharing arrangements**, **strategic reserves**, and **cross-border power grids** to ensure energy security. E.g., India–Bangladesh and India–Nepal electricity trade.
- ✓ **Trade Integration:** Promote regional trade agreements, resilient supply chains, & connectivity projects to reduce dependency on disrupted routes. E.g., Enhancing **intra-SAARC trade below 5%** of total trade.
- ✓ **Diaspora Protection:** **Establish robust evacuation plans** and **diplomatic support mechanisms** for South Asian workers in conflict-affected West Asia. E.g., **Operation Rahat**, Yemen 2015.
- ✓ **Strategic Autonomy:** **Maintain balanced relations** with rival West Asian powers while safeguarding South Asian regional interests. E.g., India's parallel partnerships with Israel, Iran, and Gulf countries.

{IR – India – Nepal} India–Nepal Relations

❖ **Context (TH): Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP)**, led by **Balendra Shah**, secured a landslide victory in Nepal's general elections.

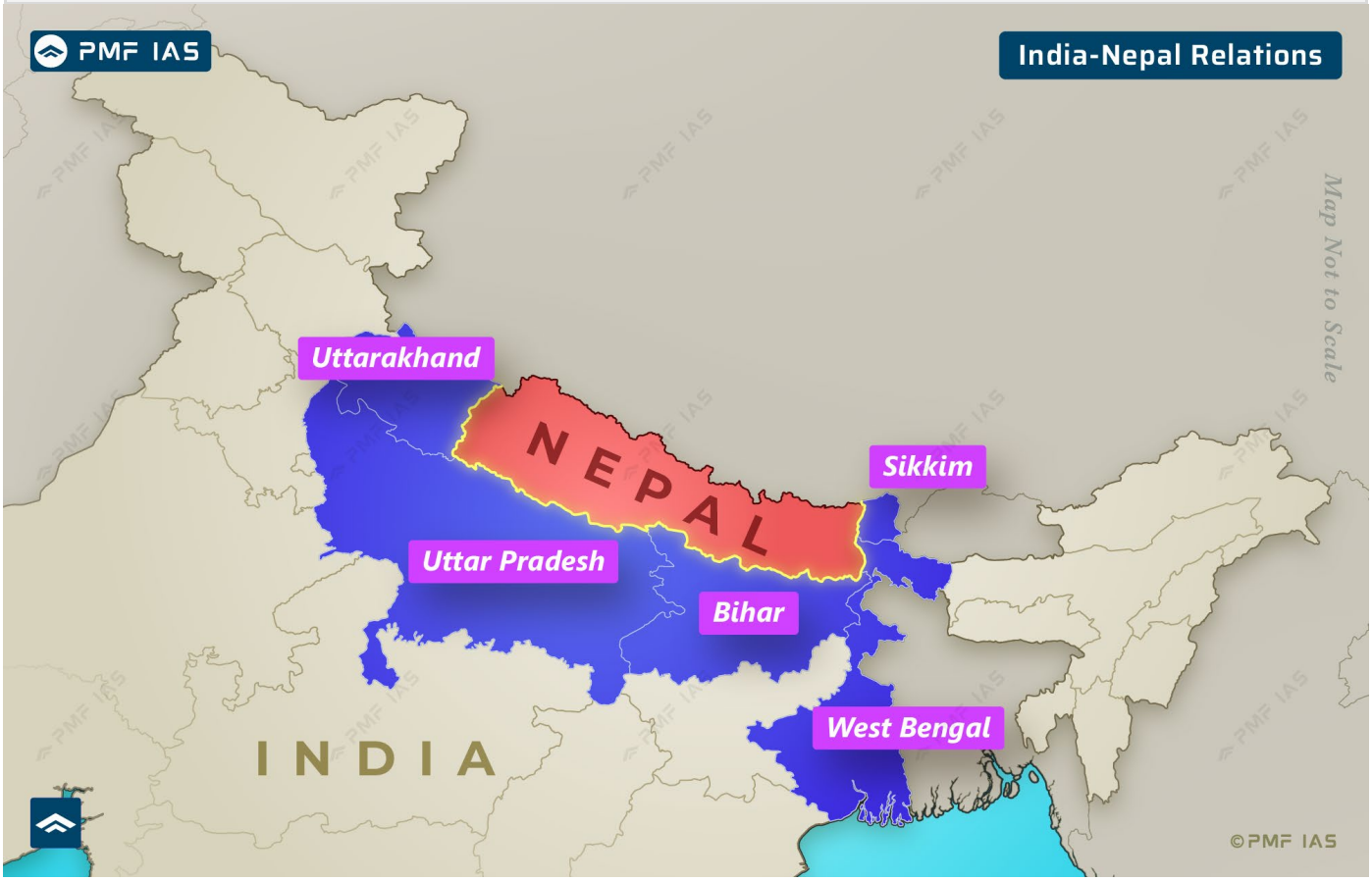
- **Political Backdrop:** This was the first general election since the 2025 "Gen Z" protests that toppled the government of then-Prime Minister K.P. Sharma Oli.

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- **Historic First:** At 35 years old, Balen Shah is set to become **Nepal's youngest Prime Minister** and the first from the **Madhesh** descent to hold the post.

⇨ ***Madhesh** is a fertile plain in the **Terai belt of southeastern Nepal**, bordering **Bihar** along its entire southern boundary. It is popularly known as the "**Granary of Nepal**."*



Potential Challenges for India

- **Boundary Dispute:** Balen Shah's **assertive nationalism** on Kalapani–Limpiyadhura may harden Nepal's bargaining position in bilateral boundary negotiations.
- **Treaty Leverage:** RSP's push to revisit the **1950 Treaty of Peace and Friendship** may reduce India's traditional diplomatic leverage in Kathmandu.
- **Connectivity Risk:** Nepal's efforts to **reduce historical dependence on India** could divert key connectivity and trade projects toward extra-regional partners.
- **Channel Rebuild:** The decline of traditional parties forces New Delhi to **rebuild diplomatic networks** beyond established back channels.

Potential Gains for India

- **Political Stability:** A **single-party majority government** provides a stable environment for implementing long-term bilateral agreements, free from the uncertainty of coalition politics.
- **Policy Alignment:** The new leadership's **technocratic focus** aligns with India's Neighbourhood First initiative through cross-border cooperation on rail and energy grids.

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- **China Counterbalance:** Rising pragmatic political forces may **counterbalance communist** factions that have been more receptive to Beijing.
- **Partnership Basis:** RSP's preference for a "balanced" and "neutral" foreign policy opens space for a **rules-based**, **interest-driven partnership** over personality-led diplomacy.

Overview of India-Nepal Bilateral Relations

- Nepal serves as a crucial **Himalayan buffer state** between **India** and **China** and remains a central pillar of **India's "Neighbourhood First" policy**.
- **Friendship Treaty:** The **1950 Treaty of Peace and Friendship** underpin India–Nepal ties by –
  - ❖ Granting **reciprocal rights** to work, own property, and reside.
  - ❖ Allowing **unrestricted movement** across the 1,751 km porous border spanning five Indian states.
  - ❖ Obligating both countries to inform each other of **external security threats**.
- **Trade:** India is **Nepal's largest trading partner**, accounting for **over 64%** of Nepal's total trade.
- **Volume:** Bilateral trade reached **$8.5 billion in FY 2024-25**, with a strong surplus in **India's favour**.
  - ❖ **Export Basket:** Petroleum products, iron and steel, food grains, machinery, etc.
  - ❖ **Import Basket:** Hydroelectric power, edible oils, cardamom, tea, etc.
- **Energy Agreement:** A long-term power trade agreement commits India to **importing 10,000 MW** of hydropower over the next decade.
- **Defence Links:** Security cooperation exemplified by the annual **'Surya Kiran'** joint military exercise and the recruitment of around **32,000 Nepali Gorkhas** in the Indian Army.
- **Diaspora:** Over 6 million Nepalis in India and about 600,000 Indians in Nepal uphold the deep civilisational bond of "**Roti-Beti ka Rishta**".
- **Connectivity Projects:** South Asia's first cross-border petroleum pipeline, the **Motihari-Amlekhgunj pipeline**, and the **Jayanagar-Kurtha** rail links.
- **Key Divergences:** Boundary disputes, Nepal's engagement with China's BRI, its view of the 1950 Treaty as "unequal," open-border smuggling, and "Big Brother" perception of India.

Challenges

- ➢ **Big Brother Perception:** **Power asymmetry** and the 2015 blockade reinforce Nepal's perception of India as an overbearing neighbour.
- ➢ **Boundary Disputes:** The unresolved **Kalapani–Limpiyadhura issue** continues to fuel nationalist sentiments and bilateral tensions.
- ➢ **Political Instability:** Frequent government changes and **Gen-Z protests** complicate policy continuity and predictable diplomatic engagement.
- ➢ **Chinese Influence:** China's expanding BRI, security cooperation, and Trans-Himalayan projects intensify strategic competition in Nepal.
- ➢ **Implementation Gaps:** Delays in Pancheshwar, rail, and hydropower projects, and in porous border management, weaken trust and security.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Trust Building:** Deepen high-level political engagement under the **Neighbourhood First policy** to build trust with Nepal's new leadership.
- ✓ **Connectivity Push:** Fast-track cross-border railways, power trade and integrated check posts to strengthen economic interdependence and regional connectivity.

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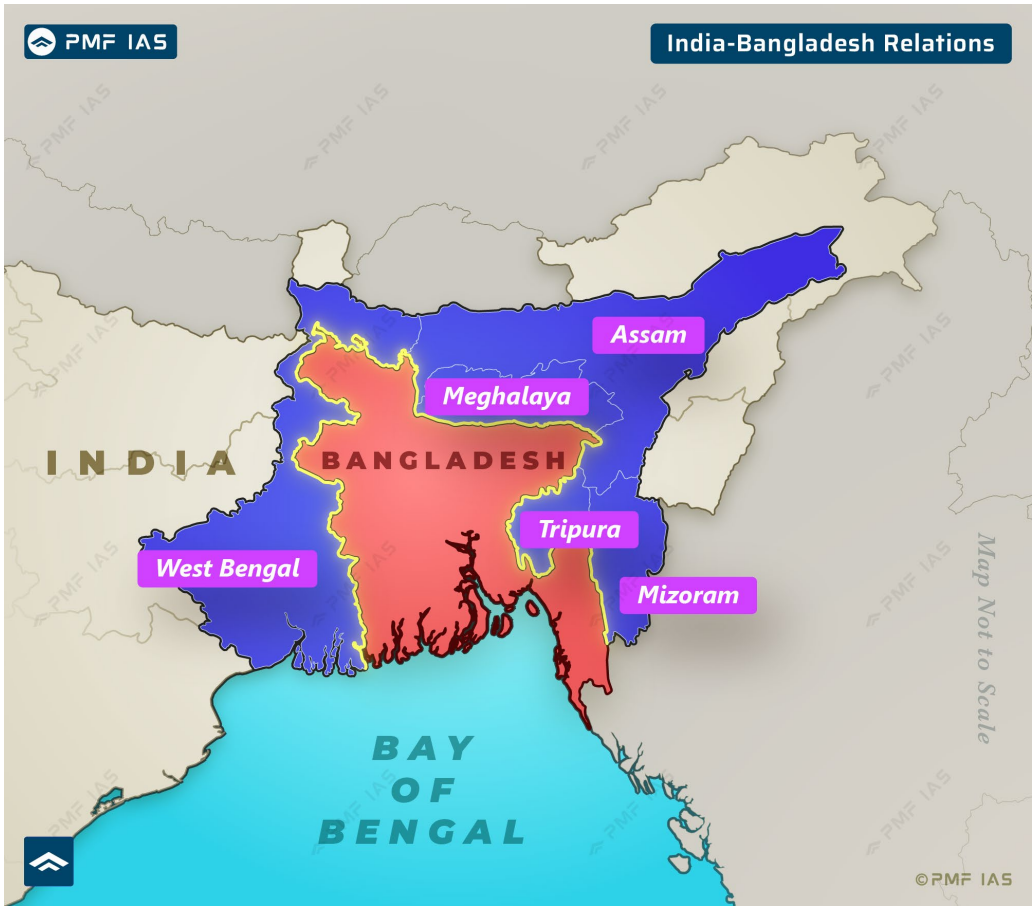
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- ✓ **Boundary Dialogue:** Resolve the **Kalapani–Limpiyadhura dispute** through sustained diplomatic dialogue while respecting mutual sensitivities and international law.
- ✓ **People Connect:** Expand educational scholarships, cultural exchanges and development partnerships, leveraging the **1950 India–Nepal Treaty** and **deep civilisational ties**.

Read More> *India-Nepal Relations*

{IR – India – Bangladesh} India–Bangladesh Relations *

❖ **Context (TH):** India–Bangladesh relations, built on deep strategic and developmental cooperation, are facing renewed strain amid political instability in Dhaka. India's intervention signals concern over **rising radicalism** and **potential spillover risks** to bilateral and regional security.



Evolution of the India-Bangladesh Relationship

- **Liberation Phase (1971–1975):** India's role in the **1971 Liberation War** led to Bangladesh's creation; the **1972 Friendship Treaty** formalised close ties.
- **Reversal Phase (1975–1990):** Post-Mujib assassination, military regimes tilted towards Pakistan, triggering anti-India rhetoric.
- **Democratic Flux (1990–2009):** Alternating **BNP–Awami League** governments shaped ties; the **Ganga Water Treaty (1996)** was a key milestone.
- **Partnership Consolidation (2009–2024):** Hasina's era stabilised relations through security cooperation, BBIN, power trade, and the 2015 Land Boundary Agreement.

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- **Strategic Uncertainty (2024–Present):** Political unrest, Hasina's exit, and rising Islamist influence compel India to recalibrate its Bangladesh policy.

Significance of Bangladesh for India

- **Geostrategic & Connectivity Hub:** Bangladesh is **India's gateway to the Northeast**, bypassing the vulnerable Siliguri Corridor, and is central to the Act East Policy.
- **Border & Security:** Sharing India's longest border (4,096 km), Bangladesh's cooperation is key to countering insurgents (**ULFA, NLFT**) and ensuring border stability.
- **Maritime Security:** Bangladesh's strategic location near the Bay of Bengal Sea lines of communication **(SLOCs)** is vital to secure trade routes and **counter piracy** in the Indian Ocean region.
- **Regional Integration:** Central to **BBIN** and BIMSTEC, driving sub-regional connectivity and trade.

Indo-Bangladesh Cooperation

- **Political Trust:** Institutionalised cooperation through the **2015 Land Boundary Agreement** and Bangladesh's role as **G20 guest** (2023).
- **Regional Integration:** Shared platforms in **SAARC**, **BIMSTEC**, and **IORA** position Bangladesh as India's Bay of Bengal gateway. E.g., BIMSTEC Secretariat in Dhaka.
- **Economic Interdependence:** Strong trade ties with **$14.01 bn bilateral trade** (FY 2023–24) and duty-free access under SAFTA.
- **Connectivity Links:** Multi-modal links boost trade and Northeast connectivity. E.g., Maitri Setu, Agartala–Akhaura rail.
- **Energy & Security:** Energy trade and defence cooperation enhance regional stability. E.g., 1,160 MW power supply.

Challenges in India–Bangladesh Relations

- **Political Flux:** **Hasina's 2024 exit** triggered unrest, empowering Islamist groups and increasing risks of radicalisation and minority insecurity.
- **Strategic Realignment:** Pakistan's diplomatic outreach, Turkey's Islamist support, and China's deepening infra–military ties are reshaping Dhaka's external orientation.
- **China Factor:** Beijing's role in the revival of the **Lalmonirhat airbase** and the **Teesta project** heightens security concerns in the vicinity of the Siliguri Corridor.
- **Border Stress:** Illegal migration and cross-border smuggling persist in Assam and West Bengal despite ongoing **BSF–BGB coordination**.
- **Water Tensions:** **Stalled Teesta talks** and the 2026 expiry of the **Ganga Water Treaty** pose significant bilateral challenges.

Way Forward

- **Diversified Engagement:** Broaden outreach beyond Sheikh Hasina by engaging opposition, civil society, and youth through **Track 1.5** and **Track 2 diplomacy** to ensure balanced ties.
- **Strategic Balancing:** Counter China's deepening footprint (e.g., **Teesta River Project, port infrastructure**) by offering credible alternatives in trade, connectivity, and finance.
- **Regional Cooperation:** Leverage **BIMSTEC**, **BBIN**, and **Act East** to integrate Bangladesh with India's Northeast and Southeast Asia, reducing Dhaka's tilt towards Beijing.

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- ✓ **Patience & Pragmatism:** Move beyond the **1971-centric narrative**; invest in long-term trust through commerce, **energy grids**, **digital linkages**, and climate-resilient water-sharing agreements.
- ✓ **Economic Hedging:** Resume, renegotiate or expand trade agreements (e.g. **CEPA/FTA** talks) to reduce Dhaka's tilt toward China.

{IR – India – Bhutan } India-Bhutan Relations

❖ **Context (IE):** India–Bhutan relations are founded on mutual trust, shared security, and development, evolving into a special strategic partnership under **Neighbourhood First**.

Evolution of India-Bhutan Relations

- **Treaty of Punakha (1910):** Made Bhutan a **protected state of British India**, allowing Britain to control its foreign policy and defence affairs during regional unrest.
- **Treaty of Peace and Friendship (1949):** Recognized Bhutan's sovereignty and established perpetual peace and friendship. Bhutan agreed to be **guided by India** in external affairs.
- **Agreement on Trade, Commerce and Transit (1972):** Created a **free trade regime** and allowed **duty-free movement** of Bhutan's exports and imports through India.
- **Agreement on Cooperation in Hydropower (2006):** Provided a framework for India to support Bhutan's hydropower projects and facilitate the **import of surplus electricity**.
- **Revised India–Bhutan Friendship Treaty (2007):** Ended the **1949 guidance clause** and reaffirmed equal partnership based on mutual interests.

Significance of Bhutan for India

- **Strategic Buffer:** Bhutan's **position between India and China** acts as a protective buffer for India's northern borders and security interests.
- **Siliguri Corridor:** Its proximity to the Siliguri Corridor helps India safeguard its critical land link to the northeastern states.
- **Policy Anchor:** Strong ties with Bhutan support India's 'Neighbourhood First' policy through cooperation in trade, infrastructure, and security.
- **Reliable Partner:** Bhutan remains India's **most trusted regional ally**, ensuring lasting strategic cooperation and mutual stability.
- **Diplomatic Alignment:** Bhutan's alignment with India in regional and global forums strengthens India's diplomatic influence and balances China's growing presence.

Challenges in India-Bhutan Relations

- ➢ **Chinese Engagement:** China's **increasing border talks** and infrastructure projects challenge India's traditional strategic influence in Bhutan.
- ➢ **Economic Diversification:** Bhutan's efforts to **diversify its economy** and seek new partners may lead to policy differences over trade and investment priorities.
- ➢ **Connectivity Constraints:** The mountainous terrain and **limited road and rail networks** hinder trade and regional integration, while **environmental concerns** delay new connectivity projects.
- ➢ **Perception Gap:** A section of the Bhutanese view India's dominant role as overbearing, reinforcing the perception of India as a '**big brother**'.

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- **Border Security:** Despite joint operations like '**All Clear**' (2003-04), insurgent groups still **exploit** the **porous border** areas as temporary hideouts.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Economic Diversification:** Expand cooperation beyond hydropower into digital, start-up, and green energy sectors to reduce Bhutan's debt and deepen interdependence.
- ✓ **Connectivity Integration:** Fast-track rail, road, and digital corridors enhance regional connectivity and Bhutan's market access. E.g., Kokrajhar–Gelephu rail link, BBIN
- ✓ **Strategic Sensitivity:** Respect **Bhutan's sovereign space** while ensuring close coordination on border and security issues, especially amid China's assertiveness.

{IR – India – Maldives} India-Maldives Relations

❖ **Context (IE):** India–Maldives relations, rooted in geographic proximity & cultural ties, are witnessing a strategic reset due to changing regional dynamics. Prime Minister Modi's recent visit as **Guest of Honour on Maldives' Independence Day** marks a renewed commitment to deepening bilateral cooperation.

Historical Background

- **Recognition:** India was among the **first to recognise** Maldives after its independence in 1965.
- **Trade Agreement:** A 1981 pact **liberalised bilateral trade** in essential goods and services.
- **SAARC Membership:** Both nations co-founded SAARC in 1985 to promote regional integration.
- **Operation Cactus:** In 1988, India swiftly intervened to foil a coup attempt in Malé.
- **Defence Assistance:** India has gifted patrol aircraft, helicopters, and radar systems since 2013.
- **Open Skies Pact:** The 2022 agreement expanded bilateral air routes for greater connectivity.

Key Developments

- **Historic Participation:** PM Modi became the **first Indian PM** to attend the Maldives' Independence Day.
- **Rupee-Based Credit:** India extended **₹4,850 crore credit** in rupees for bilateral projects.
- **Debt Relief:** India restructured past loans, reducing the Maldives' repayment burden by 40 per cent.
- **Trade Talks:** Both sides **signed Terms of Reference** to launch **FTA negotiations**.
- **Legislative Forum:** An **India–Maldives parliamentary Friendship group** was formed in the 20th Majlis.
- **Medical Aid:** Arogya Maitri cubes were gifted to boost emergency health response capacity.
- **Fintech Integration:** UPI payments were formalised for use in Maldivian markets.
- **Housing Delivery:** India handed over 3,300 housing units under the **Buyers' Credit facilities**.
- **Fisheries MoU:** New pact signed for joint research, aquaculture, and fisheries **value-chain support**.
- **Digital Governance:** India to share large-scale **digital infrastructure** platforms for governance support.
- **Tourism Linkages:** Both sides discussed launching **direct commercial flights** to boost tourism.

Strategic Implications

- India's calibrated diplomacy transformed the **"India Out" rhetoric into a cautious "India In" narrative**, reaffirming its centrality in Maldivian security and development.
- **IOR Outreach:** India reinforced its **Indian Ocean presence** amid intensifying geopolitical competition.
- **Digital Diplomacy:** Payment system integration showcased India's **expanding soft power** in the region.
- **Civic Engagement:** Diaspora events and legislative ties deepened cultural and people-level bonds.

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- **Reliable Partner:** India reaffirmed its role as **Maldives' first responder** and **long-term ally**.
- MAHASAGAR **Vision:** The visit advances India's maritime agenda for **security & growth across regions**.

Significance of Maldives for India

- Maldives serves as a **maritime cornerstone** in India's Indo-Pacific calculus and Indian Ocean outreach.
- **Strategic Geography:** Maldives anchors India's SAGAR and Neighbourhood First maritime policies.
- **SLOC Security:** Over 50% of Indian trade and 80% of energy imports pass nearby.
- **Maritime Tollway:** Maldives lies between the **Hormuz** and **Malacca** straits, vital for Indian Ocean access.
- **Development Partner:** India emerged as Maldives' largest development partner with ~$1B trade.
- **Greater Malé Project:** India is funding the ₹1,600 crore+ connectivity project to ensure **maritime access**.

Challenges in India-Maldives Relations

- As **trust amid turbulence** defines current ties, India's strategic space faces pressure from ideological shifts and external alignments in the Maldives.
- **Radicalisation:** Islamist groups and Pakistan-linked madrassas threaten regional security and stability.
- **Chinese Footprint:** BRI-linked projects like **Sinamalé Bridge** increase Beijing's maritime influence.
- **Non-Traditional Threats:** Piracy, drug trade, and illegal fishing impact Indian Ocean security.
- **India Out Campaign:** In 2023, rising nationalism fuelled public calls to **remove Indian presence**.
- **Political Volatility:** Frequent regime changes hinder long-term strategic alignment with India.
- **Debt Leverage:** **Chinese debt exposure** limits the Maldives' **foreign policy autonomy** regarding India.

Way Forward

- **Strategic Cooperation:** Strengthen collaboration in defense, trade, climate action, and counter-extremism, backed by India's **$2 billion development assistance**.
- **Trade Expansion:** **Fast-track pending FTAs** to reinforce India's economic leadership in South Asia and **update the 1981 trade pact**.
- **Blue Economy Push:** Align with Maldives' **Blue Economy goals** to support marine tourism and fisheries, which contribute over **30% to its GDP**.
- **Project Execution:** Ensure timely delivery of projects like the **$500 million Greater Male** Connectivity Project to counter China's growing influence.
- **Proactive Diplomacy:** Shift from **passive policy to assertive engagement** to tackle **"India Out"** narratives and secure maritime interests near the **8° Channel**.

{IR – India – Afghanistan} India-Afghanistan Relations

❖ **Context (IE):** India-Afghanistan relations are at a pivotal juncture, with New Delhi signaling bold moves to **re-engage with the Taliban-led regime**, as it explores strategic options to safeguard national interests and rebuild its influence amid evolving regional dynamics.

Historical Background

- **Ancient Links:** India and Afghanistan share deep-rooted civilizational ties through trade, **Buddhism**, and **Silk Route exchanges**.
- **Medieval Interactions:** Afghan dynasties like **Ghazni** and **Lodi** shaped Indo-Afghan political and cultural relations.

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- **Colonial Era:** Afghanistan was a buffer between British India and Tsarist Russia during the "**Great Game**."
- **Early Diplomacy:** Afghanistan was the **first to recognise independent India** in 1947, marking strong bilateral ties.
- **Post-2001 Development Role:** India invested **over $3 billion** in rebuilding Afghanistan's infrastructure, health, and education post-Taliban fall.
- **Post-2021 Realignment:** India is cautiously **re-engaging with Taliban-ruled Afghanistan** to safeguard strategic and humanitarian interests.



Significance of Afghanistan for India

- **Strategic Route:** Afghanistan helps India reach Central Asia through Chabahar Port, avoiding Pakistan.
- **Terror Check:** India wants to stop groups like **LeT**, **JeM**, and **ISKP** from using Afghan soil for attacks.
- **Big Projects:** India built key projects like the Salma Dam & Afghan Parliament, spending **over $3 billion**.
- **Goodwill Aid:** India sends help like wheat and medicines and gives **scholarships to Afghan students**.
- **Check on Pakistan:** A friendly Afghan government helps India **reduce Pakistan's hold** in the region.
- **Drug Control:** India worries about Afghan opium funding terrorism & harming states like Punjab & J&K.

Major Area of Cooperation

Development Partnership

- **Flagship Projects:** **Salma Dam** and **Afghan Parliament** reflect India's infrastructure-led soft power.
- **Human Capital Building:** **1,000+** annual scholarships & **4,000+** officials trained under ITEC,

Trade & Connectivity

- **Air Corridor:** Enabled **direct export of Afghan** dry fruits, saffron, & pharma goods, bypassing Pakistan.
- **Chabahar Link:** Zaranj-Delaram Highway connects to Chabahar Port, giving India access to Central Asia.

Humanitarian Assistance

- **Food & Health Aid:** Supplied **75,000 tonnes of wheat** and **essential medicines** during Taliban crisis.

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- **Medical Diplomacy:** India reopened the **Indira Gandhi Institute of Child Health** in Kabul post-2021 and sent vaccines during COVID-19.

Key Issue in India-Afghanistan Relations

- **Terror Threat:** LeT and JeM presence in Afghanistan confirmed by UN (2023) poses J&K security risks.
- **Opium Trade:** Afghanistan supplies **~80% of global opium**, threatening India's border states (UNODC).
- **Project Stagnation:** $3 billion Indian investments in 500+ Afghan projects stalled post-2021.
- **Transit Barriers:** Pakistan blocks land route, forcing reliance on **Chabahar Port–Zaranj Highway** and limited air corridor.
- **Geopolitical Pressure:** Pakistan's Taliban influence & China's $10 billion lithium deals shrink India's role.

Way Forward: Reorienting India's Afghanistan Policy

- ✓ **Chabahar–Zaranj Link:** Fast-track India's 218 km **Zaranj–Delaram highway** for Central Asia access.
- ✓ **Security Engagement:** Cooperate with Taliban to **curb threats** from **LeT**, **JeM**, and **ISKP**.
- ✓ **Cultural Diplomacy:** Continue scholarships and skill programs to strengthen ties with Afghan youth.
- ✓ **Regional Coordination:** Work with Iran, Russia, and Central Asia through the SCO and UN platforms for Afghan stability.
- ✓ **Counter-Terrorism:** Coordinate with regional powers against **6,500+ foreign fighters** in Afghanistan.
- ✓ **Narcotics Control:** Partner with UNODC to curb **80% global opium** output from Afghanistan.

{IR – India – China} India-China Relations

- ❖ **Context (TH):** The External Affairs Minister's first high-level engagement with China **since the Galwan clash** signals a shift toward **structured normalisation**, aimed at reviving the long-stalled **Dragon-Elephant tango** through calibrated diplomatic, economic, and military steps.



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Why Stability Matters

Economic Leverage

- **Trade and Investment:** Stable ties facilitate a **$120 bn** bilateral trade relationship and enable calibrated Chinese investment in non-sensitive sectors.
- **Supply Chain Access:** Normalisation **secures critical input** access—APIs, chips, rare earths—for industrial self-reliance.
- **Diversification Push:** Strategic calm enables supply chain diversification through **China+1 shifts** and Quad-led technology realignment.

Strategic Gains and Autonomy

- **Border Dividend:** Border tranquillity dividend eases **two-front military** pressure and restores India's strategic planning bandwidth.
- **Strategic Autonomy:** Balanced engagement enables **India to deepen Quad ties** while maintaining a **functional dialogue** with China.
- **Multilateral Leverage:** Stability enables India to engage constructively with China in the BRICS and SCO, while safeguarding India's normative space.

Connectivity, Water, and Climate Cooperation

- **Border Trade:** Border stability enabled the **reopening of Nathu La trade** and reinforced economic recovery in frontier regions.
- **Hydro Cooperation:** Hydro-diplomacy revived **Brahmaputra flood data** sharing and fostered a basic trust framework in water relations.
- **Climate-Tech Link:** Clean-tech collaboration supports India's just energy transition and secures rare-earth access for net-zero ambitions.

Steps Toward Normalisation

- **75-Year Milestone:** In 2025, India and China marked 75 years of diplomatic ties with renewed calls to revive Dragon-Elephant ties.
- **LAC Disengagement:** Military disengagement protocols at **Depsang** and **Demchok** were fully completed by late 2024.
- **Border Trade:** The **Nathu La** trade route in **Sikkim** officially reopened, signalling intent to stabilise frontier economies.
- **SR Dialogue:** The Special Representatives' meeting in 2024 revived **Track-I diplomatic** engagement on border resolution.
- **BRICS Interaction:** The Modi-Xi meeting at the **2023 BRICS Kazan** Summit marked the first structured leader-level dialogue since 2019.
- **River Cooperation:** China resumed **Brahmaputra** and **Sutlej flood data** sharing in 2025 under a renewed hydro-diplomatic framework.
- **Pilgrimage Resumed:** The **Kailash Mansarovar Yatra** resumed in April 2025 as a people-centric confidence-building initiative.

Key Roadblocks Ahead

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- **Boundary Disputes:** Unresolved disputes over Aksai Chin and Arunachal Pradesh continue through stand-offs at Doklam, Galwan, Depsang, and Demchok.
- **Economic Dependence:** India's trade deficit with China reached **$99.2 billion (2024–25)**, alongside heavy dependence on critical technology imports.
- **Strategic Competition:** China's partnership with Pakistan (CPEC) and India's engagement with the QUAD reflect intensifying geopolitical and security rivalry.
- **Maritime Encirclement:** China's **String of Pearls** strategy expands its Indian Ocean presence, challenging India's maritime security and regional influence.
- **Border & Water Pressures:** Xiaokang villages, the **Five Fingers** approach, and Brahmaputra dam-building increase territorial and water-security concerns.

Path to Stable Engagement

- ✓ **Strategic Dialogue:** Strengthen **SR** and **WMCC** mechanisms to ensure complete LAC disengagement, confidence-building, and sustained border stability.
- ✓ **Balanced Engagement:** Use **BRICS** and **SCO** to maintain dialogue, prevent escalation, and strengthen bilateral confidence.
- ✓ **Economic Diversification:** Reduce China's dependence through **China+1**, domestic manufacturing, and resilient critical mineral supply chains.
- ✓ **Border Security:** Upgrade LAC infrastructure, ISR systems, drones, and logistics to strengthen deterrence and rapid response.
- ✓ **Regional Balancing:** Deepen **QUAD**, **IMEC**, **BIMSTEC**, and **SASEC** partnerships to counterbalance China's regional influence.

{IR – India – China} Panchsheel Doctrine for India–China Ties

❖ **Context (TH):** In the recent Modi–Xi meeting, China underscored the relevance of the **Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence (Panchsheel)**, signalling its strategic importance in shaping India–China relations.

Historical Evolution

- **Bandung Adoption (1955):** **Bandung Conference** integrated Panchsheel into the **Ten Principles of International Peace**.
- **UN Recognition (1957):** UNGA Resolution legitimised Panchsheel as a principle of international law.
- **NAM Endorsement (1961):** **Belgrade** NAM **Summit** recognised Panchsheel as **a core principle** of the movement.
- **The Five Principles of Panchsheel:** Mutual respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, non-aggression, non-interference, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence.

Contemporary Relevance

- **Strategic Autonomy:** Panchsheel supports India's non-alignment, sovereignty, and **South–South cooperation** in a multipolar world.
- **Multilateral diplomacy:** Reflected in BRICS and SCO, highlighting sovereign equality & mutual benefit.
- **Conflict Resolution:** It offers a **diplomatic framework** for peaceful global dispute resolution.
- **Maritime Security:** It guides Indo-Pacific navigation and fosters balanced global economic partnerships.

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Panchsheel Doctrine Shaping India's Foreign Policy

- **Mutual Respect:** 1972 India-China Panchsheel Treaty **upheld sovereignty** and **territorial integrity**.
- **Non-Aggression:** India's **no first-use nuclear policy** reflects commitment to peaceful coexistence.
- **Non-Interference:** India avoids meddling in **Bhutan** and **Nepal's internal affairs**, fostering trust.
- **Equality & Cooperation:** India-Africa Forum Summit provided **$10 billion in aid** and **credit lines**.
- **Peaceful Coexistence:** Panchsheel guides India in BRICS and SCO, balancing major-power relations.

Reasons for the Failure of the Panchsheel Agreement

- **Divergent Intentions:** India upheld Panchsheel as a **moral code** of peaceful coexistence, while China **used it tactically** to consolidate control over Tibet.
- **Tibet Issue:** By the 1954 Agreement, India formally **recognized Tibet as part of China**, sacrificing its buffer while legitimizing China's hold.
- **Boundary Neglect:** Panchsheel bypassed the undefined boundary. China later rejected India's claims over **Aksai Chin** and **Arunachal Pradesh**.
- **Trust Deficit:** India's **"Hindi–Chini Bhai Bhai"** idealism clashed with China's perception of India's **Forward Policy (1959–62)** as provocative.
- **Chinese Expansionism:** Despite Panchsheel, China built the **Aksai Chin road (1950s)**, culminating in the 1962 war that shattered bilateral trust.

Structural Challenges

- **Border Tensions:** The fragile peace is exposed by clashes such as **Doklam** (2017) and **Galwan** (2020).
- **Trade Asymmetry:** India's **$100 billion trade deficit** with China highlights economic imbalance.
- **Sovereignty Concerns:** Territorial integrity is threatened by **BRI projects** and CPEC through PoK.
- **Geopolitical Balance:** Strategic suspicion rises due to India's QUAD alliance with the United States.
- **Enforcement Gap:** The lack of monitoring leaves Panchsheel vulnerable to realpolitik violations.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Border Stability:** Confidence-building measures and commander-level talks to reinforce border peace.
- ✓ **Economic Balance:** Diversifying sources, decreasing trade deficits, and facilitating **technology transfers**.
- ✓ **Institutional Reform:** Monitoring frameworks and river-sharing to improve enforcement & sovereignty.
- ✓ **Multilateral Engagement:** BRICS, SCO, and G20 platforms collectively revitalise Panchsheel's global role.
- ✓ **Cultural Exchanges:** Promote education, tourism, and pilgrimages to foster societal understanding.

{IR – India's Neighbourhood First Policy – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. Examine how India's growing role in the Bay of Bengal is shaped by geopolitical dynamics and infrastructural constraints. Also, suggest ways to balance regional integration with strategic autonomy. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief overview of India's increasing presence in the Bay of Bengal..
- **Body:** Write about the geopolitical dynamics shaping India's role, the infrastructural constraints hindering India's influence, and suggest ways to balance regional integration with strategic autonomy.

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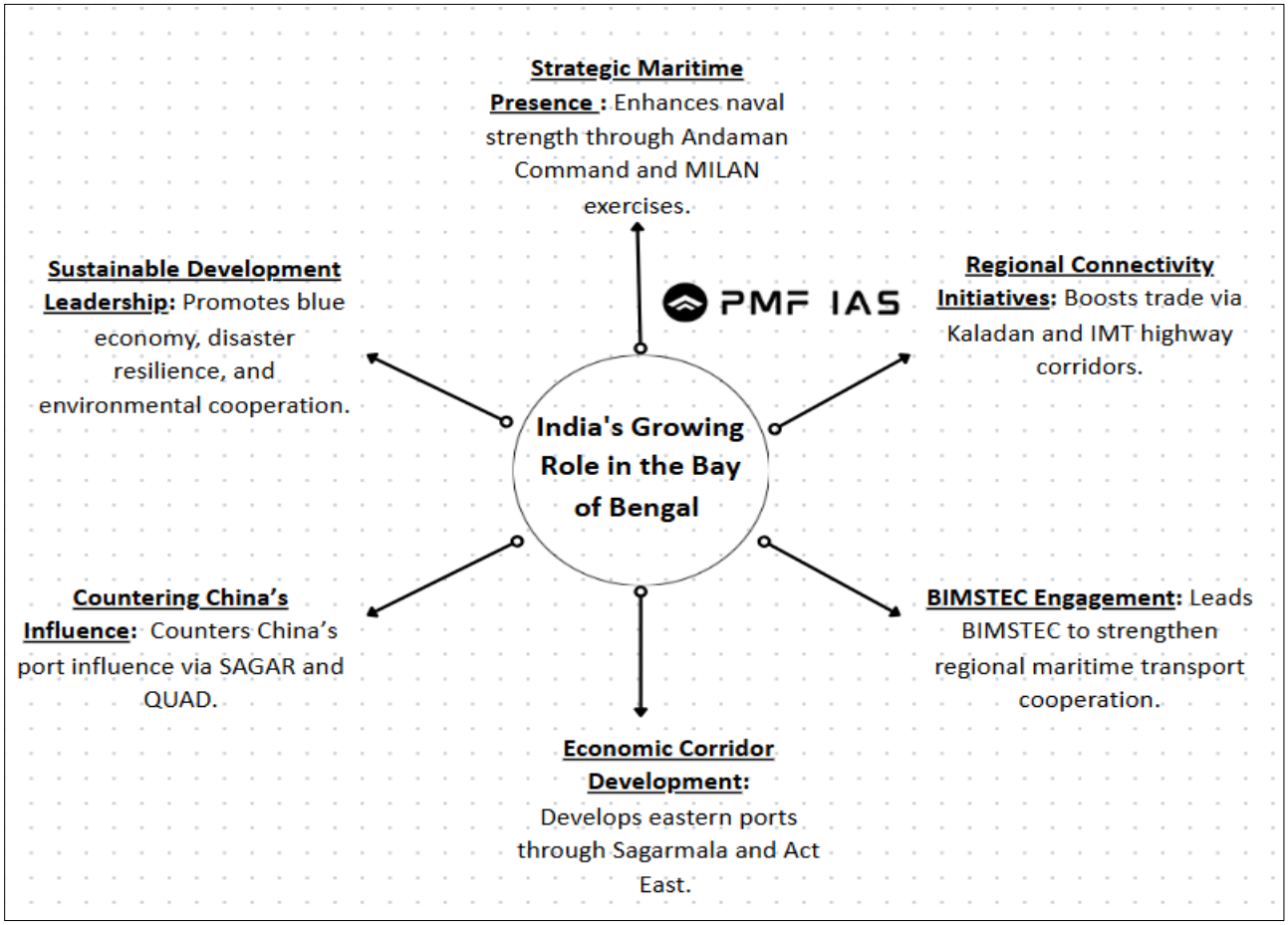
- **Conclusion:** Emphasizing a balanced approach among connectivity, regional trust, and geopolitical rivalry through infrastructure development and smart diplomacy.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- **India's rising engagement in the Bay of Bengal** reflects its aspiration to emerge as a **key maritime power** linking South and Southeast Asia. Guided by **SAGAR** and the **Act East Policy**, India's role is being shaped by emerging geopolitical rivalries and persistent infrastructural limitations.

Geopolitical Dynamics Shaping India's Role

- **China's Maritime Push:** China's ports in **Kyaukpyu**, **Hambantota**, and **Chittagong** spur **India's SAGAR** and QUAD-led maritime counterbalance.
- **BIMSTEC Leverage:** India uses **BIMSTEC over SAARC**; 2024 transport pact boosts port and trade connectivity.
- **External Power Entry:** The presence of the U.S., Japan, and Australia in the Bay prompts India's strategic leadership without formal alliances.
- **Security Focus:** India counters maritime threats via the **Andaman Command** and **MILAN naval** drills.



Infrastructural Constraints Hindering India's Role

- **Cross-Border Project Delays:** Slow progress on the **Kaladan** and **IMT Highway** limits limits India's regional connectivity leadership.

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- **Port Inefficiency & Trade Gaps:** Eastern ports are growing, but BIMSTEC **trade remains low** (~6–7%) due to logistics constraints.
- **Regulatory Mismatch:** Divergent customs and standards **across littoral states hinder the** smooth operation of trade and ports.
- **Environmental Risks:** Frequent **cyclones** and **sea-level rise** pose a threat to coastal infrastructure and investor confidence.

Balancing Regional Integration with Strategic Autonomy

- ✓ **Accelerate Regional Connectivity:** Expedite the Kaladan River project, BBIN Connectivity Corridor project, and **East Coast Economic Corridor** (ECEC) project; modernise ports through **Sagarmala initiative**.
- ✓ **Strengthen BIMSTEC Institutions:** Enhance BIMSTEC's role with coordination cells and dispute-resolution mechanisms.
- ✓ **Deepen Economic Diplomacy:** Support Maldives, Bhutan, and Myanmar through aid, technology, and green collaborations.
- ✓ **Preserve Strategic Autonomy:** Engage in **joint drills** while avoiding binding military pacts.

Conclusion

- As PM Modi stated, "**SAGAR is not just a policy but a commitment**." A balanced approach—combining infrastructure push, economic diplomacy, and strategic caution—is essential to transform the Bay of Bengal into a zone of regional trust, connectivity, and autonomous leadership.

Q. Examine how stable and constructive ties between India and China are essential not only for bilateral relations but also for regional and global stability. In this context, analyse the roadblock in India-China relations and suggest a way forward. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write briefly about India-China relations by mentioning the fact.
- **Body:** Write the significance of stable India-China ties, the roadblocks in India-China relations and the way forward.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on sustained dialogue, strategic prudence, and multilateral cooperation is crucial for a stable, multipolar Asia and a fairer world order.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- India and China, comprising over **2.7 billion** people and **18%** of global GDP, are central to regional and global stability. Their constructive engagement is vital in a shifting geopolitical landscape.

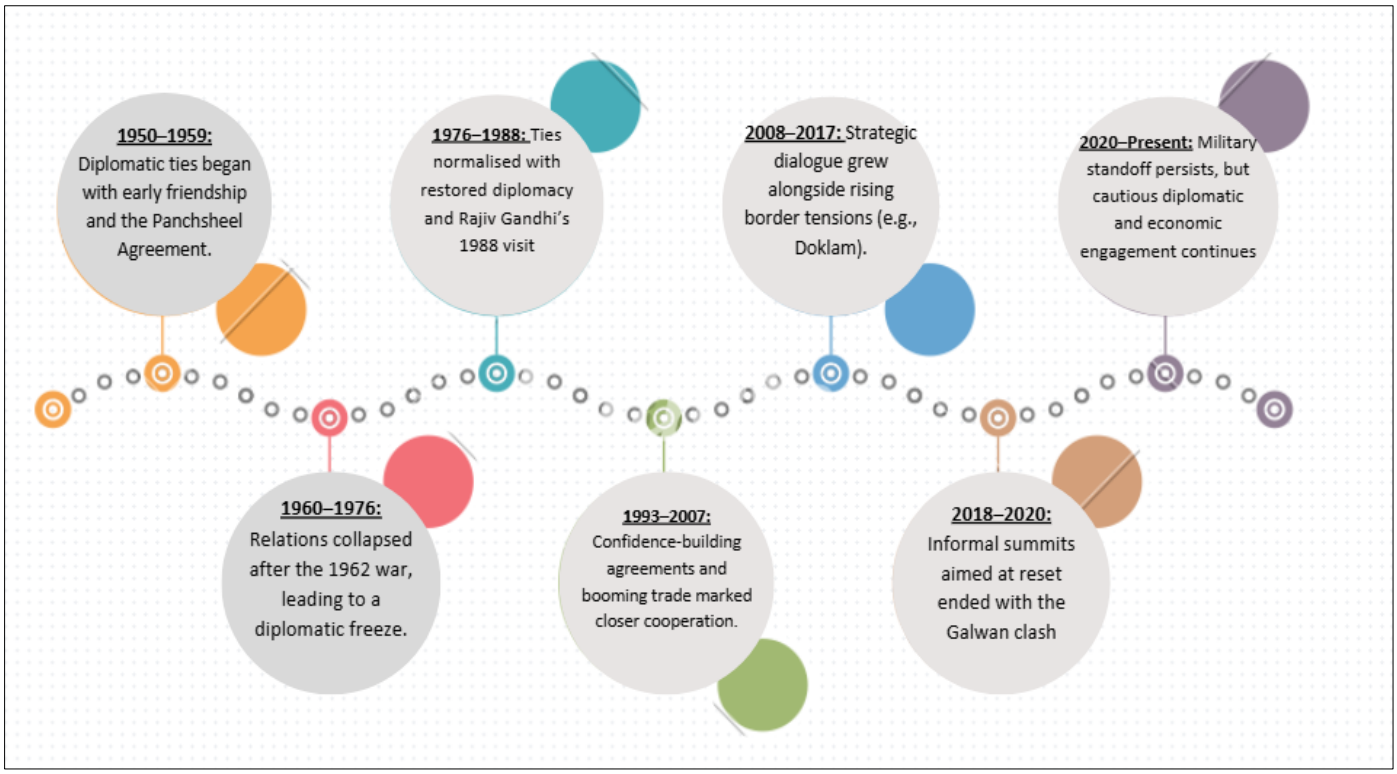
Significance of Stable India-China Ties

- **Border Stability**: Resolving tensions along the **3,488 km** disputed border is crucial for Indo-Pacific peace.
- **Economic Interdependence:** Bilateral trade around **USD 128 billion** in 2024–25, China remains India's second-largest trade partner.
- **Multilateral Engagement:** India and China cooperation shape global discourse through **BRICS**, **SCO**, and **G20** on key issues like climate and development.
- **Global South Advocacy:** Stable ties strengthen their joint push for reforming institutions like the **UN**, **WTO**, and **IMF**.

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Evolution of India–China Relations



Roadblock in India-China Relations

- **Territorial Disputes:** Ongoing conflicts over borders in the **Himalayas** create persistent tension and distrust.
- **Strategic Rivalry:** China's support for Pakistan and opposition to India's membership in the UNSC and NSG undermine trust.
- **Economic Asymmetry:** India's **trade deficit** with China and **critical dependency** on Chinese imports such as APIs, electronics.
- **Debt Trap Diplomacy:** China's lending strategy to developing nations often results in economic dependence.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Institutionalised Dialogue:** Resume the **India-China Strategic Economic** Dialogue and sustain Corps Commander-level military talks.
- ✓ **People-Centric Diplomacy:** Expanding cultural exchange programs, such as increased **scholarships** for Indian students in China and vice versa.
- ✓ **CBMs 2.0:** Build upon the 1993 and 1996 border agreements with real-time communication and demilitarisation in friction points.
- ✓ **Economic Rebalancing:** Under Atmanirbhar Bharat, India should reduce **critical dependency** on China.

Conclusion

- As India and China sustain **dialogue**, strategic **prudence**, and **multilateral cooperation** are crucial for a stable, **multipolar Asia** and a fairer world order.

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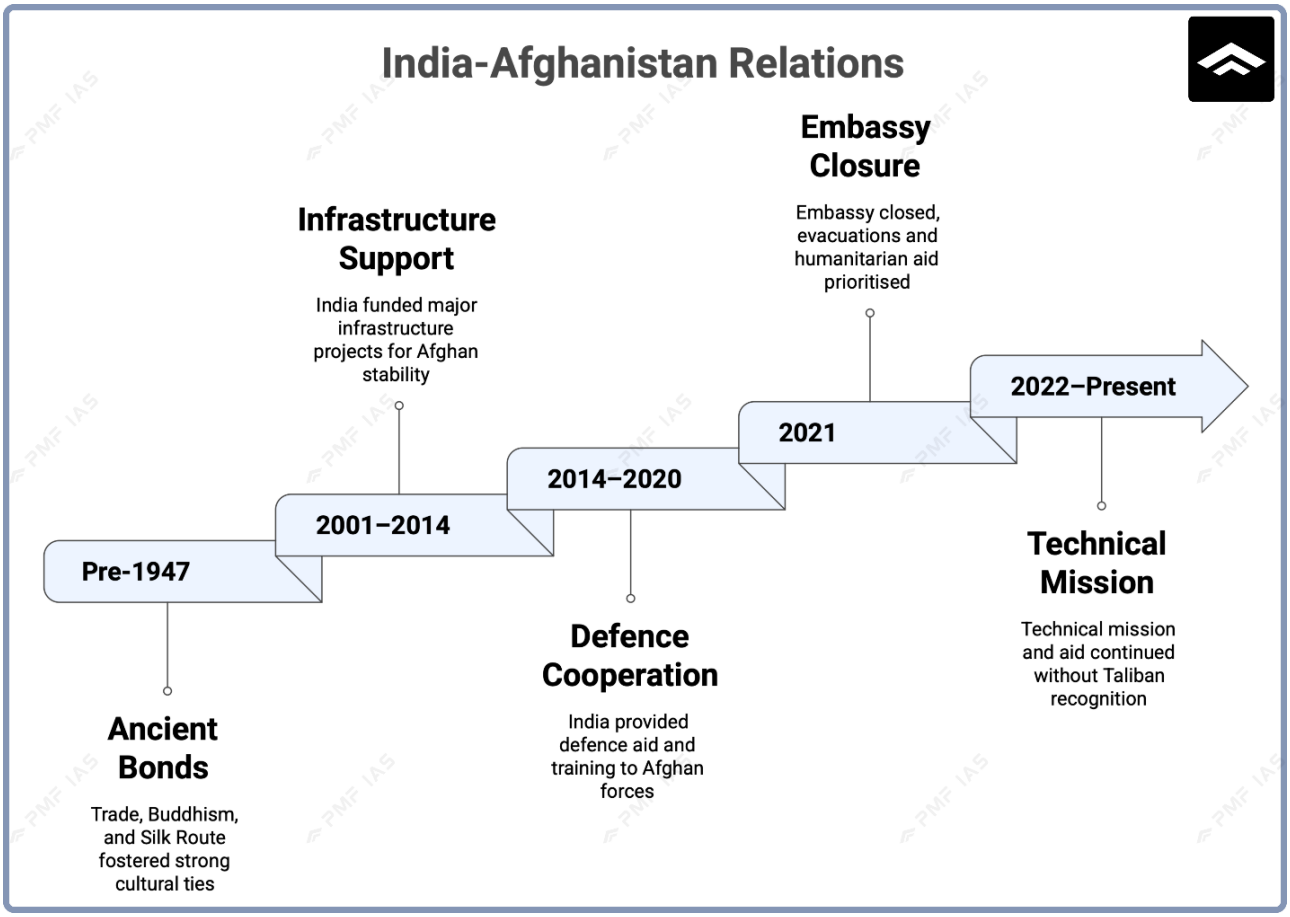
Q. In light of the changing regime in Afghanistan, critically discuss India's evolving diplomatic strategy and suggest a plan to balance its strategic interests and humanitarian responsibilities in Afghanistan. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write briefly about the current status of Afghanistan and India's response to it.
- **Body:** Discuss India's evolving diplomatic strategy, challenges and suggest a plan to balance its strategic interests and humanitarian responsibilities in Afghanistan.
- **Conclusion:** Highlights the need for a balanced approach to **pragmatic diplomacy** with a **people-centric approach.**

Model Answer (250 Words)

- The 2021 Taliban takeover forced India to rethink its Afghan policy amid security & geopolitical shifts. New Delhi now seeks to balance **counterterrorism with humanitarian & development commitments**.



India's Evolving Diplomatic Strategy

- **Pragmatic Outreach:** Kabul mission reopened via technical team, avoiding Taliban legitimisation.
- **Counter-terrorism Links:** Coordinates with Iran, Russia, Central Asia against **LeT**, **JeM**, **ISKP**; keeps informal Taliban contacts.
- **Aid Delivery:** Since 2021; **50,000 MT** wheat, **45 MT** medicines, **5 lakh vaccines**; ₹200 cr in 2023–24.
- **Soft Power:** Sustains **Salma Dam**, **Afghan Parliament**; educates 14,000 Afghans, mostly ICCR scholars.

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- **Connectivity Push:** Chabahar & INSTC secure Central Asia access, bypassing Pakistan via Afghanistan.

Challenges

- **Security Threats:** **Rise in cross-border terrorism** and presence of anti-India groups like Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammed in Afghanistan.
- **Reduced Diplomatic Presence:** Closure of Indian missions post-2021 **limits on-ground engagement**.
- **Pakistan's Influence:** Strengthened strategic depth of Pakistan in Afghan affairs marginalizes India.
- **Uncertain Governance:** Lack of **inclusive governance**, **human rights violations**, and restrictions on **women's education** hinder development cooperation.

Recommendations for Balanced Engagement

- ✓ **Codify Taliban Contact:** Formalise a **Doha-style channel** to protect $3 bn Indian assets like Salma Dam.
- ✓ **Boost Aid:** Expand beyond 50,000 MT wheat via Chabahar to fund UN-backed health & school meals.
- ✓ **Expand Scholarships:** Increase ICCR seats & reopen cultural hubs like the **"Friendship Library"** in Kabul.
- ✓ **Use Forums:** Champion Afghan stability in SCO, echoing India's 2021 UNSC focus on aid access.

Conclusion

- A cautious yet proactive strategy can protect India's security while sustaining goodwill among Afghans. Blending **pragmatic diplomacy** with **people-centric aid** will secure both strategic and moral objectives.

Q. With China expanding its footprint in the Maldives, India's traditional influence is being challenged. Analyse the evolving dynamics of India–Maldives relations and assess how soft power and strategic communication can help rebuild trust. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write briefly about the India-Maldives relation by mentioning China's influence and anti-India sentiments.
- **Body:** Write evolving dynamics of India–Maldives relations, challenges and role of soft power and strategic communication.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on soft power and people-centric diplomacy to increase strategic foothold in the Maldives.

Model Answer (250 Words)

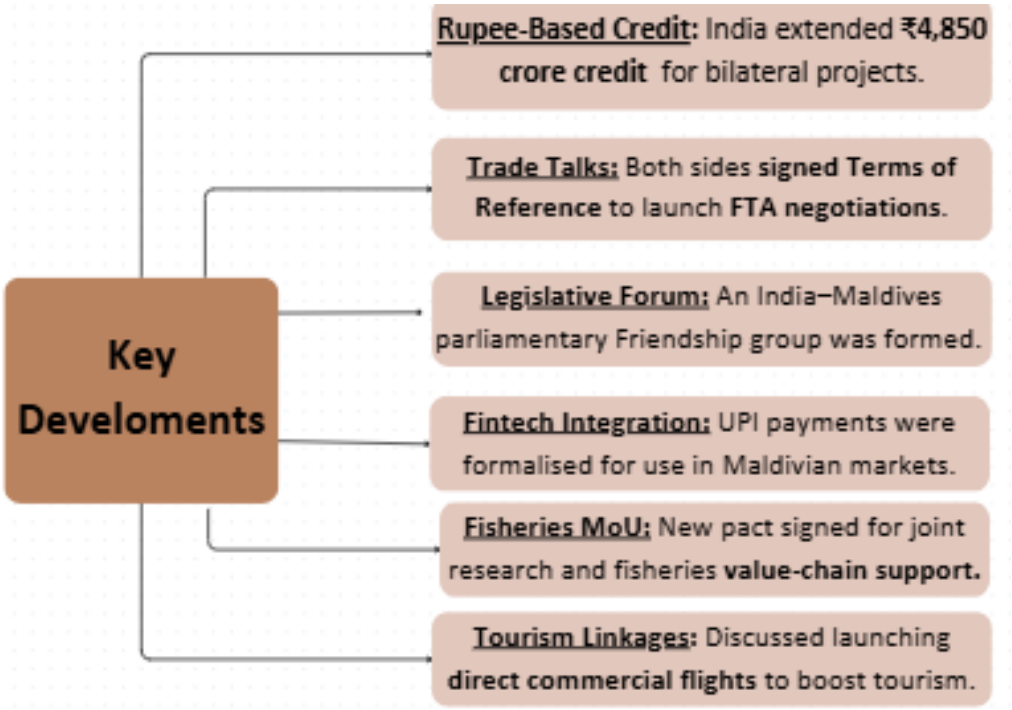
- India's influence in the Maldives is challenged by **China's rise** and **the 2023 "India Out" push**. Restoring trust requires sharp soft power and strategic outreach.

Evolving Dynamics of India–Maldives Relations

- **Early Diplomatic Recognition:** India **recognized Maldives** in 1965 and signed a **trade pact** in 1981.
- **Security Credibility:** India's 1988 **Operation Cactus** prevented a coup in Malé, solidifying its role as Maldives' first security responder.
- **Financial Assistance:** India extended **₹4,850 crore** in rupee credit & cut debt repayment burden by **40%**.
- **Infrastructure & Digital Links:** India funded the **₹1,600+ crore Greater Male Project**, delivered 3,300 housing units, & enabled UPI in Male.
- **Sea Relevance:** Maldives lies near **SLOCs** through **50%** of India's trade & **80%** of energy imports transit.

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Challenges

- **"India Out" Surge:** In 2023, rising nationalism fuelled public calls to remove Indian presence.
- **China's Influence:** The $210 million **Sinamalé Bridge** exemplifies Beijing's expanding strategic presence.
- **Rising Insecurity:** **Radicalised elements** & **Pakistan-linked madrassas**, along with drug and piracy threats, endanger Indian Ocean security.
- **Debt Leverage:** **30%** of the Maldives' external debt was owed to China, curbing autonomy with India.

Role of Soft Power and Strategic Communication

- ✓ **Cultural Diplomacy:** A joint stamp & **1 lakh+** annual Indian tourists strengthened cultural ties.
- ✓ **Aid:** India delivered **3,300 housing** units, **Arogya Maitri health cubes**, & **₹1,600 crore** for connectivity.
- ✓ **Digital Diplomacy:** **UPI rollout** in Maldives & vernacular campaigns helped counter anti-India narratives.
- ✓ **Institutional Outreach:** A **parliamentary friendship group** & **diaspora events** reinforced bilateral trust.

Conclusion

- India's **soft power** and **people-centric diplomacy** are key to restoring trust and securing its strategic foothold in the Maldives.

Q. In light of changing dynamics with Pakistan, examine how India must recalibrate its foreign policy to address broader geopolitical shifts in an emerging multipolar world. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write briefly about the current status of India's foreign policy with Pakistan and beyond by mentioning Pahalgam attack.
- **Body:** Write need to recalibrate foreign policy and how India must recalibrate its foreign policy to address broader geopolitical shifts in an emerging multipolar world.

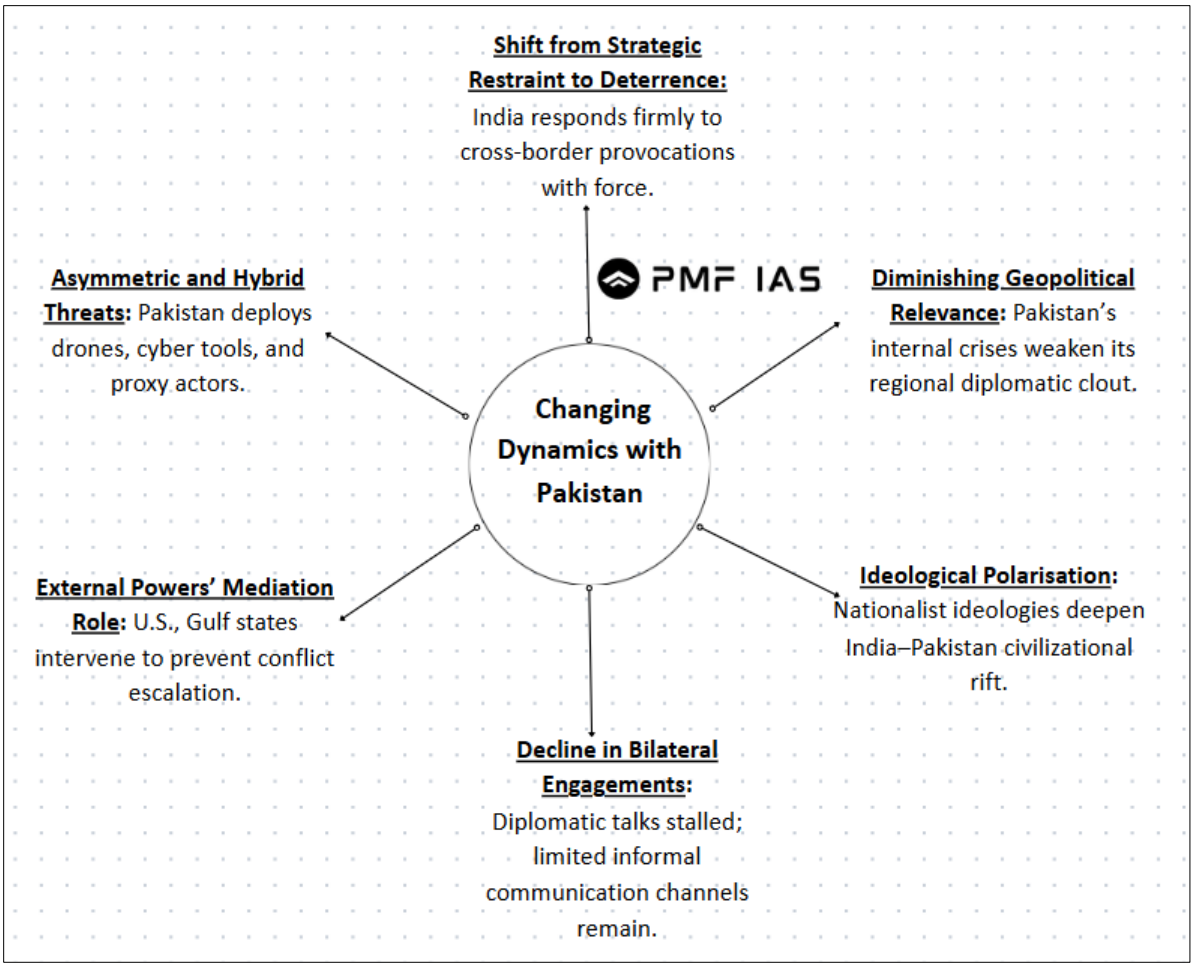
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- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on strategic focus must shift to countering China, securing tech and energy, and shaping global order.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- India's response to the **Pahalgam attack** showed tactical resolve, but rising China and global realignments demand a strategic shift beyond **Pakistan-centric policy**.



Need to Recalibrate its Foreign Policy

- **China's Challenge:** LAC tensions and Indo-Pacific assertiveness push India to strengthen ties through **Quad** and **IPEF**.
- **Digital and Tech Threats:** Surging cyberattacks (**More than 2 million** in 2024) demand digital resilience and tech self-reliance.
- **Supply Chain Risks:** Import vulnerabilities drive India's push for **critical mineral access** and manufacturing autonomy.
- **Evolving Alliances:** Weakening old blocs prompt India to lead flexible groupings like Quad & I2U2.

Way Forward

✓ **Pursue Balanced Multi-Alignment:** Engage major powers without compromising **strategic autonomy**.
✓ **Deepen Issue-Based Minilaterals:** Strengthen platforms like **Quad**, **I2U2**, and **BIMSTEC**.

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- ✓ **Leverage Tech Diplomacy:** Prioritize AI, **quantum**, **space**, and **cybersecurity** cooperation.
- ✓ **Expand Trade and Digital Reach:** Seal key **FTAs** and globalize India Stack as a digital public good.

Conclusion

- Pakistan poses tactical threats, India's strategic focus must shift to **countering China**, **securing tech** and **energy**, and **shaping global order**. India must now "**think globally**, **act strategically**, and **lead multilaterally**."

Q. The ongoing crisis in West Asia has emerged as a critical stress test for India's economic resilience and foreign policy orientation. Critically analyse its implications and assess India's role in navigating competing interests while protecting its national priorities. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the West Asia conflict and India's role.
- **Body:** Write about the implications of West Asia conflicts, India's role in navigating competing interests while protecting its national priorities and suggest the way forward.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasising a proactive, integrated approach to ensure India safeguards its interests and regional credibility.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- The West Asia conflict strains India's **energy**, **trade**, and **diaspora**, testing its economic resilience and its management of **regional foreign policy**.

Implications of the West Asia Crisis for India

- **Energy Risk:** India imports **~60%** of crude oil and gas from West Asia. E.g., **tensions in the Strait of Hormuz** spike domestic fuel costs.
- **Diaspora Threat:** **10 million Indians** in West Asia face safety risks, and **remittance flows** are vulnerable.
- **Maritime Pressure:** Sinking of **IRIS Dena** exposes Indian Ocean risks, testing India's credibility as a **net security provider**.
- **Diplomatic Balance:** India must maintain ties with Israel, Iran, and Gulf states; the delayed **Minab response** showed **regional expectation gaps**.

India's Role in Navigating Competing Interests

- **Balanced Diplomacy:** India maintains ties with Israel, Iran, and Gulf nations to navigate competing regional interests.
- **Diaspora Safeguard:** **Ensures protection** and **evacuation of ~10 million Indians** in conflict zones, e.g., Operation Rahat, Yemen 2015.
- **Energy Security:** **Supplies fuel and manages strategic reserves** to stabilise domestic and regional energy needs during Gulf disruptions.
- **Strategic Autonomy:** Pursues **independent foreign policy decisions** to protect national priorities while managing international pressures.

Way Forward

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- ✓ **Regional Outreach: Strengthen dialogue** and **crisis coordination** with South Asian neighbours. E.g., SAARC COVID-19 virtual summit, 2020.
- ✓ **Maritime Leadership:** Consolidate India's role in **Indo-Pacific security**. E.g., Indian Navy-led patrols during Gulf tensions, 2026.
- ✓ **Economic Security:** Build **strategic reserves** and **diversify energy** partners. E.g., petroleum exports to Nepal and Bhutan during the 2026 Gulf oil disruption.
- ✓ **Diplomatic Balance: Calibrate responses** while maintaining a neutral image. E.g., parallel partnerships with Israel, Iran, and the UAE.

Conclusion

- The West Asia crisis challenges India's **resilience** and **regional leadership**; a **proactive combination** of **energy security**, **maritime strength**, and **balanced diplomacy** ensures credibility and strategic edge.

Q. Stability in West Asia is vital for India's economic and strategic interests. Discuss how the Israel–Hamas ceasefire can influence India's trade linkages, overseas community, and regional engagement. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- ❖ **Introduction:** Write a contextual introduction by mentioning the current facts and data.
- ❖ **Body:** Discuss how the Israel–Hamas ceasefire can influence India's trade linkages, overseas community, and regional engagement and stability risk.
- ❖ **Conclusion:** Emphasis on stable West Asia by mentioning the way forward.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- West Asia provides **60% of India's oil** and hosts **8 million Indians**; the Israel–Hamas ceasefire may ease **Red Sea trade risks** and enhance maritime security.

Israel–Hamas Ceasefire Influence on India

- ❖ **Trade Route:** Ceasefire may reopen the Red Sea, reducing Cape of Good Hope dependence.
- ❖ **Export Costs:** Eases freight for **90–95%** of India's overseas trade.
- ❖ **Diaspora Safety:** Protects 8 million Indians, ensuring secure remittances.
- ❖ **Strategic Gains:** Boosts Gulf ties and IMEC corridor efficiency by 40%.

Regional Stability Risks

- ❖ **Houthi Compliance:** 2023 attacks halted **90% of Red Sea shipping**, risking ceasefire success.
- ❖ **Freight Risk:** Route insecurity could **triple shipping costs**, as seen previously.
- ❖ **Export Vulnerability: $16 billion** in textiles and **$6 billion** in marine exports face profit losses.
- ❖ **Strategic Balance:** India must safeguard **$75–80 billion** energy imports and maritime routes.

Conclusion

- The Israel–Hamas ceasefire can stabilise West Asia, securing India's **trade linkages**, protecting **expatriates**, and enhancing **regional strategic engagement**.

-------- End of Chapter --------

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India's Relations with Major Powers & Strategic Regions

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India-US Relations *

❖ **Context (DDNEWS):** India–US relations have evolved into a strategic partnership, strengthening trade, defence, technology, global governance, security, economic growth, and global influence.

Evolution of India–US Relations

- **Cold Estrangement (1947–1991):** Ideological differences, **India's non-alignment**, and the **1971 Bangladesh war** strained ties with the US.
- **Economic Convergence (1991–2008):** India's **liberalisation** attracted US economic interest and counter-terror cooperation post-9/11.
- **Strategic Alignment (2008–2024):** Rising China drove **India-US collaboration** through defence, nuclear, and Indo-Pacific initiatives.
- **Institutionalisation (2008–2024):** Frameworks like the **123 Nuclear Deal**, **Major Defence Partnership**, and **2+2 Dialogue formalised strategic ties**.
- **Policy Strain (Trump Era):** **Make America Great Again (MAGA) nationalism**, tariffs, and restrictive **H-1B visas** created friction in bilateral relations.

Significance of India-US Relations

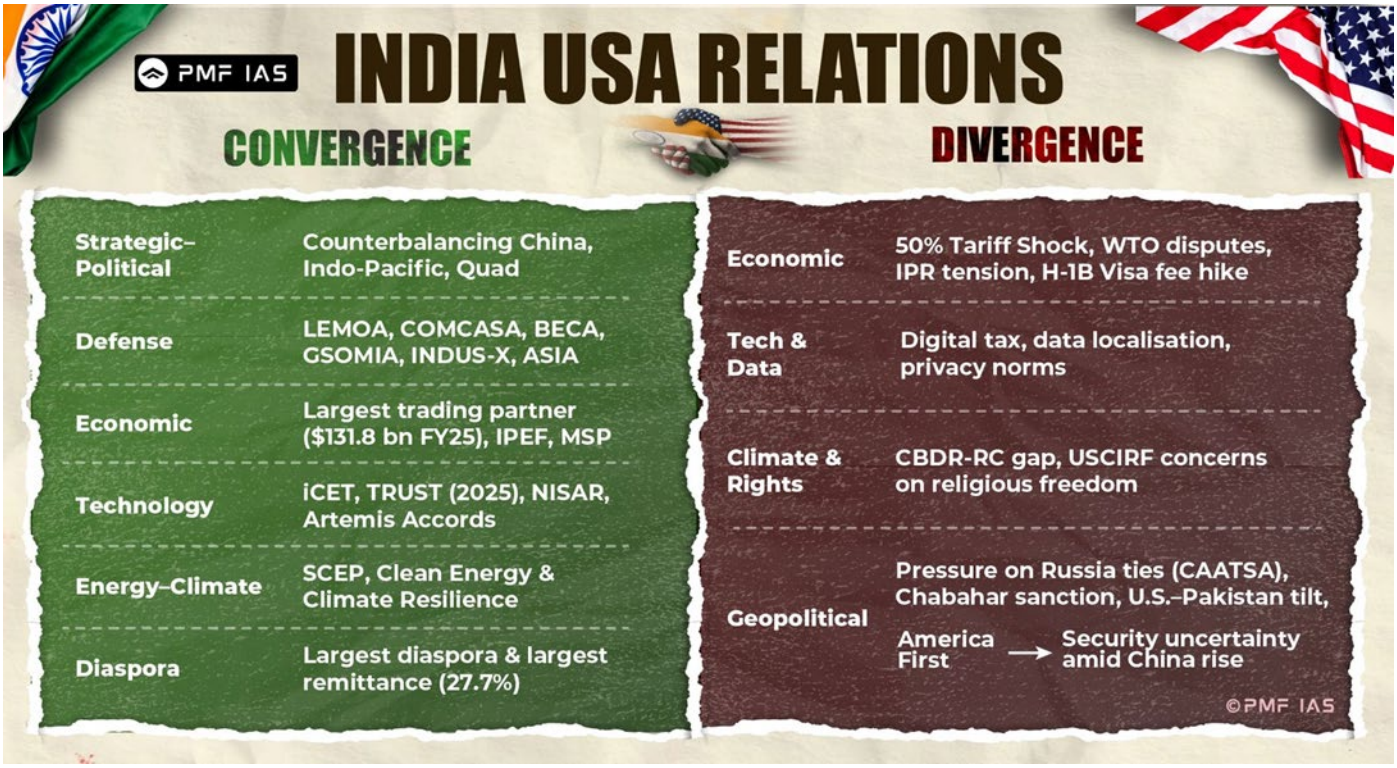
- **Economic Growth:** India–U.S. trade rose 72% from 2017–18 to 2022–23; the **U.S. is India's largest trading partner**, boosting jobs and investment.
- **Technological Partnership:** **ICET** drives cooperation in critical technologies, enhancing innovation and competitiveness.
- **Cultural Ties:** **Over 200,000 Indian students** study in the U.S., strengthening people-to-people and cultural exchanges.
- **Strategic Cooperation:** **Quad initiatives** support Indo-Pacific security and vaccine distribution; U.S.–India Clean Energy Partnership advances sustainable development.

India-US Relations: Cooperation

- **Political Cooperation:** **2+2 Dialogue** and **I2U2** enhance strategic coordination. E.g., India–US–Israel–UAE clean energy projects.
- **Economic Ties:** U.S. is India's largest partner ($131.84 bn in 2024–25); India joined the **Minerals Security Partnership** (MSP) to secure critical minerals.
- **Defence Collaboration:** **LEMOA**, **COMCASA**, **BECA** boost interoperability. E.g., INDUS-X fosters joint defence tech development.
- **Tech Cooperation:** **iCET**, **NISAR**, **Artemis Accords**, and **TRUST (2025)** advance AI, quantum, and space technology.
- **Energy & Culture:** **Strategic Clean Energy Partnership (SCEP)** promotes clean energy and climate resilience; Cultural Property Agreement curbs antiquities trafficking.

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Challenges

- **IPR Disputes:** The U.S. placed India on the 2024 **Priority Watch List** over pharmaceutical intellectual property concerns, affecting trade negotiations.
- **Trade Conflicts:** Disagreements at the **WTO on dispute resolution** and **e-commerce rules** hinder India–U.S. multilateral economic cooperation.
- **Climate Differences:** Divergence on **CBDR-RC** principles slows joint climate action, impacting initiatives like the U.S.–India **Strategic Clean Energy Partnership (SCEP)**.
- **Data Barriers:** Conflicting policies on data localisation, cross-border data flow, and digital taxation impact the India–U.S. tech trade, valued at approximately **$200 billion annually**.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Trade Disputes: Resolve tariff issues** (steel, aluminium) to strengthen bilateral economic ties.
- ✓ **Tech Collaboration:** Align **data privacy** and **cybersecurity** standards. E.g., establish a US–India Cybersecurity Forum.
- ✓ **Defence Cooperation:** Streamline procurement & technology transfers via DTTI. E.g., projects like JATGS.
- ✓ **Talent Mobility & IP: Ease H1-B visas** and strengthen IP dialogue. E.g., India–US IP Working Group.
- ✓ **Strategic Partnerships: Boost ICET** cooperation and regional diplomacy on Indo-Pacific security and counter-terrorism.

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India-Russia Relations

- **Context (PIB):** India and Russia mark **25 years of Strategic Partnership** and continue expanding cooperation across defence, energy, trade, connectivity, and multilateral platforms.

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India-Russia Relations: Evolution

- **<u>Planned Economy (1950s–60s):</u>** India adopted Soviet Five-Year Plans, with **USSR building Bhilai** (1955) and **Bokaro steel plants** to drive heavy industrialisation.

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- **Treaty Alliance (1971):** The Indo-Soviet Treaty ensured military support and repeated Soviet UNSC vetoes during the Bangladesh War.
- **Post-Soviet Shift (1991):** USSR's collapse weakened Russia, pushing India to diversify Westward while retaining ties via the **Intergovernmental Commission**.
- **Strategic Partnership (2000):** The **India-Russia Strategic Partnership** institutionalised cooperation in defence, nuclear energy, space, and S&T.
- **Privileged Status (2010):** Relations were elevated to a **"Special and Privileged Strategic Partnership,"** deepening defence co-production and energy ties.
- **2+2 Dialogue (2021):** The **Foreign** and **Defence Ministers' 2+2 Dialogue** reaffirmed strategic coordination amid shifting global alignments.
- **Strategic Balancing (2022–24):** Ukraine war, **Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA) risks**, over 35% Russian oil imports, S-400 deliveries, and Sino-Russian closeness tested India's multi-alignment.

Significance of Russia

- **Strategic Autonomy:** Russia is key to India's **multi-alignment doctrine**.
- **Energy Security:** Russia is India's top crude & fertilizer supplier (FY24–25: **$63.8 bn imports**).
- **Defence Backbone:** **Approximately 65%** of the Indian arsenal Russian origin.
- **Reformed Multilateralism:** Consistent Russian backing for **India's UNSC bid**.
- **Eurasian Connectivity:** Integration through **International North-South Transport Corridor** (INSTC), **Chennai–Vladivostok Corridor** (Eastern Maritime Corridor), Northern Sea Route.

India-Russia Relations: Cooperation

- **Trade Surge:** Bilateral trade hit a record **$68.7 billion** (FY 2024–25), driven by Russian energy imports and Indian exports of pharmaceuticals, chemicals, and steel.
- **Connectivity Push:** Projects like **INSTC**, **Chennai–Vladivostok Corridor**, and the **Northern Sea Route** aim to cut transit time, costs, and improve Eurasian logistics integration.
- **Defence Backbone:** The 2021–2031 military-technical pact enables co-production of **Su-30 MKI**, **T-90S**, **BrahMos**, **AK-203**, and induction of INS Tushil and INS Tamal.
- **Cultural Outreach:** Soft power ties deepened through **Bharat Utsav 2025** (8.5 lakh visitors), Indian Film Festivals in five Russian cities, and yoga-cinema exchanges.
- **Multilateral Synergy:** India and Russia coordinate in the **UN**, **G20**, **SCO**, and **BRICS**, with Russia backing India's UNSC permanent seat and India set to chair BRICS in 2026.

Challenges in India-Russia Relations

- **Strategic Autonomy:** India adopted **"strategic silence"** on the Ukraine war, balancing Western pressure with continued Russian oil imports (35%+ of crude in 2023–24).
- **Trilateral Drift:** Growing **Russia–China–Pakistan coordination** via SCO/BRICS and exercises like Druzhba-VI, dilutes India's traditional strategic primacy in Moscow's South Asia calculus.
- **Quad Dissonance:** Russia supports India's Indo-Pacific vision but criticises the Quad as an **"anti-China construct,"** complicating India's alignment choices.
- **Economic Frictions:** Bilateral trade shows a **$58.9 bn deficit**, with the **INSTC and Vladivostok corridor** underdeveloped and banking constrained post-SWIFT exclusion.

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➢ **Defence Diversification:** SIPRI notes Russian arms share fell from 76% (2009–13) to 36% (2019–23) as India sources from **France**, the **US**, and **Israel amid S-400 delays**.

Way Forward

✓ **Strategic Autonomy: Sustain balanced engagement** with both Russia and the West through a calibrated multi-alignment strategy.
✓ **Trade Diversification:** Expand Indian exports in pharmaceuticals, agriculture, and engineering goods to correct the trade imbalance.
✓ **Payment Stability: Institutionalise rupee–ruble settlement** or develop a secure digital payment corridor to bypass sanction-related disruptions.
✓ **Defence Co-development:** Strengthen joint R&D and production (BrahMos-II, naval propulsion) aligned with Make in India.
✓ **Connectivity Acceleration: Fast-track INSTC** and the **Chennai–Vladivostok corridor** to enhance Eurasian market access.

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India-EU Relations

❖ **Context (TH):** The announcement comes ahead of **European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen's** visit to New Delhi as the Chief Guest at India's **77th Republic Day**, underscoring the growing strategic depth of India–EU relations.

Evolution of India-EU Relations

- **Ancient Trade: Pliny the Elder's** concern over Rome's gold drain reflects thriving **Indo-Roman commerce**, marking the earliest India–Europe economic linkage.
- **Cold War: India – European Economic Community (EEC) ties (1962)** remained largely economic as India's non-alignment and Europe's US alignment constrained deeper strategic engagement.
- **Strategic Turn:** The **1994 Cooperation Agreement** and the **2004 Strategic Partnership** institutionalised broad-based political, economic, and security cooperation.
- **Agenda 2025: The New EU–India Strategic Agenda** anchors tie on five pillars: prosperity & sustainability, technology, security, connectivity, and global governance.

India-EU Cooperation

- **Strategic Alignment: EU's Global Gateway** and India's MAHASAGAR provide sustainable alternatives to China's BRI, reinforced by the EU joining **India-led Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative** (IOPI) in 2023.
- **Multilateral Reform:** Europe backs India's bid for **permanent UNSC membership** and **rules-based multilateralism** amid China's rise and relative US retrenchment.
- **Security Cooperation:** Joint naval drills in the **Gulf of Aden (2021)**, **EUNAVFOR Atalanta exercises**, and a **2025 counterterror drill** reflect growing maritime and CT coordination.
- **Economic Partnership: The EU is India's largest trading partner**, with goods trade at **$136 bn** in 2024–25, accounting for nearly 17% of India's exports.
- **Connectivity Corridors:** The 2021 Connectivity Partnership, India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor (2023), and the 11,700-km Blue Raman Cable integrate India–Europe trade, energy, and digital links via the Gulf and Africa.

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- **Technological Cooperation: S&T Agreement (2007)** and **Trade and Technology Council (2022)** enhance collaboration in research, technology, and innovation.
  - ESA–ISRO Proba-3 mission (2024) and **EURATOM-India nuclear research pact** (2020) strengthen scientific linkages.

Challenges in India-EU Relations

- **FTA Deadlock:** Divergences on tariffs, IPR, agriculture, and labour mobility delay agreement.
- **CBAM Dispute:** EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism impacts Indian exports.
- **Russia Divergence:** India's oil imports and defence ties with Moscow conflict with the EU's sanctions regime following **Russia's 2022 invasion of** Ukraine.
- **China Ambivalence:** EU's selective engagement with China contrasts with India's approach.
- **Internal EU Challenges:** Brexit, rising **Euroscepticism**, nationalism, and anti-immigrant politics strain the coherence of the EU.

Way Forward

- **Conclude FTA (2025):** Prioritise **phased liberalisation** and sectoral early-harvest deals.
- **Sustain Strategic Autonomy:** Balance relations with US, Russia, & EU to maintain multipolar flexibility.
- **Joint Global Governance Role:** Collaborate in the WTO, G20, and UN for **reformed multilateralism**.
- **Deepen Maritime Security:** Institutionalise **India–EUNAVFOR coordination** in the Indian Ocean.
- **Sustainable Connectivity:** Integrate the **EU's Global Gateway** with India's **MAHASAGAR** initiatives.

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India-EU FTA **

- **Context (TH): India** and the **European Union** have concluded a landmark **Free Trade Agreement**, marking a major upgrade in bilateral economic ties. The pact aims to boost trade, services, and investment while protecting sensitive domestic sectors.

About Free Trade Agreement (FTA)

- **Meaning:** FTAs are **agreements between two or more countries or economic blocs**. It aims to facilitate trade & eliminate or reduce barriers to the exchange of goods & services.
- **Deal Scale:** Dubbed the **"mother of all trade deals,"** it creates a **free-trade zone** spanning a combined market of **2 billion people**, representing about **25% of global GDP**.
- **Timeline:** The agreement is expected to **apply provisionally by Q4 2026** and **fully enter force** by **early 2027** after ratification.
- **Review Clause:** A **joint committee** will review the agreement **every two years** to resolve implementation issues and update its provisions.

Key Provisions of India-EU Free Trade Agreement

- The India–EU Free Trade Agreement is a landmark, next-generation pact expanding trade in goods and services while safeguarding strategic, regulatory, and developmental interests.

Trade in Goods

- **EU Commitments:** The European Union will **eliminate tariffs** on **99.5% of India's exports by value**, granting **immediate zero-duty access to 90.7%** of India's export value.

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- **India Concessions:** India grants tariff concessions covering **97.5% of EU import value**, with duty elimination or reduction across **92.1% of tariff lines**.
- **Tariff Schedule:** While **customs duties on 49.6%** of European tariff lines are eliminated immediately, India adopts **phased cuts** over **5**, **7**, and **10 years** for the remaining 39.5% of lines.
- **Labour Sectors:** **Labour-intensive sectors** like **textiles**, apparel, **leather**, **footwear**, gems and jewellery, and **marine products** will receive immediate duty-free access.
- **Sensitive Exclusion:** Sensitive sectors, including **dairy**, **cereals**, **poultry**, and **sugar**, are **excluded from the agreement** to protect domestic producers.
- **Auto Imports:** Import duties on **European automobiles** will be progressively **reduced to 10%**, with a fixed **annual quota** of **250,000 units**.

Trade in Services

- **Market Access:** India gains access to **144 EU service subsectors**, including IT, professional services, and education, while the European Union gains access to 102 Indian subsectors.
- **Professional Movement:** The EU provides binding commitments to **ease visa requirements** for Indian **IT professionals**, **nurses**, and **consultants**.
- **Commercial Presence:** European companies gain **privileged access** to India's **financial**, **legal**, and **maritime services** markets.
- **Family Rights:** Spouses and dependents of intra-corporate transferees are granted both **entry** and **work rights**.
- **AYUSH Provision:** For the first time, **AYUSH practitioners** may work **under home titles** in EU states where these practices remain unregulated.
- **Source Code:** The pact **prohibits** the **mandatory transfer of source code** as a **condition for market access**, thereby safeguarding the intellectual property of Indian IT firms.

Regulatory Framework

- **Rules Origin:** The agreement adopts **Product-Specific Rules** (PSRs) with **self-certified 'Statements of Origin'** to determine origin and reduce the compliance burden.
- **SPS Alignment:** An Equivalence Agreement on Sanitary and Phytosanitary measures aims to harmonise standards and reduce the rejection rate for Indian agricultural exports.
- **CBAM Dialogue:** A formal **Technical Dialogue** is created to align carbon reporting standards under the **CBAM** to protect Indian exporters from unfair taxation.
- **Rebalancing Mechanism:** India retains the right to **impose retaliatory tariffs** if EU **non-tariff barriers** (like CBAM) **nullify trade benefits**.

Significance of India-EU Free Trade Agreement

- **Strategic Autonomy:** Deep economic integration with the EU may strengthen India's strategic autonomy by diversifying dependencies beyond the US-China binary.
- **Technology Spillovers:** Cheaper imports of European high-tech machinery and precision equipment will likely accelerate modernisation and automation of Indian industries.
- **Export Parity:** Duty-free access will **level the playing field** for Indian exporters vis-à-vis **Bangladesh** and **Vietnam**, which enjoy prior preferential access.
- **Standards Upgrade:** Alignment with stringent European standards may incentivise modernisation of India's domestic quality control and production ecosystems.

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Concerns with the India-EU Free Trade Agreement

- **Phytosanitary Barriers:** Strict European **phytosanitary standards** may continue to **restrict** Indian **agricultural exports** despite the equivalence agreement.
- **CBAM Impact:** The Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (**CBAM**) can **erode tariff advantages** for Indian steel and aluminium exporters by imposing additional compliance costs.
- **MSME Competition:** Increased imports of European machinery and chemicals may pose **competitive challenges** for **domestic MSMEs** that lack economies of scale.
- **Data Status:** The absence of the **EU "Data Secure" status** for India will **limit cross-border flows** of sensitive personal data required for advanced IT services.
- **Rules Origin:** Complex **'Rules of Origin'** requirements have **historically lowered FTA utilisation rates** among Indian exporters.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Export Readiness:** Strengthen MSMEs' capacity through credit, standards support, and trade facilitation to maximise FTA utilisation.
- ✓ **CBAM Mitigation:** Accelerate industrial decarbonisation and develop credible carbon accounting to minimise CBAM-related cost shocks.
- ✓ **Standards Alignment:** **Upgrade Sanitary and Phytosanitary (SPS)**, **quality**, and conformity infrastructure to meet EU norms and reduce export rejections.
- ✓ **Data & Digital Trust:** Pursue EU **"Data Secure/Adequacy" status** to unlock high-value digital and IT-enabled services trade.
- ✓ **Implementation Review:** Use the biennial joint review mechanism to simplify rules of origin, resolve Non-Tariff Barriers (NTBs), and recalibrate sectoral safeguards.

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India–France Relations

❖ **Context (IE):** French President Emmanuel Macron's fourth India visit elevated ties to a **Special Global Strategic Partnership**, aiming to ensure **"stability and progress"** amid unpredictable global dynamics.

Historical Evolution

- **Post-Independence Engagement (1947–1998):** Cordial ties with cooperation in space and civil nuclear energy, while **France respected India's strategic autonomy**.
- **Strategic Partnership (1998):** France became the **first Western nation to sign a Strategic Partnership** with India after Pokhran-II, expanding defence and security cooperation.
- **Institutional Consolidation (2006–2018):** **Defence Cooperation Agreement (2006)**, **Civil Nuclear Agreement (2008)**, & **Reciprocal Logistics Support Agreement (2018)** deepened ties.
- **Special Global Strategic Partnership (2023–present):** Broadened collaboration into Indo-Pacific security, AI, space (**TRISHNA**, Gaganyaan), clean energy, and innovation under the **Horizon 2047 vision**.

India–France Special Global Strategic Partnership

- **Diplomatic Elevation:** The bilateral relationship was formally elevated to a **Special Global Strategic Partnership** to strengthen Indo-Pacific cooperation.

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- **Institutional Oversight:** An **Annual Foreign Ministers Dialogue** was instituted to monitor the implementation of the **Horizon 2047 goals**.
- **Defence Production:** A Joint Venture (JV) between **BEL** and **Safran** was established to **localise** HAMMER missile manufacturing in India.
- **Military Interoperability:** **Reciprocal liaison officers** were deployed at Indian Army and French Land Forces establishments to strengthen field-level coordination.
- **Human Capital:** The countries signed a Letter of Intent (LoI) to establish a **National Centre of Excellence for Skilling in Aeronautics**.
- **Fiscal Alignment:** Both countries signed a protocol to amend the **Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement** (DTAA) to ease cross-border investments.
- **Digital Infrastructure:** The **Indo-French Centre for Digital Sciences** was launched to co-develop trusted public infrastructure and emerging technologies.
- **Logistics Modernisation:** The **Department of Posts** (India) and **La Poste** (France) signed a Letter of Intent (LoI) to co-develop **e-commerce logistics** and **digital postal services**.
- **Innovation Synergy:** The **India-France Year of Innovation 2026** was launched to foster R&D synergy between startups and research institutions.
- **Healthcare AI:** **AIIMS**, **New Delhi**, will host the **Indo-French Centre for AI in Health** to integrate advanced AI into diagnostic processes.
- **Professional Mobility:** France operationalised a **five-year Schengen visa** for Indian Master's alumni to streamline professional and academic travel.

India-France Cooperation

- **Defence Modernisation:** India's acquisition of **Rafale jets** and **Scorpene submarines** strengthens military capability and joint operational readiness. E.g., **Varuna**, **Shakti**, **Garuda exercises**.
- **Tech Collaboration:** Partnership in space and technology, including **TRISHNA climate satellite** and ISRO's Gaganyaan mission, enhances India's strategic tech edge.
- **Economic Ties:** France is India's **3rd largest trade partner** in the **EU**, bilateral trade of **$15.11 bn** and FDI of **$10.5 bn** supports industrial growth and investment flows between India and France.
- **Energy Cooperation:** Joint nuclear projects like Jaitapur, Small Modular Reactors (SMRs), and Advanced Modular Reactors (AMRs), along with International Solar Alliance (ISA) solar initiatives, advance clean energy and climate goals.
- **Cultural Integration:** Strong people-to-people ties with **1.19 lakh Indians** in France and digital integration via **UPI (NPCI–Lyra)** foster social and technological connectivity.

Defence Cooperation Agreement

- **Strategic Transition:** The **2006 Defence Cooperation Agreement** operationalised Indo-French relations into a **comprehensive military partnership** under the **1998 Strategic Partnership framework**.
- **Technology Transfer:** It established a formal mechanism for the **transfer of defence technology**; India developed **six Scorpene submarines** under **Project 75**, using French technology.
- **Institutional Oversight:** The **High Committee on Defence Cooperation** (**HCDC**), led by **Defence Secretaries**, was created to oversee military, industrial, and research collaboration.
- **Joint Exercises:** The 2006 agreement formalised **three major bilateral exercises**, namely **Varuna** (Navy), **Garuda** (Air Force), and **Shakti** (Army; initiated in 2011).

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- **Security Dialogue:** Both nations institutionalised a **systematic exchange of views** on counter-terrorism and global security threats.
- **Logistics Access:** The **Reciprocal Logistics Support Agreement** (**2018**) expanded the DCA by allowing the **Indian Navy to use French bases** in the **Indian Ocean** (like Reunion Island) and vice versa.

Key Challenges in India–France Relations

- **Nuclear Liability Barriers:** India's **Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act (2010)** imposes supplier liability, slowing French investments in **Jaitapur** and **nuclear expansion**.
- **Geopolitical Divergences:** Differences over the Russia-Ukraine conflict and West Asia positions create occasional diplomatic misalignment.
- **Trade Barriers:** EU strict **Sanitary and Phytosanitary (SPS)** measures and disputes, such as basmati GI recognition, restrict India's export access to French and EU markets.
- **Stalled India–EU FTA:** The India-EU **Broad-based Trade and Investment Agreement (BTIA)** negotiations have remained unresolved since 2007, limiting the full realisation of bilateral economic potential.
- **IPR Issues:** French companies cite weak IPR protection in India, particularly in pharmaceuticals, technology, and luxury goods.

Way Forward

- **Indo-Pacific Engagement:** Expand joint maritime presence & coordination across the Indo-Pacific.
- **Defence Co-Production:** Accelerate joint R&D and manufacturing and foster innovation through **FRIND-X** (France-India Defence Startup Excellence), connecting startups, investors, and agencies.
- **Green Cooperation:** Scale collaboration in renewable, green hydrogen, & climate resilience initiatives.
- **High-Technology Partnerships:** Enhance cooperation in AI, quantum technology, space systems, and other dual-use technologies.

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India-Japan Relations

Context (IE | TP): India and Japan concluded their **18th Strategic Dialogue in New Delhi**, co-chaired by the Indian External Affairs Minister and his Japanese counterpart.

Evolution of India-Japan Relations

- **Civilisational Linkages:** Buddhism spread from India to Japan via China and Korea (6th century), forming an enduring cultural–spiritual bond.
- **Freedom Struggle Ties:** Indian revolutionaries like **Rash Bihari Bose** and **Subhash Chandra Bose** forged close links with Japan during the colonial period.
- **Cold War Phase:** Diplomatic relations were formalised with the **1952 Peace Treaty**, though ties remained limited due to Japan's U.S. alignment and India's non-alignment.
- **Strategic Engagement (2006–13):** India–Japan relations deepened with the **Strategic and Global Partnership** and the **CEPA (2011)**, boosting trade.
- **Special Strategic Phase (2014 onwards):** Partnership upgraded under **Modi–Abe**, marked by the **2016 Civil Nuclear Agreement**, signalling high strategic trust.

Significance of India–Japan Relations

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- **Indo-Pacific Stability:** India and Japan anchor the Quad to uphold a **Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP)** and a rules-based order, countering China's regional assertiveness.
- **Global Governance:** Both countries coordinate in forums like the G20, G4, and the UN to advocate reforms reflecting contemporary power realities.
- **Derisking Global Economy:** The **Supply Chain Resilience Initiative** (**SCRI**), a trilateral framework with **Australia**, diversifies supply chains to reduce over-reliance on a single country.
- **Africa Engagement:** Joint efforts for African development through the **Asia-Africa Growth Corridor** (**AAGC**) and the Japan–India Cooperation Initiative for Sustainable Economic Development in Africa.
- **Regional Connectivity:** Through the **Act East Forum**, Japan partners in developing India's **Northeast**, strengthening industrial linkages and **cross-border connectivity** with **Bangladesh**.

India-Japan Relations: Cooperation

- **Partnership Status:** India and Japan elevated bilateral ties to a **Special Strategic Partnership** in **2014**.
- **Strategic Frameworks:** Cooperation rests on the **Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation** (**2008**) and the **Acquisition and Cross-Servicing Agreement** (ACSA, 2020) for logistics support.
- **Defence Engagement:** The **2+2 Ministerial Dialogue** anchors security talks, complemented by regular military drills like JIMEX, Dharma Guardian, and Veer Guardian.
- **Trade Relations:** The **2011 Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement** (**CEPA**) liberalised trade; bilateral trade reached about USD 25.15 billion (FY 2024–25), with a trade deficit favouring **Japan**.
- **Investments:** Japan is India's **5th largest** FDI source, with investment of around **USD 43 billion** (2024).
  - ❖ Building on a **JPY 5 trillion target** set in **2022**, the '**Joint Vision for the Next Decade**' (2025) aims for an additional **JPY 10 trillion** in private investment.
- **Development Cooperation:** Japan has been India's largest **Official Development Assistance (ODA)** donor since 1958; flagship projects include the **Mumbai–Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail** (MAHSR).
- **Technology Linkages:** Collaboration spans **AI**, semiconductors, **ISRO–JAXA LUPEX mission**, and the Clean Energy Partnership (2022).
- **Demographic Alignment:** To balance Japan's ageing population and India's youth bulge, both sides agreed to facilitate the mobility of **500,000** skilled Indian workers over **five years**.

Challenges

- ➢ **Divergent Regional Priorities:** India focuses on South Asia and the Indian Ocean, while Japan's strategic concerns lie in East Asia-China, North Korea, and alliance obligations with the U.S.
- ➢ **Trade Imbalance:** Despite **USD 25.15 bn bilateral trade**, India faces a large deficit due to low exports and restrictive non-tariff barriers in Japan's market.
- ➢ **Defence Procurement Stalemate:** The long-pending **ShinMaywa US-2 amphibious aircraft** deal underscores sluggish progress in defence cooperation.
- ➢ **Slow Project Implementation:** Flagship projects such as the **Asia–Africa Growth Corridor** (**AGFC)** & the **Ahmedabad–Mumbai Bullet** Train face delays due to land acquisition issues & bureaucratic red tape.
- ➢ **Limited People-to-People Connectivity:** **Only about 54,000 Indians** live in Japan, and student exchanges remain minimal compared to India–US or Japan–Korea ties, limiting cultural intimacy.

Way Forward

- ✓ **CEPA Review:** **Conduct a review of the CEPA** to address trade imbalances and expand market access.
- ✓ **Defence Modernisation:** Fast-track pending projects like the **ShinMaywa US-2** amphibious aircraft and expand joint exercises such as **Dharma Guardian** to enhance interoperability.

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- ✓ **Technological Collaboration:** Deepen cooperation in semiconductors, AI, and 5G, leveraging the **2023 Semiconductor Supply Chain Partnership** for digital resilience.
- ✓ **Maritime and Strategic Security:** Bolster coordination under **Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP)** to counter Chinese assertiveness in the East China Sea and Indian Ocean Region.

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India-Australia Relations

❖ **Context (TH | TH):** India and Australia share a longstanding relationship rooted in **historical ties**, **democratic values**, and growing **people-to-people connections**.

Significance of Australia for India

- **Strategic Partnership:** India-Australia **Comprehensive Strategic Partnership 2020** strengthens Indo-Pacific security and Quad ties.
- **Critical Minerals:** Australia supplies **lithium**, **cobalt**, and **rare earths** vital for India's clean energy.
- **Clean Energy:** **Green Hydrogen** & **Solar Taskforces** advance renewable energy & storage projects.
- **People-Education:** India is the second-largest migrant group & the top international student source.

Expanding Horizons of India–Australia Cooperation

- **Strategic Defence:** India–Australia **Comprehensive Strategic Partnership 2020** deepened defence ties through **AUSINDEX** and **Malabar drills**, enhancing Indo-Pacific security cooperation.
- **Trade Boost:** Bilateral trade reached **US$24.1 billion (FY25)** under Ind-Aus ECTA, with CECA talks targeting **US$100 billion by 2030**.
- **Mineral Security: KABIL–CMFO MoU** enables India's investment in Australia's **lithium and cobalt** projects for the clean energy transition.
- **Science Cooperation:** **Australia-India Strategic Research Fund** (**AISRF**) funded joint R&D on quantum tech, critical minerals, and digital health.
- **Green Energy:** Green Hydrogen and Solar Taskforces drive collaboration on renewables, storage, and Net Zero targets.

India-Australia Relations: Challenges

- ➢ **Trade Gap:** India's trade deficit with Australia was **$6.9 bn in FY25**, led by coal & mineral imports.
- ➢ **Market Barriers:** Despite **ECTA (2022)**, India faces hurdles in pharma and agri exports to Australia.
- ➢ **Strategic Differences:** Divergent stances on **China** & **AUKUS** occasionally test Indo-Pacific alignment.
- ➢ **Visa Delays:** Over **1.2 lakh Indian students** in Australia face visa and safety challenges.
- ➢ **Diaspora Threat:** Rising anti-India rallies in Australia strain bilateral goodwill.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Trade Expansion:** Fast-track **CECA negotiations** to raise bilateral trade to **US$100 billion by 2030**.
- ✓ **Critical Minerals Partnership:** Accelerate joint projects under **KABIL–CMFO MoU** for lithium and cobalt supply chains.
- ✓ **Defence Synergy:** Deepen **2+2 Dialogue** and joint exercises like **AUSINDEX 2023** to boost Indo-Pacific security cooperation.
- ✓ **Education & Mobility:** Leverage the **Australia-India Education Qualification Recognition Mechanism** to ease student and workforce movement.

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{IR – Bilateral Relations} India-Canada Relations

❖ **Context (IE): Canadian PM Mark Carney's** visit to India signalled a formal reset of bilateral ties following the 2023 diplomatic crisis over the Nijjar assassination allegations.

Key Outcome of PM Carney's Visit to India

- **Fuel Security:** **Canada's Cameco** will supply **uranium ore concentrates from 2027 to 2035** to support India's nuclear energy expansion.
- **Trade Talks:** Negotiations for the **Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement** (**CEPA**) formally resumed, with a **target to conclude by end-2026**.
- **Trade Target:** A **$50 billion bilateral trade target** was set for **2030**.
- **Climate Entry:** Canada announced its **intent to join** the **International Solar Alliance** (ISA) and upgrade to **full membership** in the **Global Biofuels Alliance** (GBA).
- **Tech Partnership:** The trilateral **Australia-Canada-India Technology and Innovation** (**ACITI**) **Partnership** will advance cooperation in emerging technologies.
- **Agri Centre:** The **India-Canada Pulse Protein Centre of Excellence** was announced at **NIFTEM-Kundli, Haryana,** with a focus on fortified pulse products.
- **Student Mobility:** Canada will offer **fully funded research internships** to 300 Indian students each year.
- **Mineral MoU:** A MoU on **Critical Minerals Cooperation** was signed to build secure and resilient mineral supply chains.

Areas of Cooperation in India–Canada Relations

- India and Canada are celebrating **79 years** of diplomatic relations in **2026** under a **Renewed Strategic Partnership** following a period of diplomatic strain.
- **Trade Volume:** Total bilateral merchandise trade reached **~$9 billion in FY 2024-25**.
- **Trade Balance:** Both merchandise and services trade remain in **Canada's favour**.
  - ❖ **Export Basket:** Pharmaceuticals, iron and steel, jewellery, textiles, organic chemicals, etc.
  - ❖ **Import Basket:** Pulses (lentils), coal, fertilisers, wood pulp, newsprint, etc.
- **Defence:** An **India-Canada Defence Dialogue** was formalised during PM Carney's 2026 visit.
- **Diaspora:** **Persons of Indian origin** constitute **around 5% of Canada's population** (**~2 million**).
  - ❖ India remains the largest source of **international students in Canada**, with **nearly 4 lakh enrolled**.
- **Key Divergences:** Khalistani extremism, free speech interpretation, selective human rights criticism, and extradition delays.

Factors Behind the India-Canada Diplomatic Crisis

- ➢ **Vote-Bank Politics:** Canada's accommodation of Khalistani sympathisers undermined India's sovereignty and security interests.
- ➢ **Divergent Worldview:** Conflicting stances on **cross-border terrorism**, **human rights**, and **free speech absolutism** widened the foreign policy gap.
- ➢ **Intelligence Standoff:** The Five Eyes Alliance's mobilisation over **Nijjar assassination allegations** escalated the bilateral dispute into a **multilateral crisis**.
- ➢ **Migration Friction:** Canada imposed **strict new visa caps**, while **India suspended e-visa services**, disrupting mobility of the Indian diaspora.

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- **Extradition Failure:** Canada's refusal to act on Interpol Red Corner Notices remains an unresolved bilateral friction point.

Key Developments Reshaping India-Canada Relations

- ✓ **Political Reset:** The newly elected Canadian administration **reinstated High Commissioners** and **retracted public allegations**.
- ✓ **Trade Revival:** India and Canada **resumed CEPA negotiations** and revived the bilateral **CEO Forum**.
- ✓ **Security Frameworks:** NSA-level **dialogues were renewed** for intelligence-sharing, law enforcement, and counter-terrorism cooperation.
- ✓ **Tech Cooperation:** Joint commitments on **AI**, **critical minerals**, and **digital public infrastructure** (DPI) unlocked new frontiers for bilateral cooperation in emerging technologies.
- ✓ **Energy Security:** The re-established **Ministerial Energy Dialogue** (CIMED) and new long-term **uranium agreements** integrated strategic energy supply chains.

Read More > *India-Canada Relations*

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India-New Zealand Relations

❖ **Context (PIB):** The **India–New Zealand FTA** marks a new era of economic partnership, boosting trade, investment, innovation, talent mobility, and resilient supply chains.

Key Highlights of the India–New Zealand FTA

- **100% Duty-Free Access:** New Zealand grants **zero-duty access** to all Indian exports, benefiting MSMEs, textiles, leather, footwear, and gems.
- **Investment Commitment:** New Zealand has committed **US$20 billion FDI** in India over the next **15 years**.
- **Sensitive Sector Protection:** India offers market access on **70% tariff lines (95% bilateral trade)** while excluding dairy, sugar, onions, and other sensitive products.
- **Rules of Origin:** Robust **Product Specific Rules of Origin (PSRs)** prevent misuse of tariff concessions and trade diversion.
- **Talent Mobility:** Provides **5,000 Temporary Employment Visas** annually and post-study work opportunities for Indian STEM graduates.
- **Services & AYUSH:** Opens **118 service sectors** with **MFN treatment in 139 sub-sectors** and recognizes **AYUSH, Ayurveda, and Yoga**.
- **Agricultural Cooperation:** Promotes **agricultural productivity partnerships**, Centres of Excellence, technology transfer, and knowledge sharing for farmers.

Challenges

- **Low Trade Volume:** Bilateral merchandise trade is **only US$1.3 billion** (2024–25), far below its potential.
- **Sensitive Sector Exclusion:** Around **30% tariff lines** (dairy, sugar, onions, edible oils, etc.) remain excluded to protect Indian farmers.
- **Distance & Logistics:** Long maritime routes increase freight costs and reduce export competitiveness despite tariff benefits.
- **High Standards Compliance:** Strict **Sanitary and Phytosanitary, Technical Barriers to Trade, and Product-Specific Rules of Origin** (**PSRs**) may pose challenges for Indian MSMEs.

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- **FTA Utilisation Gap:** Many MSMEs lack awareness and export readiness, limiting gains from 100% duty-free market access.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Boost Export Competitiveness:** Improve quality, branding, and value addition to maximise 100% duty-free access in New Zealand.
- ✓ **Empower MSMEs:** Expand export credit, digital trade support, and FTA awareness for labour-intensive sectors like textiles and leather.
- ✓ **Fast-track Investments:** Operationalise the **US$20 billion FDI** commitment through ease of doing business and policy stability.
- ✓ **Expand Strategic Sectors:** Deepen cooperation in AI, renewable energy, semiconductors, food processing, and digital public infrastructure.
- ✓ **Strengthen Human Capital:** Fully utilise **5,000 skilled visas**, **post-study work rights**, and collaboration in AYUSH, education, and research.

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India–South Korea Relations *

❖ **Context (IE): South Korean President Lee Jae Myung** completed his maiden three-day state visit to India, elevating the **Special Strategic Partnership** into a **'futuristic partnership'**.

Key Outcomes of the South Korean President's Visit to India

- **Strategic Partnership:** India and South Korea adopted a **Joint Strategic Vision** to elevate their **Special Strategic Partnership** through 2030.
- **Industrial Synergy:** The **Chips to Ships initiative** was launched to combine South Korea's semiconductor and shipbuilding expertise with India's manufacturing goals.
- **Digital Integration:** The **India-Korea Digital Bridge** was established to promote joint research and development in AI and next-generation IT services.
- **Trade Target:** Bilateral trade was targeted to **nearly double** from $27 billion to **$50 billion by 2030**, at an annual growth rate of 18%.
- **CEPA Upgrade:** Negotiations were formally resumed to upgrade the **2010 Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement** (CEPA) within one year.
- **Industrial Township:** A **Korean Industrial Township** with **plug-and-play infrastructure** will be established in India to attract Korean investment, targeting small and medium enterprises.
- **Defence Accelerator:** The **Korea-India Defence Accelerator** (**KIND-X**) was launched to connect defence startups, businesses, incubators, and investors from both countries.
- **Alliance Membership:** South Korea officially joined the **International Solar Alliance** (ISA) and the **Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative** (IPOI) to support regional stability.
- **GGGI Membership:** India announced its decision to join the **Global Green Growth Institute** (GGGI), headquartered in **Seoul**, to coordinate climate action.
- **Friendship Year:** Both countries **designated 2028-29** as the **Year of India-ROK Friendship**, anchored in K-pop, cinema, and sports.

Significance of South Korea for India

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- **Semiconductor Access:** South Korean expertise supports **India Semiconductor Mission** (ISM) by integrating Korean **3D packaging** and **design IP** into India's domestic supply chains.
- **Shipbuilding Edge:** Its **22% share** of global shipbuilding output makes **South Korea India's primary partner** for maritime modernisation.
- **Talent Demand:** South Korea's **ageing tech workforce** and **shrinking working-age population** create direct demand for India's software engineers and digital talent.
- **Energy Security:** **Seoul's naphtha imports** give South Korea a non-Middle East supply source and India a stable **refined petroleum export market**.
- **Cultural Bridge:** **Hallyu's consumer reach** in India builds a soft power foundation for Indian wellness, arts, and cinema across East Asian markets.

Challenges in India–South Korea Relations

- **Trade Imbalance:** Bilateral trade remains below potential at **$27 billion**, with India facing a persistent merchandise trade deficit.
- **CEPA Constraints:** Delayed **2010 CEPA** upgrade and non-tariff barriers continue to limit exports, investment and market access.
- **Regional Security:** North Korean tensions and Indo-Pacific strategic competition complicate deeper defence and technology cooperation.
- **Investment Gaps:** Regulatory delays, land acquisition issues and supply-chain bottlenecks constrain Korean investments under **Make in India** and semiconductor initiatives.

Way Forward

- **CEPA Upgrade:** Conclude the upgraded **CEPA** by 2027 to achieve the **$50 billion** bilateral trade target by **2030**.
- **Technology Partnership:** Expand collaboration in semiconductors, AI, shipbuilding and defence under **India Semiconductor Mission** and **KIND-X** initiatives.
- **Supply Diversification:** Build resilient Indo-Pacific supply chains through joint manufacturing, critical minerals cooperation and trusted technology partnerships.
- **People Connect:** Strengthen academic exchanges, skilled mobility and cultural diplomacy through the **2028–29 India–ROK Friendship Year** and innovation partnerships.

Read More > *India and South Korea Signed Four MoUs*

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India-Vietnam Relations

- **Context (IE):** India and Vietnam elevated their ties to an **Enhanced Comprehensive Strategic Partnership** following President Lam's state visit, setting a trade target of $25 billion by 2030.
- Vietnam formally joined the Indo-Pacific Oceans Initiative (IPOI) and signed a UPI linkage agreement for cross-border transactions.

Overview of India-Vietnam Relations

- **Trade**: Vietnam is India's **4th-largest trading partner in ASEAN**, with bilateral trade reaching $16.46 billion in 2025. The balance of trade is in **favour of Vietnam**.
- **Trade Basket:** India mainly exports frozen bovine meat, engineering goods, and pharmaceuticals, while importing electrical and electronic equipment, machinery, and inorganic chemicals.

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- **Defence:** The **Joint Vision Statement for 2030** aims to drive joint development of advanced defence platforms. India has extended a $500 million defence credit line to strengthen maritime security.
- **Joint Exercises:** **VINBAX** (Army) and **Sahyog** (Coast Guard).
- **Cultural Link:** Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has been restoring **My Son Sanctuary**, a UNESCO World Heritage Site and a 4th-13th-century Champa Hindu temple complex in Vietnam.
- **Strategic Convergence:** Rules-based Indo-Pacific order, freedom of navigation, and deeper ASEAN-India and Quad-adjacent cooperation.

Challenges in India–Vietnam Relations

- **Trade Imbalance:** Bilateral trade remains skewed in Vietnam's favour, limiting balanced economic gains for India.
- **Connectivity Gaps:** Weak maritime and air connectivity restricts the faster expansion of trade and tourism linkages.
- **Supply Chain Dependence:** Over-reliance on external supply chains, especially electronics, limits diversification of the trade basket.
- **Regional Geopolitics:** **South China Sea tensions** and **China's influence** complicate deeper strategic coordination.

Way Forward for India–Vietnam Relations

- **Balanced Trade:** Expand Indian exports in pharma, IT, and engineering to reduce trade imbalance.
- **Enhanced Connectivity:** Strengthen direct shipping routes, air links, and ASEAN integration frameworks for smoother trade flow.
- **Defence Cooperation:** Deepen joint production, capacity building, and maritime domain awareness under the 2030 vision.
- **Cultural & Digital Links:** Promote tourism, digital cooperation, and heritage restoration to strengthen people-to-people ties.

Read More > *Vietnam's Economic Transformation & Lessons for India*

IR – India - West Asia} India-West Asia Relations

❖ **Context (IE):** As West Asia witnesses overlapping conflicts and shifting regional alignments, India must pursue a balanced, **multi-vector diplomacy** to protect its long-term national interests.

Evolution of India's West Asia Policy

- **Non-Alignment (1947–1991):** Prioritised Arab solidarity, support for Palestine, energy security, and labour migration under the **Non-Aligned Movement** (NAM).
- **Strategic Opening (1991–2014):** Normalised ties with Israel, expanded engagement with GCC countries, and launched the **Look West Policy**.
- **Multi-Alignment (2014–Present):** Adopted the **Think West Policy** and pursued **de-hyphenation**, engaging all major regional powers independently.

West Asia Significance for India

- **Energy Security:** The Gulf remains crucial for India's crude and LNG supply and price stability.
- **Remittances:** ~90 lakh Indians live in the region; remittances from Gulf countries like the UAE.

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- **Maritime Security:** India has gained access to the strategically located **Duqm port** in Oman.
- **Connectivity & Trade:** Chabahar, **North-South Transport Corridor** (INSTC), & **India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC**) aimed at Eurasian access, Central Asia outreach & alternatives to Suez.
- **Technology:** Collaboration with Israel on **agri-tech**, water management, defence, & start-ups.

India–West Asia Cooperation

- **Energy Security:** West Asia supplies **55–60%** of India's crude oil and nearly **50% of LNG** imports, ensuring long-term energy security.
- **Trade & Investment:** Bilateral trade exceeds **US$200 billion**; United Arab Emirates is India's 3rd-largest trading partner under the CEPA.
- **Defence & Security:** India co-developed the **Barak-8 missile** with Israel; **40%** of India's crude imports transit the Strait of Hormuz.
- **Connectivity:** Chabahar Port, the **International North-South Transport Corridor** and the **India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor** strengthen connectivity to Central Asia and Europe, bypassing Pakistan.
- **Diaspora & Multilateralism:** **Around 9 million Indians** reside in Gulf countries, while I2U2 advances co-operation in food, technology, energy, and innovation.

Challenges in India–West Asia Relations

- **Strategic Balancing:** Balancing defence ties with Israel while **maintaining strong partnerships** with Arab states and Iran amid regional conflicts.
- **Sanctions & Energy:** US sanctions on Iran constrain energy imports and delay the development of **Chabahar Port** and the **International North-South Transport Corridor**.
- **Connectivity Challenges:** Geopolitical conflicts, Red Sea disruptions, and instability hinder projects like the **India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor** and regional supply chains.
- **Chinese Competition:** China's **Belt and Road Initiative** (**BRI**) and expanding strategic footprint reduce India's economic and geopolitical influence in West Asia.
- **Pakistan Factor:** Pakistan's defence ties with Gulf countries and Turkey's pro-Islamabad stance complicate India's diplomatic and security interests.

Way Forward for India–West Asia Relations

- ✓ **Strategic Autonomy:** Maintain balanced engagement with Israel, Arab states, and Iran through multi-alignment and strategic autonomy.
- ✓ **Economic Integration:** Fast-track the **India–GCC Free Trade Agreement** (**FTA**) to boost trade, investment, and resilient regional value chains.
- ✓ **Connectivity Expansion:** Expedite **India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor**, Chabahar Port and **International North-South Transport Corridor** to strengthen connectivity and logistics resilience.
- ✓ **Energy Diversification:** Diversify crude oil and LNG imports, expand renewable energy cooperation, and strengthen India's strategic petroleum reserves.
- ✓ **Minilateral Diplomacy:** Leverage **I2U2**, **the Abraham Accords**, and **India–GCC partnerships** to deepen technology, connectivity, food, and clean energy cooperation.

{IR – Bilateral Relations} India-Israel Relations

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❖ **Context (IE):** Against a volatile West Asian backdrop, PM Narendra Modi's Israel visit underscores **India's de-hyphenated**, strategic partnership with Israel beyond historical constraints.

- During the visit, PM Modi will address the **Knesset** (**Israel's unicameral national legislature**), enhance parliamentary diplomacy and reaffirm India's multi-dimensional strategic engagement with Israel.

Evolution of India–Israel Relations

- **Ancient Connect (Pre-1947):** Jewish communities found refuge in India, building early **civilisational goodwill** and **mutual respect**.
- **Qualified Recognition (1947–1950):** India opposed the **UN Partition Plan** but recognised Israel in 1950 while backing Palestine.
- **Cold Alignment (1950–1992):** **Pro-Arab** and **pro-Soviet** stance limited ties with Israel; India recognised the PLO in 1975.
- **Diplomatic Normalisation (1992–2014):** Post-Cold War shifts led to full diplomatic ties in 1992, expanding defence and economic cooperation.
- **Strategic Convergence (2014–Present):** **De-hyphenation policy** deepened independent ties with Israel and Palestine, elevating relations to a strategic partnership.

India-Israel Cooperation

- **Defence Cooperation:** Israel remains a top defence supplier, collaborating on **UAVs**, **AWACS**, and **missile systems** like **Barak-8 under Make in India**.
- **Security Synergy:** Close **counter-terror coordination** includes intelligence sharing and critical infrastructure protection, notably strengthened during the Kargil War.
- **Minilateral Framework:** Through I2U2 (**India, Israel, UAE, USA**), both nations cooperate on food security, space, clean energy, and water management.
- **Trade Connectivity:** Economic ties expanded via the India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor, supported by **Adani Ports' 2022 acquisition of Haifa Port**.
- **Innovation Partnership:** The **$40 million I4F fund** and **DRISHTI Programme** promote AI, health-tech, and dual-use innovation, alongside startup collaboration with **iCREATE**.

Challenges in India–Israel Relations

- **Regional Volatility:** **Israel–Iran tensions** and the **Gaza crisis** threaten India's trade flows, energy security, and regional stability interests.
- **Iran Dilemma:** India's **strategic engagement with Iran** contrasts with Israel's perception of Tehran as an existential threat. E.g., Chabahar Port.
- **Arab Balancing:** Strong ties with Arab states post-2020 normalisation face strain amid renewed instability in West Asia.
- **Connectivity Risk:** The **India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor** and related infrastructure projects risk disruption due to escalating conflicts.
- **Nuclear Escalation:** Israeli strikes on Iran could **trigger regional arms races** and **heighten nuclear proliferation concerns**.
- **FTA Stalemate:** **India–Israel** Free Trade Agreement talks launched in 2010 remain unresolved, limiting the full economic potential.

Way Forward in India–Israel Relations

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- ✓ **FTA Acceleration:** Fast-track conclusion of the pending **Free Trade Agreement** to enhance bilateral trade and economic integration.
- ✓ **Sector Diversification:** **Expand cooperation** into defence electronics, fintech, green technologies, and the digital economy.
- ✓ **Strategic Balancing:** Sustain the **de-hyphenation approach** by strengthening Israel ties while prudently engaging Iran, Gulf states, and Palestine.
- ✓ **Co-Development Push:** Scale up **joint defence production** and **innovation** with greater emphasis on technology transfer and indigenous capacity building.

{IR – India-Africa} India-Africa Relations **

- **Context (TH):** India–Africa ties have strengthened since the **2015 India–Africa Forum Summit (IAFS)**, with deeper diplomacy, **over $100 bn trade**, & **greater global cooperation**. This moment offers a chance to review achievements & shape the next phase.

Current Status of India-Africa Ties

- **Trade Milestone:** Bilateral trade exceeded **$100 billion** in **FY 2024–25**, nearly doubling since 2019–2020; this made India the **third-largest trading partner** of Africa.
- **Investment:** India's total investments in Africa have **surpassed $75 billion**, mainly in the telecom, energy, and infrastructure sectors, placing it among **Africa's top five investors**.
- **Diplomatic Expansion:** India has opened several new diplomatic missions since 2018 and supported the African Union's G20 **membership** during India's presidency in 2023.
- **Capacity Building:** Over 40,000 African professionals and students have been trained under the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) programmes.
- **Digital Cooperation:** India's **digital public infrastructure (DPI)** is increasingly being adopted by African nations, such as **Namibia adopting** UPI.
- **Security Cooperation:** Joint initiatives like the **AIKEYME exercise** in **2025** involved navies from **nine African countries**, strengthening maritime security.

Key Opportunities

- **Strategic Partnership:** India supported **AU's G20 inclusion**, strengthening Global South representation.
- **Demographic Leverage:** Africa's growing population and India's economic expansion form **substantial complementary markets** for goods, services, and technology.
- **Mineral Access:** Africa's reserves of critical minerals, such as cobalt and manganese, are vital for India's green energy transition.
- **Digital Blueprint:** India's expertise in digital platforms (UPI, digital ID, education) offers scalable models supporting **Africa's 2020–2030 Digital Transformation Strategy**.

India's Digital Partnership

- **Open-Source DPI:** India offers scalable platforms like **Aadhaar, UPI, CoWIN, and DIKSHA** to strengthen Africa's governance and financial inclusion.
- **Partnership Model:** India promotes transparent, locally owned, and co-created digital ecosystems, avoiding technological dependence and fostering sustainable capacity.

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- **Capacity Building:** Through **ITEC**, the **Pan-African e-Network**, and **IIT Madras Zanzibar**, India advances digital skills and emerging technology expertise.
- **Global South Leadership:** India leverages **IBSA**, **G20**, and the **UN** to promote inclusive digital governance and equitable digital transformation.

Major Challenges

- **Strategic Competition:** China's infrastructure investment and **"chequebook diplomacy"** in Africa can overshadow India's more measured approach.
- **Project Delays:** Bureaucratic constraints and **slow project execution** impede the timely delivery of Indian-funded initiatives.
- **Security Risks:** Persistent instability and terrorism in certain parts of Africa pose a threat to Indian investments and disrupt trade continuity.
- **Connectivity Gaps:** Limited direct air and sea connections hinder efficient logistics, weakening overall economic integration.

Way Forward

- **Summit Revival:** Organising the fourth **India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS-IV)** can revitalise high-level political engagement and articulate a long-term vision roadmap.
- **Digital Corridor:** Joint development of digital platforms leveraging not only UPI, India Stack, but also Africa's digital strengths can benefit the Global South.
- **Debt Crisis Management:** India can promote alternative financing models, such as **debt restructuring**, to avoid long-term economic instability in Africa.
- **Green Partnerships:** Co-investment in renewable energy projects and **EV mobility markets** can align mutual interests in sustainable growth and energy security.
- **Delivery Reform:** Enhancing and **digitalising project monitoring** will ensure the timely delivery of lines of credit (LoCs), linking finance to tangible outcomes.

{IR – India-Central Asia} India-Central Asia Relations

❖ **Context (HT):** The Central Asian Republics, forming **India's extended neighborhood**, lie at the crossroads of **geopolitics**, **energy**, and **trade**. India's engagement with them blends civilizational ties with **development-driven** and **strategic cooperation** to advance regional connectivity and stability.

About the Central Asian Region

- **Location:** Located at the heart of the Eurasian landmass, bounded by Russia (north), China (east), Iran and Afghanistan (south), and the Caspian Sea (west).
- **Members:** Comprises 5 landlocked countries: Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan.

Evolution of India-Central Asia Relations

- **Cultural Linkages (Ancient):** The Silk Road fostered **trade**, Buddhism, and **Sufi cultural** exchanges between India and Central Asia.
- **Diplomatic Outreach (1991):** **Post-USSR breakup**, India established ties with CARs to boost energy and trade access.

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- **Strategic Ties (2009–2012):** India signed **strategic partnerships** and launched the **Connect Central Asia Policy (2012)**.
- **Leadership Diplomacy (2015):** PM Modi's visit to all five CARs strengthened political and security cooperation.
- **Regional Integration (2017–2019):** Joining the **SCO (2017)** and launching the **India–Central Asia Dialogue (2019)** expanded engagement.
- **Development Focus (2021–Present):** Post-U.S. exit from Afghanistan, India launched the **Summit (2022)** and Development Group for regional stability.

Significance of CAR for India

- **Strategic Location:** Central Asia serves as India's Eurasian gateway, vital for regional connectivity, security outreach, and projects like **Chabahar Port** and **INSTC**.
- **Energy Hub:** The region's vast oil and gas reserves boost India's energy security through initiatives like the **TAPI Pipeline** and **Kazakhstan uranium supply**.
- **Resource Access:** Rich in **minerals**, **uranium**, and **rare earths**, Central Asia supports India's clean energy transition and technology manufacturing goals.
- **Security Cooperation:** Partnership through the **SCO** frameworks aids counterterrorism, border stability, and checks extremism and drug trafficking.
- **Trade Connectivity:** The **INSTC corridor** and **Chabahar** route enhance India's Eurasian trade linkages, reducing freight time by **40%** and **logistics costs**.



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Key Challenges

- **Lack of Direct Access:** India does **not share a direct land border** with Central Asia, making trade routes dependent on third countries like Iran, Afghanistan, or Pakistan.
- **Geopolitical Competition:** Central Asia is a region of strategic interest for major powers like China (through its Belt and Road Initiative), Russia, Turkey, and the EU.
- **Low Trade Volume:** Trade between India and Central Asia lies at a measly **US $2 billion** compared to China's US $100 billion trade.
- **Regional Security:** Terrorism, radicalization, drug trafficking, and instability in neighboring Afghanistan.
- **Drug and Arms Trafficking:** The proximity to the Death Crescent (Iran-Pakistan-Afghanistan) makes Central Asia susceptible to drug and arms trafficking, which can fuel instability and corruption.
- **Regulatory Hurdles:** Difficulties in visa issuance, customs clearances, and investment regulations.

Way Forward: Leveraging Emerging Regional Dynamics

- ✓ **Multimodal Connectivity:** Accelerate integration of Chabahar Port and **INSTC** to bypass Pakistan and link with Eurasian markets.
- ✓ **Digital Partnership:** Expand **India–Central Asia Digital Forum** to share **Digital Public Infrastructure** and fintech innovation.
- ✓ **Energy Collaboration:** **Revive the TAPI pipeline** and expand **uranium**, **gas**, and **rare earth imports** from CARs.
- ✓ **Strategic Diplomacy:** **Use the SCO** and **India–Central Asia Dialogue** to ensure balanced engagement amid China–Russia influence.
- ✓ **Development Cooperation:** **Channel $1 billion LoC** for infrastructure, education, and healthcare projects to strengthen goodwill and trust.

{IR – India's Relations with Major Powers & Strategic Regions – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. Discuss the geopolitical significance of India-Indonesia relations and analyze how India can strengthen this partnership to counterbalance Beijing's influence. Highlight the key areas of cooperation that could further India's strategic interests. (250 words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Briefly Introduce the answer about India and Indonesia relations.
- **Body:** Discuss geopolitical significance and key areas of cooperation between India and Indonesia.
- **Conclusion:** Write a way forward by highlighting the need for enhanced partnership.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- **India** and **Indonesia,** two major democracies with shared cultural and historical ties, have deepened relations, especially in the context of **an assertive China in Southeast Asia**. Strengthening this partnership is crucial for **regional stability** and a **balanced** Indo-Pacific.

Key Significance & Areas of Co-operation

Geopolitical Significance

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- **Strategic Gateway:** Indonesia's control of the **Malacca Strait** boosts India's influence and access in the Indo-Pacific, aiding freedom of navigation.
- **Counter to China:** With Indonesia's reliance on **Chinese investments**, India's balanced, sovereignty-respecting approach offers an alternative.
- **Indo-Pacific Security:** **India's Act East Policy** aligns with **Indonesia's Global Maritime Fulcrum**, supporting a rules-based Indo-Pacific.

Key Areas of Cooperation between India and Indonesia

- **Defense:** Naval cooperation through exercises like **GARUDA SHAKTI** under the Strategic Partnership.
- **Economic Growth:** Fast-track CEPA to boost trade, surpassing **USD 38.85 billion**.
- **Blue Economy:** Collaborate on sustainable marine resources and fisheries.
- **Cultural Linkages:** Promote **'RICH' tourism** to strengthen cultural ties.
- **Multilateral Coordination:** Engage in regional platforms like **ASEAN** and **IORA** for joint action.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Tourism Diplomacy:** Launch **joint tourism campaigns** focusing on shared heritage sites to boost cultural ties and economic growth.
- ✓ **Expedite CEPA Negotiations:** Address **trade barriers swiftly** to unlock the full potential of bilateral economic engagement.
- ✓ **Joint Infrastructure Projects:** Collaborate on **sustainable infrastructure projects** in Indonesia to offer alternatives to Chinese BRI investments.
- ✓ **Expand Blue Economy Initiatives:** Establish a **joint task force** on the **blue economy** to develop sustainable projects.
- ✓ **Enhance Regional Cooperation:** Advocate for Indonesia's participation in **global initiatives** like the International Solar Alliance and Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure.

Conclusion

- ✓ By leveraging strategic & cultural ties, India can improve partnership with Indonesia, promoting **shared prosperity** and **regional stability** while counterbalancing China's growing influence in Southeast Asia.

Q. Despite strong strategic convergence, India–Japan economic engagement remains below potential. Analyse the major structural and policy constraints and suggest measures to deepen bilateral trade and investment. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about India-Japan Relations.
- **Body:** Write major structural and policy constraints and suggest measures to deepen bilateral trade and investment.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on a coordinated and cooperative approach to become a "dual engine" of Asia's growth.

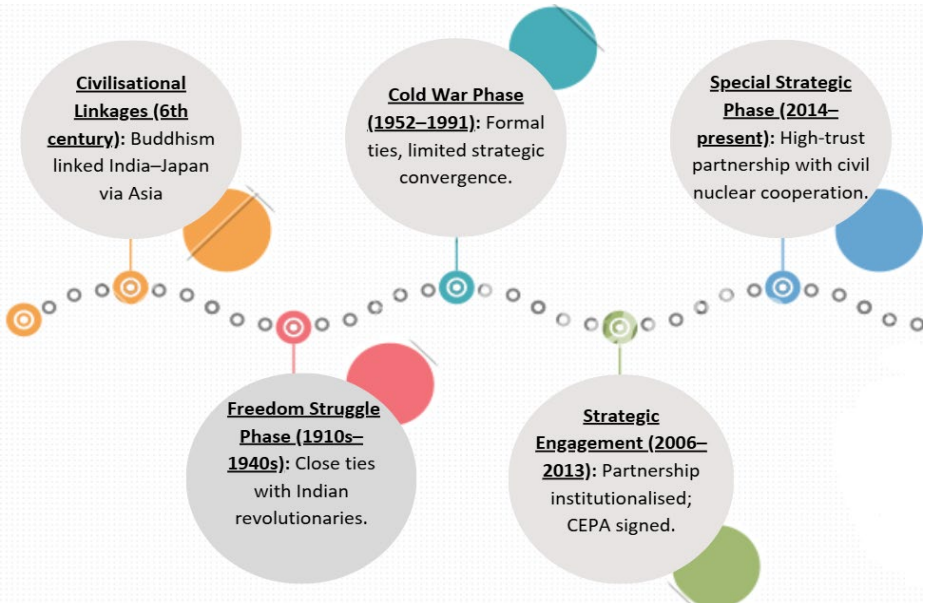
Model Answer (150 Words)

- India and Japan share a strategic partnership inspired by Abe's **"Confluence of Seas,"** linking the Indian and Pacific Oceans; their **18th Strategic Dialogue** was recently held in New Delhi.

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Evolution of India-Japan Relations



Major Structural and Policy Constraints

- **Trade Deficit:** India imports **USD 17.7B** from Japan against **USD 5.15B in exports**, creating a **USD 12.55B gap**.
- **Import Reliance:** Heavy dependence on **Japanese machinery**, **electronics**, and **vehicles** widens the trade imbalance.
- **Market Barriers:** Strict quality norms and certification requirements restrict Indian exports in textiles, food, and IT.
- **FDI Constraints:** **Japanese FDI** (**~USD 43B, 2024**) remains limited due to bureaucratic delays and slow approvals.

Measures to Deepen Bilateral Trade and Investment

✓ **CEPA Expansion:** **Revise the 2011 CEPA** to reduce barriers and include digital and green sectors.
✓ **Trade Facilitation:** Simplify customs and certifications, and boost SME linkages via business councils.
✓ **FDI Promotion:** **Attract Japanese investment** in manufacturing, EVs, and infrastructure (~USD 43 bn, 2024).
✓ **Defence Collaboration:** Fast-track defence deals & expand joint R&D through **2+2 * ACSA frameworks**.

Conclusion

- India–Japan ties can transform from strategic alignment to a strong economic partnership, driving Asia's growth. Together, they can become a **"dual engine"** powering **regional prosperity** and **innovation**.

Q. "Mauritius serves as India's bridge to Africa." In light of this statement, evaluate Mauritius's role in India's Africa outreach strategy and how it can be leveraged to enhance trade, investment, and diplomatic engagement. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

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- **Introduction:** Start the answer by highlighting Mauritius' strategic location and historical ties with India, making it a gateway for India's Africa outreach.
- **Body:** Explain how Mauritius serves as a financial hub (DTAA, CECPA), trade and investment bridge, and diplomatic partner (AU, IORA).
- **Conclusion:** Conclude by suggesting deeper economic integration, maritime security cooperation, and cultural diplomacy to enhance India-Mauritius-Africa ties.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- Mauritius, strategically located in the **Indian Ocean**, acts as a key conduit for India's engagement with Africa. With deep historical, economic, and security ties, it provides India with a **stable entry point** into the continent.

Strategic Importance of Mauritius in India's Africa Outreach

- **Geopolitical Ally:** A trusted partner in the Indo-Pacific and **SAGAR** (**Security and Growth for All in the Region**) vision.
- **Economic Gateway:** Facilitates investment and trade with Africa, leveraging its financial ecosystem and bilingual workforce.
- **Maritime Security Partner:** Critical for anti-piracy, surveillance, & counterterrorism in the Indian Ocean.
- **Diplomatic Support:** Backs India's stance in global forums like the UN and IORA and **supports** India's Chagos Archipelago position.

How Mauritius Can Be Leveraged to Enhance Engagement

- **Strengthening Trade & Investment:** Expand **CECPA** and establish a **local currency settlement system** to ease business transactions.
- **Maritime & Defense Collaboration:** Enhance naval presence and joint exercises to secure sea lanes.
- **Infrastructure Development:** Leverage Mauritius' location for **port connectivity projects** linking Africa and India.
- **Financial Sector Cooperation:** Utilise Mauritius as a **financial hub** for Indian investments in Africa.
- **Cultural & Educational Diplomacy:** Increase scholarships, diaspora engagement, and Hindi promotion for deeper people-to-people ties.

Challenges

- **Chinese Influence:** Rising investments from **China challenge** India's presence.
- **Regulatory Hurdles:** Changes in DTAA have reduced Mauritius' FDI role.
- **Maritime Security Issues:** Piracy, smuggling, and illegal fishing remain concerns.

Conclusion

- Mauritius is a **linchpin in India's Africa strategy**. Strengthening economic, security, and cultural ties will ensure a **mutually beneficial partnership**, reinforcing India's outreach in Africa.

Q. The India–UK Free Trade Agreement marks a new era of post-Brexit economic diplomacy. Discuss the potential benefits for India and highlight key challenges associated with its implementation. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

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- **Introduction:** Write briefly about the India–UK Free Trade Agreement and aiming to double the trade.
- **Body:** Discuss the potential benefits for India and highlight key challenges associated with Free Trade Agreement implementation.
- **Conclusion:** Highlight the importance of implementation challenges to achieve the full potential of Free Trade Agreement.

Model Answer (150 Words)

- The India–UK Free Trade Agreement is a significant advancement in bilateral economic relations, aiming to double trade from **$60 billion** to **$120 billion** by **2030**.

Potential Benefits for India

- **Expanded Market Access:** The UK will remove tariffs on 99% of Indian exports, opening business opportunities, including MSMEs.
- **Support for Labour-Intensive Sectors:** Reduced barriers will boost exports in textiles, leather, and agriculture, driving job growth.
- **Eased Professional Mobility:** Provisions facilitate movement for Indian IT and healthcare professionals.
- **Social Security Benefits:** Under the Double Contribution Convention, temporary workers avoid dual social security contributions for three years.

Implementation Challenges

- **Limited Professional Mobility:** Only **around 100 additional** UK work visas per year may not satisfy India's demand.
- **MSME Impact:** Tariff cuts on UK goods (E.g., cosmetics, medical devices) threaten Indian MSMEs.
- **Regulatory Mismatches:** Differing standards hinder smooth trade flows.
- **Monitoring Gaps:** Absence of robust evaluation mechanisms may delay response to emerging challenges.

Conclusion

- For the FTA to realise its transformative potential, **India must address implementation bottlenecks** such as regulatory mismatches, limited mobility, and MSME vulnerabilities.

Q. The India–France Special Global Strategic Partnership is often projected as a pillar of India's strategic autonomy in a turbulent global order. Evaluate its contributions to India's Indo-Pacific strategy, technological sovereignty, and multilateral diplomacy, while highlighting structural and geopolitical constraints (250 words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a contextual introduction about the India-France relations.
- **Body:** Write the key contribution of India–France Special Global Strategic Partnership, highlight structural and geopolitical constraints, and the way forward.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on sustainable and strategic partnerships to shape a stable multipolar order.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- In a fragmented global order, the **India–France Special Global Strategic Partnership** advances India's strategic autonomy through Indo-Pacific cooperation, technological self-reliance, and coordinated multilateral engagement.

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Key Contributions

- **Maritime & Defence:** Varuna, Shakti, Garuda exercises plus **114 Rafale jets** and **6 Scorpene submarines** strengthen India's Indo-Pacific deterrence.
- **Technological Sovereignty:** **TRISHNA satellite**, **Gaganyaan mission**, Indo-French AI Centre, and FRIND-X foster India's high-tech independence.
- **Economic Partnership:** France is **India's 3rd largest EU trade partner** with **$15.11 bn trade** (2023–24) and **$10.5 bn FDI** (2000–2023).
- **Energy & Climate:** **Jaitapur Nuclear Project (9.9 GW)**, **SMRs/AMRs**, and **ISA solar initiatives** enhance energy security and clean transition.

Key Structural and Geopolitical Constraints

- **Nuclear Liability Laws:** India's **Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act (2010)** slows French investment in Jaitapur.
- **Geopolitical Divergences:** Differences on **Russia–Ukraine conflict** and West Asia policies occasionally strain alignment.
- **Trade Barriers:** EU **SPS measures** and unresolved **India–EU FTA** limit economic potential.
- **IP Concerns:** **Weak Intellectual Property (IP) enforcement** in India affects French tech & luxury investments.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Maritime Synergy:** Expand **joint patrols**, **logistics access**, and **Indo-Pacific trilaterals** to reinforce a rules-based maritime order.
- ✓ **Defence Co-Production:** Fast-track joint design and manufacturing of engines, submarines, and missile systems to strengthen defence self-reliance.
- ✓ **Critical Technologies:** Institutionalise collaboration in **AI**, **quantum**, **space**, and **semiconductors** to secure technological sovereignty.
- ✓ **Global Coordination:** Align strategies in **UN**, **G20**, **EU**, and climate platforms to advance multipolar and reformed global governance.

Conclusion

- The **India–France Special Global Strategic Partnership** stands as a **"pillar of strategic trust,"** enabling both nations to **"act as a force for global good"** in shaping a stable multipolar order.

Q. Examine how India-Australia defence and technology collaboration strengthens regional security and balances China's growing influence in the Indo-Pacific. (150 Words) (10 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the India-Australia defence ties by mentioning the shared goal of safeguarding a free and stable Indo-Pacific.
- **Body:** Write how defence and technology collaboration strengthens regional security and balances China's growing influence in the Indo-Pacific.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on secure, resilient, and rules-based Indo-Pacific aligned with global peace and stability goals.

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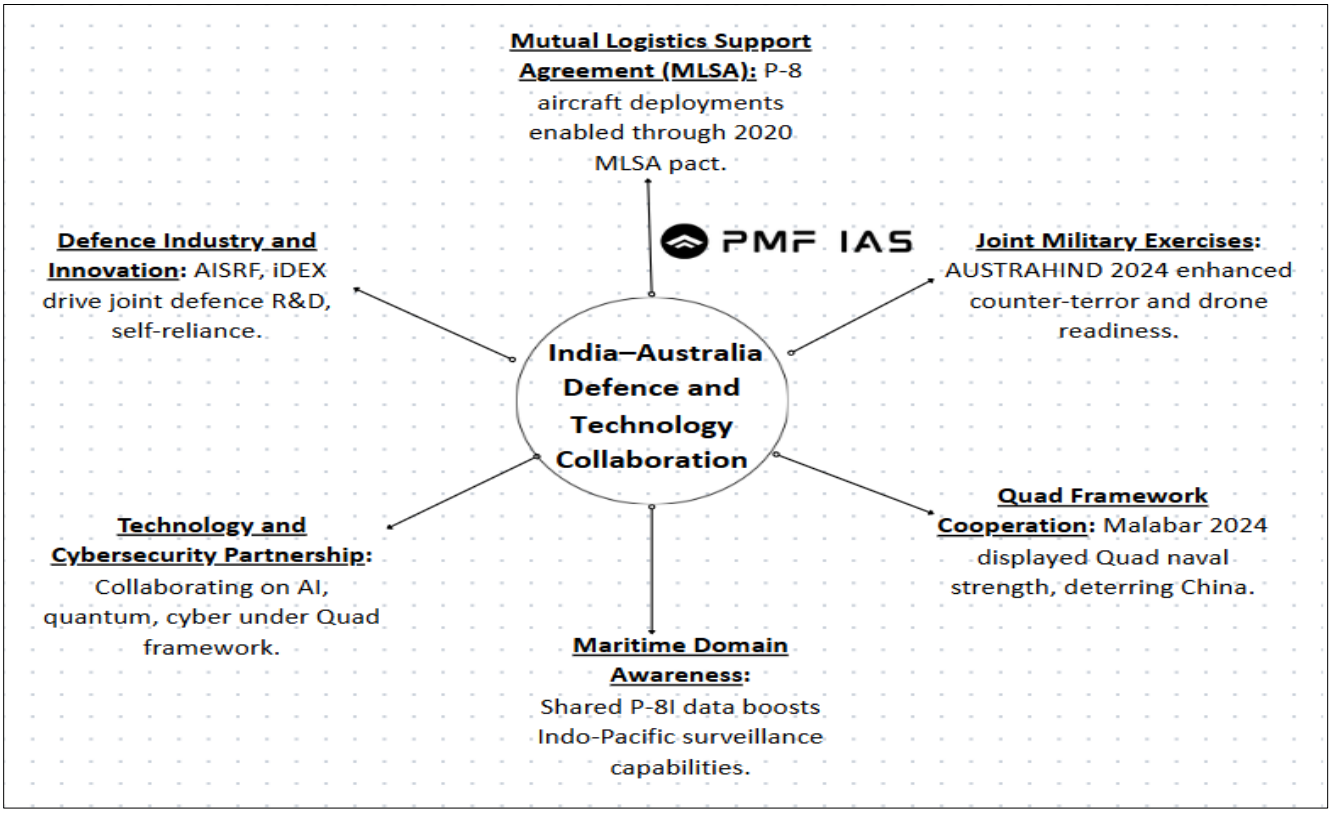
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Model Answer (150 Words)

- India and Australia's deepening **defence-tech partnership** reflects their shared goal of safeguarding a free and stable Indo-Pacific. This growing synergy counters China's assertive moves through strategic, maritime, and technological collaboration.

Defence and Technology Collaboration Strengthens Regional Security

- **Improved Interoperability:** MLSA and joint drills enable swift, coordinated Indo-Pacific operations.
- **Strategic Deterrence:** Combined naval presence counters China's maritime assertiveness effectively.
- **Maritime Route Security:** Real-time surveillance protects key sea lanes and chokepoints.
- **Tech Resilience:** Joint R&D in AI, cyber, and space ensures strategic autonomy.



Balances China's Growing Influence in the Indo-Pacific

- **Strategic Defence Ties:** MLSA and joint drills enhance interoperability and counter China's assertiveness.
- **Quad Synergy:** India–Australia defence ties within the Quad reinforce a rules-based Indo-Pacific.
- **Maritime Surveillance:** Joint tech enables real-time monitoring of strategic sea lanes.
- **Indo-Pacific Outreach:** Collaborative support to Sri Lanka and the Maldives counters China's BRI through regional capacity building and infrastructure.

Conclusion

- India–Australia defence-tech ties counter China's assertiveness while advancing a secure, resilient, and rules-based Indo-Pacific aligned with global peace and stability goals.

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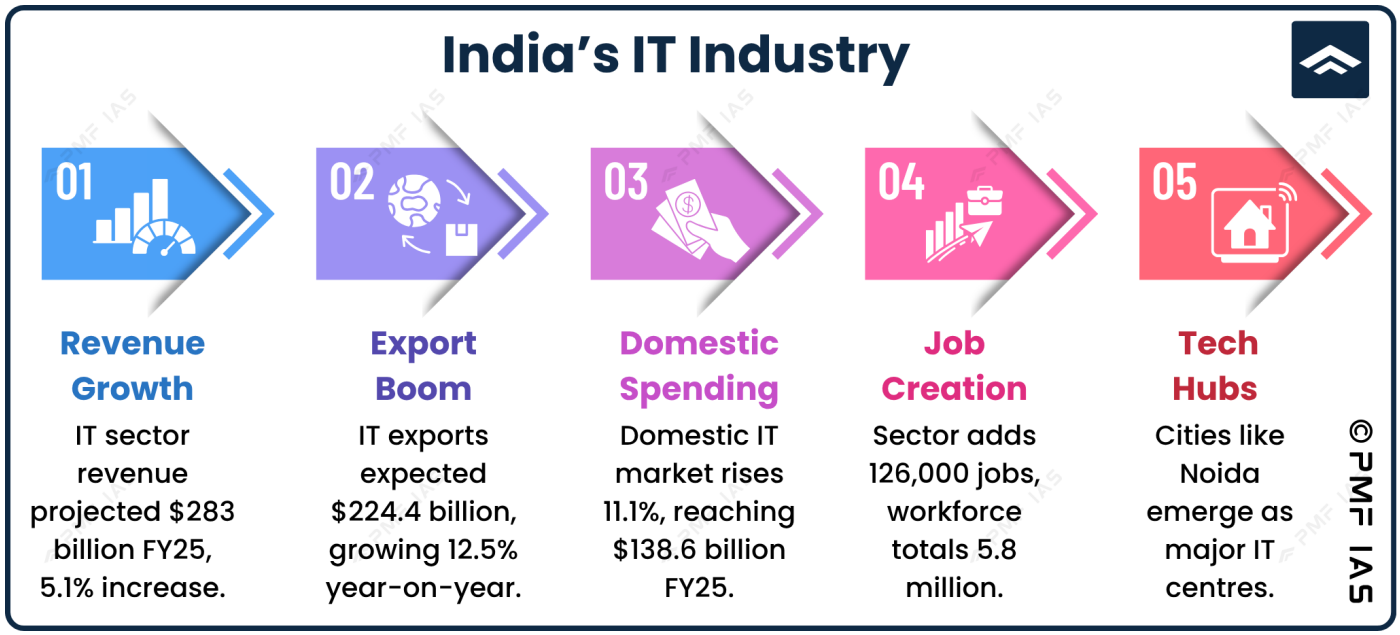
Q. "Brain drain may turn into brain gain if India invests in innovation and research." In the light of rising H-1B visa costs, evaluate this statement with special reference to India's IT industry and global competitiveness (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a contextual introduction by mentioning the rising H-1B visa costs.
- **Body:** Write how brain drain may turn into brain gains, highlight challenges to act as a barrier to this, and suggest a way forward.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on a positive approach and convert this challenge into opportunities to become a brain-gainer and a global tech leader.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- Rising H-1B visa costs hinder **Indian IT migration** but create scope for **talent retention** at home. With a more substantial investment in innovation and R&D, India can turn its **brain drain** into a **brain gain**.



Factors Turning Brain Drain into Brain Gain

- **Rising H-1B Costs:** The new $100,000 surcharge deters migration, hitting Indians who already form **71% of H-1B approvals**.
- **Talent Retention:** **With 70%** of Indian H-1B filings under $100,000 salaries, high fees may keep STEM talent in India.
- **Strategic Leverage:** Reduced U.S. dependence safeguards $250+ billion IT exports and enhances India's **global bargaining power**.
- **Domestic Innovation:** Returning professionals can strengthen India's **$80 billion R&D ecosystem** and drive product innovation.

Challenges

- **IT Export Slowdown:** India's IT export growth may drop **below 4%** in FY26 due to fewer U.S. placements.
- **Project Constraints:** The $100k fee limits short onsite work, reducing **client trust** & **knowledge sharing**.

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- **Humanitarian Disruption:** Policy changes left many workers stranded, **separating families** and exposing **weak consular support**.
- **Wage Pressure:** H-1B workers earn only $66k vs the U.S. median $104k, adding to **wage gap concerns**.

Way Forward

- ✓ **Scale GCCs:** Strengthen offshore delivery & innovation hubs in cities like Bengaluru, Hyderabad, & Pune.
- ✓ **Diversify Mobility:** Utilise **O-1**, **EB-1A**, and **Canada/UK visas** to maintain international exposure.
- ✓ **Boost Domestic R&D:** Encourage **private** and **public investment in AI**, semiconductors, and emerging technologies.

Conclusion

- Rising H-1B costs may disrupt IT exports but can drive **self-reliance**. By redirecting talent into R&D & innovation, India can convert this challenge into a **springboard** for **brain gain** & **global tech leadership**.

Q. To what extent have India-EU relations moved beyond a transactional economic engagement to become a comprehensive strategic partnership in the evolving global order? Examine the key challenges and suggest measures to further strengthen this partnership. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the India–EU relations.
- **Body:** Write how India-EU relations moved beyond a transactional economic engagement to become a comprehensive strategic partnership, mention key challenges, and suggest measures to strengthen this partnership further.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on a comprehensive strategic partnership to strengthen India-EU relations.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- India–EU relations have transformed from a transactional economic engagement into a **strategic partnership** reflected in the **New Strategic EU–India Agenda** and deepening cooperation across trade, technology, security, and global governance.



India–EU Relations: From Trade to Strategic Partnership

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- **Strategic Shift:** India–EU ties evolved from trade-focused relations to a broad strategic partnership under the **2004 Strategic Partnership and Agenda 2025**.
- **Trade Integration:** The **EU is India's largest trading partner** (**$136 bn, 17% of exports**), with FTA, Investment Protection, and GI talks boosting market access and supply chain resilience.
- **Tech-Security:** Collaboration in **AI, semiconductors, clean energy, space**, and joint maritime drills reflects a move from transactional trade to strategic engagement.
- **Global Governance:** EU support for **UNSC membership, WTO, G20, and climate initiatives** positions India as a custodian of a rules-based, multipolar order.

Challenges

- **FTA Deadlock:** Differences over **tariffs**, **IPR**, **agriculture**, and **labour mobility** stall the India–EU Free Trade Agreement.
- **CBAM Impact:** **EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism** increases export costs for Indian steel, cement, and aluminium.
- **Geopolitical Divergences:** India's ties with Russia and the EU's selective engagement with China create strategic misalignments.

Measures to Strengthen This Partnership Further

- ✓ **FTA Conclusion:** **Finalise phased FTA** and **early-harvest deals** to boost trade and market access.
- ✓ **Maritime Cooperation:** **Institutionalise EUNAVFOR** coordination to secure Indian Ocean sea lanes.
- ✓ **Connectivity Linkage:** Integrate Global Gateway with **MAHASAGAR** for sustainable infrastructure & trade.
- ✓ **Tech Partnership:** **Strengthen collaboration** in technology, green energy, and digital governance.

Conclusion

- India–EU ties have evolved into a **comprehensive strategic partnership** across trade, technology, security, and global governance. Resolving FTA and geopolitical challenges can enhance India's influence in a **rules-based, multipolar world**.

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Contemporary Geopolitics & Emerging Challenges

{IR – Israel-Palestine} Israel-Hamas Ceasefire

❖ **Context (IE):** The Israel-Hamas ceasefire offers a chance to reopen the Red Sea trade corridor, disrupted for two years by Houthi attacks. Its effect on India's trade hinges on ensuring sustained security along this vital maritime route.

Background of the Israel-Hamas Conflict

- **Historical Conflict:** Rooted in the splitting of **Palestine** post-WWII, multiple wars followed the **1947 UN plan**. Arab rejected the plan, while Jews declared **Israel's independence** in **1948**.
- **Oslo Accords (1993):** A peace agreement between Israel and the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), which Hamas opposed.
- **Operation Al-Aqsa Storm:** Hamas launched a large-scale attack on Israel, resulting in over 1,200 deaths.
- **Israeli Military Response:** Israel initiated military operations targeting Hamas, leading to over 64,000 casualties in Gaza.

Israel-Hamas Ceasefire: Implications for India

- **Trade Dependence:** Around **90-95% of India's trade** depends on **foreign shipping lines**, making it highly vulnerable to fluctuations in freight rates.
- **Export Vulnerability:** Exporters of **low-margin goods** like textiles, marine products, footwear, and engineering items were hit hardest as **profit margins shrank**.
- **Rising Costs:** Even before the crisis, India **remitted** over **$100 billion annually** as transport service payments, a figure that surged during the crisis.
- **Route Challenges:** The **Cape of Good Hope** route significantly **increased voyage duration** and **insurance costs**, reducing **export competitiveness**.

Israel-Hamas Ceasefire: Geopolitical and Strategic Implications

- **Project Uncertainty:** The **India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC)**, announced at the **2023 G20 Summit**, also faced **uncertainty** due to prolonged regional tensions.
- **Corridor Advantage:** IMEC, comprising an **Eastern Corridor (India-Gulf)** and a **Northern Corridor (Gulf-Europe),** aims to offer a **40% faster alternative** to the Suez Canal route.
- **Stability Impact:** The ceasefire may **revive confidence** in regional infrastructure projects, though **stability in Yemen** and the Red Sea remains critical.

Government Response: Maritime and Shipbuilding Reforms

- **Shipbuilding Boost:** To reduce dependence on foreign carriers, the Centre approved a **₹69,725 crore shipbuilding package**.
- **Key Components Include:**
  - ❖ Extension of the **Shipbuilding Financial Assistance Scheme (SBFAS)** till March 2036 with a corpus of ₹24,736 crore.
  - ❖ Introduction of a **Shipbreaking Credit Note** worth ₹4,001 crore.

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- ❖ Creation of a **National Shipbuilding Mission** to coordinate domestic capacity building.
- **Capacity Expansion:** The package aims to unlock **4.5 million Gross Tonnage capacity**, create **30 lakh jobs**, and attract **₹4.5 lakh crore** investment.

Instability: Risks for India

- ➢ **Maritime Vulnerability:** Red Sea instability threatens shipping lanes, affecting **90–95%** of India's trade (freight & insurance costs rise).
- ➢ **Export Losses:** Low-margin exporters like **textiles**, **marine products**, and **engineering** face reduced competitiveness due to higher transport costs.
- ➢ **Project Uncertainty:** **India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC)** faces delays and investor hesitancy amid regional tensions.
- ➢ **Geopolitical Spillovers:** Fragile peace endangers Indian expatriates in **Israel**, **Palestine**, and **Gulf countries**, challenging diplomatic engagement.

Future Course of Action

- ✓ **Maritime Security:** **Ensure Red Sea corridor safety** to revive India's $100 billion annual trade through foreign shipping lines.
- ✓ **Shipbuilding Expansion:** Implement **₹69,725 crore package** to create 30 lakh jobs and 4.5 million GT domestic capacity.
- ✓ **IMEC Fast-Tracking:** Accelerate **India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor** to offer a 40% faster alternative to the Suez Canal route.
- ✓ **Expatriate Safety:** Strengthen consular support for **8 million Indians** in West Asia and conflict zones.
- ✓ **Trade Risk Management:** Diversify **shipping routes** and **monitor freight/insurance** to protect low-margin exports like textiles and marine products.

{IR – Issues} Gaza Board of Peace **

❖ **Context (DH):** US President **Donald Trump invited PM Narendra Modi** to join a proposed **Gaza "Board of Peace"**, launched as part of the second phase of the **Israel–Hamas ceasefire**.

About the Board of Peace

- **Meaning:** A **proposed international body** aimed at **bringing lasting peace and stability in Gaza** through a new transition framework, beyond short-term ceasefire management.
- **Wider Platform:** It is projected as a platform not just for Gaza but potentially for **wider conflict-resolution**, since it is framed as a **"bold new approach"** to resolve global conflict.

Core Mandates of the Board

- **Governance Transition:** The Board is meant to **guide Gaza's transition** towards stable, lawful governance after the war, reducing institutional vacuum risks.
- **Funding Coordination:** It is expected to coordinate international funding and channel reconstruction resources in an organised manner, rebuilding sustained multi-year financing.

Structure & Membership Design

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- **Heads-Only Top Tier:** The top level is proposed to include **only heads of state**, signalling high political authority in decision-making.
- **Trump-Led Framework:** It is projected as being led under Trump's leadership, indicating a **US-driven architecture** rather than a neutral multilateral body.

Broader Implications for Global Governance

- **UN Dilution:** **Parallel peace mechanisms** like the Gaza Board bypass UN authority, weakening collective security norms. E.g., NATO's Kosovo intervention (1999).
- **Minilateral Rise:** **Ad-hoc coalitions** increasingly substitute for stalled multilateral institutions. E.g., Quad, I2U2.
- **Power Asymmetry:** Dominant states shape governance structures, marginalising weaker stakeholders, as seen in conflict mediation as seen in Afghanistan negotiations.
- **Norm Contestation:** Competing interpretations of **sovereignty**, **intervention**, and **humanitarianism fragment global rules**.
- **Global South Voice:** India's **inclusion mirrors G20's rise** as a platform beyond G7-centric governance.

Strategic Significance of Gaza Engagement for India

- **Energy Security:** West Asia supplies **over 60%** of India's crude oil and hosts **~8 million Indians**; Gaza instability risks energy shocks, remittance disruption, and security spillovers.
- **Maritime Trade:** Conflict threatens critical sea lanes and corridors (Red Sea–Suez), directly impacting India's exports, logistics costs, and Indo-Middle East-Europe connectivity plans.
- **Diplomatic Standing:** The invitation reflects India's growing acceptance as a trusted, non-ideological actor capable of engaging Israel, Palestine, the US, and Arab states simultaneously.
- **Moral Leadership:** Participation allows India to promote humanitarian access, reconstruction-led peace, and a rules-based approach aligned with its **"Vishwabandhu"** and **Global South ethos**.
- **Strategic Balancing:** Engagement must carefully align India's deep Israel ties with its principled support for a **two-state solution** and strong relations with Arab states and Iran.

Key Concerns from India's Perspective

- **UN Legitimacy:** A US-led board bypasses the UN, **weakening rules-based multilateralism** that India consistently supports.
- **Local Ownership:** Excluding legitimate Palestinian representation **risks externally imposed**, unsustainable peace outcomes.
- **Mandate Creep:** Expanding the focus to **"global conflicts"** risks dilution, contrary to India's preference for issue-specific engagement.
- **Military Neutrality:** As it is not a UN mission, **India has ruled out troop deployment**, upholding principled restraint.

Way Forward: Constructive Engagement Strategy on the Gaza Board of Peace

- ✓ **UN Anchoring:** Seek formal **UN linkage to uphold multilateralism**, avoiding precedents like NATO's Kosovo intervention (1999), bypassing the UN.
- ✓ **Local Inclusion:** Advocate for Palestinian representation, **learning from failures** of externally imposed processes such as the Afghanistan peace talks (Doha).

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- ✓ **Clear Mandate:** Restrict focus to Gaza reconstruction, preventing mandate creep seen in open-ended global coalitions like post-2001 "War on Terror".
- ✓ **Civilian Role:** **Contribute via humanitarian aid and reconstruction**, as India did in Afghanistan through infrastructure and capacity-building, not troops.
- ✓ **Balanced Diplomacy:** Use India's simultaneous engagement with Israel, Palestine, Iran, and Gulf states, similar to its **Ukraine diplomacy**, to promote a **two-state solution**.

{IR – Issue} West Asia Conflict *

❖ **Context (IE):** West Asia is vital for India's energy security, trade, diaspora, and strategic connectivity, but **ongoing regional conflicts** threaten these interests & demand careful diplomatic balancing & policy recalibration.

India's Core Interests in West Asia

- **Energy Dependence:** West Asia supplies around **50% of India's crude and LNG** and over **80% of LPG imports** via the Strait of Hormuz.
- **Price Sensitivity:** Every **$10 rise** in crude oil prices increases India's import bill by **$13–14 billion** and pushes domestic inflation upward.
- **Trade Linkages:** India – **Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC)** trade totals about **$178.7 billion**, making the Gulf region a major partner.
- **Indian Diaspora:** **Over 9 million Indians** live & work in West Asia, forming the largest overseas community.
- **Remittance Flow:** Indians in the Gulf remit about **$40 billion annually**, contributing **55%** of total remittances.
- **Strategic Connectivity:** Chabahar Port enables India to access Afghanistan and Central Asia, countering the **China–Pakistan Gwadar corridor**.

Key Military and Strategic Developments in the West Asia Conflict

- **Leadership Targeting:** During **Operation Epic Fury** (**US**) and **Operation Roaring Lion** (**Israel**), coordinated strikes reportedly killed **Ayatollah Ali Khamenei**, aiming to disrupt Iran's central command and leadership structure.
- **Massive Airstrikes:** Around **2,500 bombs were dropped across 131 Iranian cities**, targeting missile launchers, drone facilities, and key economic infrastructure.
- **Asymmetric Retaliation:** Iran responded by striking military bases, energy facilities, transport hubs, and Gulf consulates, expanding the conflict beyond its borders.
- **Strategic Adaptation:** Iran invoked the **Samson option**, decentralising authority across ministries and activating the **Axis of Resistance** to sustain long-term attrition warfare.

⇨ ***Samson Option:*** *A last-resort strategy where a country facing defeat retaliates with massive destruction so that its enemies also suffer severe damage.*

Implications of the West Asia Conflict on the Global Economy

- **Oil Shock:** The Strait of Hormuz carries **~20% of global oil trade**; disruptions can sharply raise global crude prices.

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- **Trade Disruption:** **Around 30%** of global container traffic passes through nearby routes like the Red Sea–Suez Canal corridor, risking supply chain delays.
- **Insurance Spike:** Lloyd's insures about **40% of global marine cargo**, and war-risk premiums have surged for ships entering conflict zones.
- **Inflation Surge:** Oil price spikes during past crises triggered global inflation and economic slowdown. E.g., the 1973 oil shock.

Implications for India

- **Crude Vulnerability:** Nearly **50% of India's crude imports** (**2.5–2.7 million bpd**) pass through the Strait of Hormuz, risking supply disruptions during conflict.
- **Import Cost:** Brent crude crossing $82/barrel increases India's import burden. E.g., even a $1 rise adds $1.8–2 billion annually.
- **Supply Fragility:** India holds about one week of LPG stocks and limited LNG reserves, making it vulnerable to sudden supply shocks.
- **Price Exposure:** With around **88%** oil import dependence, any global price spike directly raises India's fuel costs and energy insecurity.

Strategic and Diplomatic Challenges

- **Iran Partnership:** Iran's discounted oil, security cooperation, and access to Chabahar Port support India's regional strategy and help counterbalance the **China–Pakistan Gwadar corridor**.
- **Regional Balance:** Weakening Iran could **strengthen Pakistan–Turkey strategic ties**, reducing India's influence in West Asia and Central Asia.
- **Diplomatic Perception:** PM Modi's visit to Israel during the conflict created perceptions of India endorsing military escalation.
- **Normative Credibility:** Perceived support for unilateral strikes on Iran raises concerns about India's commitment to the **rules-based international order**.

India's Strategic Measures

- ✓ **Diplomatic Balance:** Adopt a balanced foreign policy safeguarding national interests while upholding global peace and justice, reflecting **Nehru's principled internationalism**.
- ✓ **Energy Diversification:** Expand oil and gas sourcing and strengthen strategic petroleum reserves to reduce dependence on conflict-prone West Asia.
- ✓ **Diaspora Protection:** Enhance consular support, evacuation planning, and labour welfare mechan**isms** for **over 9 million Indians in West Asia**.
- ✓ **Supply Resilience:** Build alternative supply chains for LNG, fertilisers, and critical imports to minimise disruption from regional conflicts.
- ✓ **Global Leadership:** Reinforce India's role in BRICS and **Global South forums** to promote diplomacy, conflict resolution, and multilateral cooperation.

{IR – Issues} US–China Tech Race

- ❖ **Context (IE):** Growing tech competition between the US & China is reshaping global geopolitics, forcing India to balance strategic ties with both powers while strengthening its own technological capabilities.

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US–China Tech Competition

- **Narrow AI Gap:** According to the **Stanford AI Index Report 2026**, China has nearly closed the AI performance gap with the USA, reducing **America's lead to just ~2.7%**.
- **Strategic Technologies:** The competition increasingly revolves around AI, semiconductors, quantum technologies, the rare earths, and advanced manufacturing.
- **G2 Dynamics:** The growing "G2" understanding between the **US & China** raises concerns that major global technology rules may increasingly be shaped bilaterally by the two powers.

India's Strategic Position

- India has expanded cooperation with the US through initiatives such as the TRUST initiative, iCET (**Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology**) and AI Infrastructure Roadmap.
- India–US collaboration focuses on Semiconductors, AI, Critical minerals, Quantum technology and Defence technology.
- Both countries share concerns regarding **China's growing influence in the Indo-Pacific region** and support a rules-based regional order.

Challenges Before India in the US–China Tech Race

- **Limited AI Investment:** India's investment in AI and advanced technologies remains much lower than that of the US and China.
- **Technology Dependence:** India relies heavily on imported semiconductors, advanced chips and digital technologies.
- **Balancing US and China:** India faces the challenge of maintaining strategic ties with the US while managing economic dependence on China.
- **Weak Manufacturing:** Despite "Make in India", "PLI" and "India Semiconductor Mission", India still lacks large-scale semiconductor fabrication and advanced deep-tech manufacturing.
- **Risk of Marginalisation:** A possible US–China G2 understanding could weaken the **China+1** strategy and reduce India's role in shaping global AI and technology governance.

> ⇨ *"**China+1**" is a strategy in which companies reduce their dependence on China by manufacturing or investing in other countries, such as India.*

Way Forward for India in the US–China Tech Race

- ✓ **Deep-Tech Investment:** Increase public-private R&D spending in AI, quantum, and semiconductors. E.g., India's R&D spending remains around **0.7% of GDP**.
- ✓ **Domestic Manufacturing:** Accelerate **semiconductor fabs** and **advanced electronics ecosystems** under the **India Semiconductor Mission**. E.g., Tata semiconductor projects in Gujarat and Assam.
- ✓ **Strategic Balancing:** Deepen technology partnerships with the US, EU, Japan, and Quad while preserving strategic autonomy. E.g., **iCET and TRUST initiatives**.
- ✓ **Global Rule-Shaping:** Lead AI governance, digital public infrastructure, and critical-mineral coalitions. E.g., India's leadership during G20 Digital Economy discussions.

{IR – Issues} Architecture of Contemporary Trade Agreements

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❖ **Context (TH):** Recent trade agreements signed by the **United States** under the **"Agreements on Reciprocal Trade (ART)" framework** signal a structural shift in global trade governance.

⇨ ***Reciprocal Tariffs Policy:*** *A trade policy* ***matching import duties with export tariffs*** *to counter trade imbalances, reduce deficits, pressure foreign governments to lower tariffs, and secure market access.*

Multilateral Trade Foundation

- **Non-Discrimination Principle:** Multilateral trading system, anchored in GATT and the WTO, institutionalised the **Most-Favoured-Nation (MFN) rule**, ensuring equal tariff treatment across member states.
- **Institutional Architecture:** The **WTO (1995)** expanded trade governance beyond goods into services (GATS) & intellectual property (TRIPS) while introducing a **rules-based dispute settlement mechanism**.
- **Developing Country Agency:** **WTO's one-country-one-vote structure** provides smaller economies with bargaining space despite asymmetries in economic power.

Preferential Trade Agreements (PTAs)

- **MFN Exception Logic:** **Article XXIV of GATT** permits FTAs and Customs Unions as controlled deviations from non-discrimination norms.
- **Coverage Discipline:** FTAs must cover **"substantially all trade,"** ensuring such arrangements function as trade-expansion mechanisms rather than protectionist tools.
- **WTO-Plus Expansion:** Modern FTAs increasingly incorporate labour, environmental, and investment provisions beyond WTO disciplines.
- **Transparency:** Mandatory WTO notification allows affected countries to scrutinise PTA provisions.

Erosion of Multilateral Norms in Agreements on Reciprocal Trade (ARTs)

- **Legal Ambiguity:** ARTs operate **outside Article XXIV of GATT** disciplines, weakening their institutional linkage with WTO oversight and established multilateral compliance frameworks.
- **Asymmetric Reciprocity:** ART structures frequently combine **tariff pressure** by dominant economies with expectations of accelerated market access concessions from partner countries.
- **Strategic Conditionalities:** Several ART provisions embed policy-linked obligations connecting trade concessions with national security or economic safeguard measures.
- **Data Governance Concerns:** Digital trade clauses restricting customs duties on electronic transmissions may constrain regulatory autonomy.

Implications of Agreements on Reciprocal Trade

- **Rule Fragmentation:** The rise of ARTs contributes to the diversification of global trade-agreement typologies, complicating coherence within the rules-based multilateral trading system.
- **Multilateral Erosion Risk:** Parallel bilateral frameworks **weaken WTO centrality**, increasing the likelihood of power-driven trade arrangements replacing consensus-based governance structures.
- **Power Asymmetry Expansion:** Smaller economies **face heightened vulnerability** as trade negotiations increasingly reflect geopolitical leverage rather than efficiency-driven economic integration logic.
- **Regulatory Spillover Effects:** One-sided or WTO-plus obligations embedded within ARTs may reshape domestic policy flexibility across tariffs, digital trade, and industrial regulation.

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- **Predictability Challenges:** Increased **heterogeneity of trade frameworks** reduces global trade stability, complicating long-term investment decisions and supply-chain risk assessments.

Way Forward for India

- ✓ **Multilateral Leadership:** Build coalitions with **Global South** economies to push for restoration of the **WTO Appellate Body** and strengthen rule-based dispute settlement.
- ✓ **Digital Trade:** Finalise a **national e-commerce framework** that preserves India's ability to regulate and tax cross-border digital trade.
- ✓ **Trade Diversification:** Accelerate balanced FTA negotiations with the UK, Canada and other **middle-power economies** to diversify export markets.
- ✓ **Manufacturing Competitiveness:** Expand the **Production Linked Incentive** (**PLI**) framework into advanced sectors to strengthen export capacity in emerging global trade

Read More > *USA's Reciprocal Tariffs & Its Impact*

{IR – Issues} Ecocide in Armed Conflict **

❖ **Context (IE): Lebanon accused** the **Israeli military** of committing 'ecocide', alleging a deliberate scorched-earth strategy had decimated its natural environment.

Status of Ecocide in the Indian Legal System

- **Rome Statute:** India has **not signed the Rome Statute** and is therefore not bound by international efforts to make ecocide an ICC crime.
- **Judicial Shift:** The judiciary is shifting from a human-centred to an **ecocentric approach**, treating **nature as a victim** in its own right.
  - ❖ **Fundamental Right:** In **M.K. Ranjitsinh** (2024), the Supreme Court declared that the **right against adverse climate change** is a fundamental right under **Articles 14** and **21**.
- **Peacetime Regulation:** Existing domestic laws focus on **managing industrial impacts during peacetime**, but they lack a legal threshold or definition for penalising ecocide.
- **Legal Framework:** India addresses environmental crime through a **patchwork of environmental statutes**, rather than a unified criminal code.
- **NGT Limitation:** National Green Tribunal (NGT) is **restricted to civil penalties** and lacks the criminal jurisdiction to prosecute ecocide as a major crime.
- **Corporate Penalties:** Current Indian environmental law primarily **imposes fines on companies** rather than criminal prison terms for corporate executives.

About Ecocide

- Ecocide refers to **unlawful** or **wanton acts** committed with **knowledge of a substantial likelihood** of severe, widespread, or long-term **environmental damage**.
- **Criteria:** The legal definition of ecocide identifies four criteria:
  1. **Severity:** Serious adverse changes or damage to the **environment** or to **cultural resources**.
  2. **Widespread Impact:** Damage extends beyond a limited area, crossing borders or affecting entire species or ecosystems.
  3. **Long-term Nature:** Harm is **irreversible** or incapable of natural recovery within a reasonable time.

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4. **Wantonness:** **Reckless disregard for damage**, which is clearly excessive relative to the expected social or economic benefits.

- **Knowledge-Based:** Unlike the **'intent to destroy'** required for genocide, ecocide requires **only knowledge** of a substantial **likelihood of damage**.
- **Legal Standing:** The offence remains **outside ICC jurisdiction** under the **Rome Statute** but is codified in 15 countries, including **Vietnam** (the first country to codify), **Russia**, **Ukraine**, **France**, and **Belgium**.
  - ❖ The Rome Statute recognises **four serious crimes**: (1) **Genocide**, (2) **Crimes against humanity**, (3) **War crimes**, and (4) **Crime of aggression**.
- **Historical Cases:** Examples of ecocide include **Agent Orange** in **Vietnam**, the **Deepwater Horizon oil spill**, and **Amazon deforestation**.

Challenges to Recognise Ecocide as a Formal Law

- ➢ **Vague Definitions:** Terms like "severe" and "widespread" lack the **precise legal clarity** required to satisfy the **principle of legality** in criminal law.
- ➢ **Proving Intent:** Criminal intent is difficult to prove because environmental damage is **typically a by-product of industry** rather than a deliberate aim.
- ➢ **Corporate Liability:** Current international legal frameworks **focus on individual responsibility**, making it difficult to prosecute corporations, typically responsible for large-scale destruction.
- ➢ **National Sovereignty:** International environmental oversight is often seen as an **infringement** on a country's **right to manage its natural resources**.
- ➢ **Causality Challenges:** It is scientifically challenging to establish a direct causal link between a **particular entity's actions** and **complex ecological changes**.

Way Forward on Ecocide Recognition

- ✓ **Legal Codification:** Adopt a clear **international definition of ecocide** under **ICC jurisdiction**, similar to the genocide framework.
- ✓ **Domestic Criminalisation:** Enact **national laws with criminal penalties** for executives, as seen in **France** and **Belgium's ecocide statutes**.
- ✓ **Ecocentric Jurisprudence:** Strengthen the **Supreme Court's Article 21** approach, recognising environmental rights as **fundamental human rights**.
- ✓ **Global Accountability:** Develop an **UN-led monitoring system** to investigate wartime environmental destruction like the **Lebanon conflict allegations**.

Read More> *Ecocide*

{IR – Issues} Climate Refugees *

❖ **Context (IE): Climate-induced displacement** is becoming a key **humanitarian challenge** of the 21st century. In 2024 alone, over **8.24 lakh people** were displaced by extreme weather events, yet climate refugees remain legally unrecognised, globally unprotected, and largely overlooked in policy frameworks.

Current Facts and Meaning

- **Meaning:** The term "climate refugee" typically refers to people forced to migrate due to ecological threats such as droughts, sea-level rise, or extreme weather events. However, this label **lacks formal legal recognition.**

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- ❖ The **UN High Commissioner for Refugees** avoids the term "climate refugee," instead using "persons displaced due to climate change and disasters."

- **Global Level:**
  - ❖ **Disaster Displacement:** Over **32.6 million** people were displaced in 2022 alone due to natural disasters.
  - ❖ **Future Climate Migration Risk:** Over **1.2 billion** people could be displaced due to climate-related factors globally by 2050.
- **India:**
  - ❖ **Climate-Refugees:** Over **3.6 million** Indians were displaced by climate-related disasters (IDMC).
  - ❖ **Sundarbans Delta:** Increasing **salinity** & **sea-level rise** have led to migration to cities like **Kolkata**.
  - ❖ **Assam and Bihar:** Recurrent floods displace **millions annually**.

Socio-Economic Impact of Climate Refugees

- **Rise in Urban Informal Labour:** Climate-displaced populations often migrate to cities, entering low-paying informal sectors. E.g., over **3.6 million Indians** were displaced.
- **Collapse of Climate-Sensitive Livelihoods:** Rising temperatures & erratic rainfall disrupt farming, fishing, & livestock rearing. E.g., Over **50% of workforce** depends on agriculture (Economic Survey 2023).
- **Gendered Impact on Women and Children:** Displaced women face heightened risks of trafficking, child marriage, and dropouts. E.g., climate-displaced women are **four times vulnerable** (UN Women, 2022).
- **Food and Economic Insecurity:** Loss of income sources deepens poverty and food shortages in displaced communities.
- **Erosion of Social and Cultural Identity:** Forced displacement breaks **community bonds** and disrupts **traditional knowledge systems**.

Legal Ambiguities and Gaps in Protection

- **No Protection under Refugee Convention:** The **1951 Refugee Convention** only recognises persecution, war, or violence as valid grounds for asylum not environmental or climate-induced displacement.
  - ❖ E.g., in 2015, **New Zealand** rejected an asylum plea from a **Kiribati** man fleeing sea-level rise, citing no legal grounds under the Convention.
- **Ad Hoc Humanitarianism:** Access to protection often depends on discretionary, **case-by-case humanitarian grounds** rather than enforceable legal entitlements.
- **Soft Law Tools:** Initiatives like the **Nansen Initiative** and **Platform on Disaster Displacement** foster voluntary cooperation but lack **binding legal force** or enforcement mechanisms.
- **Legal Ambiguity:** Without formal refugee status, climate migrants often fall through the gaps of both humanitarian relief frameworks and immigration law.
- **Voluntary vs. Forced Migration:** Slow-onset climate events blur the boundary between voluntary and forced migration, weakening legal claims for protection.
- **State as Victim:** Climate-affected states themselves may be incapacitated, unable to ensure citizen protection or support legal avenues for asylum.

Way Forward

✓ **Legal Recognition:** Urgently define and recognise climate refugees under international law. Broaden the **1951 Refugee Convention** or develop a separate international protocol.

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- ✓ **Regional Cooperation:** Strengthen platforms like **SAARC**, **ASEAN**, and **African Union** to develop regional mobility pacts and relocation protocols.
- ✓ **Human Rights Integration:** Embed climate displacement under the **right to life** and **right to adequate housing** in global treaties. Use the **International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR)** and other covenants to ensure legal protections.
- ✓ **Proactive Adaptation:** Invest in **climate-resilient infrastructure**, **livelihood diversification** & **early warning systems**.
- ✓ **Global Funding and Support:** Developed countries must honour climate finance commitments & establish a **Global Climate Displacement Fund** to support relocation, resettlement, and compensation.
- ✓ **India's Role:** As a regional power, India must integrate displacement into its **National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC)**. Enhance **border management** and **humanitarian protocols** for cross-border climate migrants.

{IR – Issues} Suez Crisis (1956): Early Challenge to US-European Unity

❖ **Context (WIONEWS): The 1956 Suez Crisis** marked a major early test of US-European unity in the post-World War II era. It exposed deep differences in strategic priorities between long-standing allies.

Historical Background

- **Canal Importance:** Constructed in **1869**, the Suez Canal links the **Mediterranean and Red Seas**, shortening trade routes between Europe and Asia.
- **Colonial Control:** For Britain and France, the canal ensured **access to colonies and oil**, while for Egypt it symbolized **foreign domination**.
- **Postwar Geopolitics:** After WWII, **US-European relations** were tested by strategic disagreements, highlighting diverging global priorities.
- **Unity Challenge:** The Suez Crisis was an **early post-war test** of US-European unity amid rising American global influence.

Events Leading to the Suez Crisis

- **Canal Nationalization:** On **26 July 1956**, Egypt nationalized the **Suez Canal**, previously controlled by British and French interests, to fund the **Aswan High Dam**.
- **Arab Nationalism:** President **Nasser emerged as a symbol** of Arab nationalism, inspiring anti-colonial movements across the **Middle East and Africa**.
- **Strategic Interests:** Britain and France sought to protect **trade routes, oil supply, and geopolitical influence**, all threatened by Egypt's nationalization.
- **Cold War Dynamics:** The crisis unfolded amid **US-USSR rivalry**, with Nasser balancing aid and negotiations to maintain Egypt's sovereignty and regional influence.

US Diplomacy and European Decline

- **Strategic Fear:** The US worried about war between its allies and Egypt and the risk of Soviet involvement.
- **Peace Effort:** Washington tried to solve the crisis through talks and proposed the **Suez Canal Users Association**.
- **Force Use:** Britain, France, and Israel **secretly used military action** to regain control of the canal.

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- **US Pressure:** The US opposed its allies, used UN support and economic pressure to stop the fighting.
- **Power Shift:** The **forced withdrawal** showed the fall of European power and the rise of the US as a global leader.

Global Consequences of the Suez Crisis

- **Colonial Decline:** Britain and France **lost influence in the Middle East**, signaling the end of traditional colonial dominance.
- **Arab Nationalism:** President Nasser emerged as a **regional hero**, inspiring nationalist movements across the Middle East.
- **Non-Alignment:** Egypt's stance encouraged countries to pursue neutrality, paving the way for the **1961** Non-Aligned Movement.
- **Cold War:** The US distanced itself from allies while the USSR expanded its influence in the Middle East.
- **UN Intervention:** **First UN peacekeeping force (UNEF) deployed**, setting a precedent for international conflict resolution.
- **Political Fallout:** British PM Eden resigned, and France prioritised **European integration over colonial ambitions**.

Long-Term Legacy and Strategic Lessons of the Suez Crisis

✓ **Gunboat End:** Military force alone failed as Britain and France withdrew during the Suez Crisis.

⇨ ***Gunboat diplomacy*** *refers to the use of military force or the display of naval power by a nation to assert its political interests and influence foreign policies, often in a coercive or aggressive manner.*

✓ **Decolonisation Boost:** Egypt's action **inspired independence movements**. E.g., Ghana (1957) and Sudan (1956).

✓ **Cold War Shift:** US and USSR **expanded influence**. E.g., the US gained Arab credibility & the USSR aided Egypt.

✓ **UN Precedent:** UNEF deployment set a model for peacekeeping, used later in Congo (1960).

{IR – Contemporary Geopolitics & Emerging Challenges – Pathfinder for Mains}

Q. The Suez Crisis marked a decisive rupture in the global balance of power, signalling the decline of European imperial dominance and the ascendancy of superpower politics. Critically evaluate its relevance for contemporary power shifts. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief introduction about the Suez Crisis.
- **Body:** Write about the decline of European imperial dominance and the ascendancy of superpower politics, and mention its relevance for contemporary power shifts.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on the shift from European colonial dominance to US-led global leadership to established multilateral diplomacy.

Model Answer (250 Words)

- The Suez Crisis of 1956 occurred when **Egypt nationalised the Suez Canal**, challenging British and French control. It marked a shift in global power, reducing European influence and increasing the involvement of superpowers.

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Decline of European Power

- **Colonial Withdrawal:** Britain and France lost influence in the Middle East, revealing **military and diplomatic limitations**. E.g., British-French forces withdrew from Egypt.
- **Political Fallout:** British PM Anthony Eden resigned, and France prioritised **European integration over overseas ambitions**. E.g., France shifted toward Europe.
- **Symbolic Loss:** Highlighted the inability of European powers to unilaterally maintain global dominance. E.g., Europeans exposed declining clout.

Rise of Superpower Politics and Multilateral Diplomacy

- **US Ascendancy:** Washington opposed allies' **military action**, using economic pressure and UN support to enforce withdrawal. E.g., the US threatened economic sanctions.
- **USSR Influence:** Supported Egypt, signalling the Soviet Union's strategic role in the Middle East. E.g., USSR deployed warships to Egypt.
- **UN Peacekeeping:** Deployment of the United Nations Emergency Force (UNEF) set a precedent for **multilateral conflict resolution**. E.g., UNEF deployed to Congo in 1960.
- **Lesson:** Military force alone became insufficient; **diplomacy**, **economic leverage**, and **institutions** gained primacy.

Relevance for Contemporary Power Shifts

- **Multipolarity:** Global power is **no longer concentrated**; the US, China, India, and regional actors shape geopolitics. E.g., India balances the US-China.
- **Regional Assertion:** Smaller states increasingly **assert strategic autonomy**, akin to Egypt's defiance in 1956. E.g., Iran-Turkey assert policies.
- **Limits of Traditional Powers:** **European influence is reduced** in global security and energy politics, echoing post-Suez decline. E.g., the EU is limited to the Middle East.
- **Diplomatic Leverage:** **Sanctions**, **global opinion**, and **international forums** now often determine outcomes over direct military intervention. E.g., Russia faced global sanctions.

Conclusion

- The Suez Crisis showed the **"limits of imperial power"** and the **rise of superpowers**; today, **diplomacy, strategic autonomy, and regional influence** still shape global outcomes more than military force.

Q. Examine how climate change is driving forced migration in India and suggest measures to address the challenge of climate refugees. (250 Words) (15 Marks)

Approach

- **Introduction:** Write a brief definition of climate refugees.
- **Body:** Write how climate change drivers forced migration in India, challenge of climate refugees and suggest measures.
- **Conclusion:** Emphasis on human rights and legitimate security mainly focuses on the triple gap (legal, institutional, and financial) that defines the climate refugee dilemma.

Model Answer (250 Words)

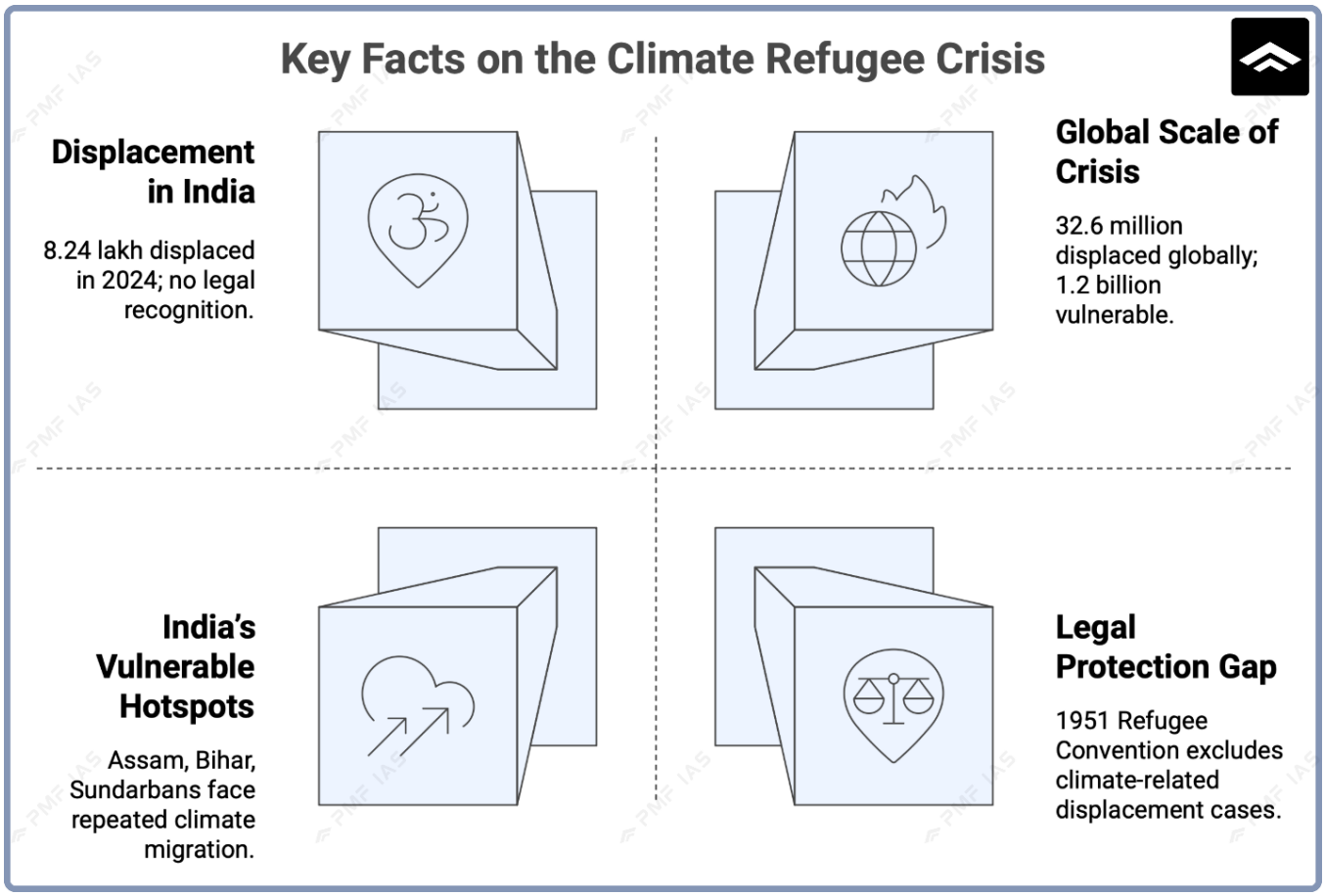
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- **'Climate refugees'** refer to those individuals or communities who are forced to migrate and seek refuge elsewhere due to ecological threats caused by climate change.

Climate Change Drives Forced Migration in India

- **Coastal Erosion:** Over **33.6%** of India's **7,500 km** coastline is eroding, leading to forced migration.
- **Extreme Weather Events:** India is experiencing an increase in cyclones, floods, and droughts. E.g., **Cyclone Amphan displaced** millions in eastern India.
- **Agricultural Stress:** Floods in **Assam** and **Bihar**, and drought in Bundelkhand, cause forced migration.
- **Water Scarcity:** **Groundwater depletion** in arid & semi-arid regions promotes migration towards cities.



Challenges Posed by Climate Refugees

- **Lack of Legal Recognition:** India lacks a specific **legal category** for "climate refugees," making rehabilitation difficult.
- **Urban Infrastructure Stress:** Sudden migration places a burden on housing, water, sanitation, and employment systems.
- **Social Tensions:** The influx of migrants may lead to **local unrest**, especially in already fragile regions.
- **Gender and Child Vulnerability:** Displaced women and children face higher risks of **trafficking** and **exploitation**.

Measures

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- ✓ **Policy and Legal Frameworks:** Recognise climate refugees in disaster management and rehabilitation policies, such as the **National Climate Migration Policy**.
- ✓ **Climate-Resilient Infrastructure:** Construct **embankments**, **cyclone shelters**, and **flood-resistant** housing.
- ✓ **Urban Planning and Rehabilitation:** Integrate climate migrants in **urban planning** through inclusive housing, **skill training**, and public services in smart cities.
- ✓ **Livelihood Diversification and Adaptation:** Promote **climate-smart agriculture**, **agroforestry**, and **water conservation** in rural areas.

Conclusion

- Addressing this silent yet deepening crisis demands a **dual lens**; one that upholds both **human rights** and **legitimate security**, Above all, we must confront the **triple gap** (**legal**, **institutional**, and **financial)** that defines the **climate refugee dilemma**.

-------- End of Chapter --------

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